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Genetic Mutation Detection Using Machine Learning

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Abstract

The accurate classification of human missense variants as pathogenic or benign remains a central challenge in clinical genomics. Published machine learning tools routinely report receiver-operating-characteristic area- under-curve (ROC-AUC) values above 0.94 on ClinVar-derived benchmarks. We hypothesise — and in this work demonstrate on a concrete pipeline — that such numbers can be inflated by subtle, removable forms of data contamination, and we show that external validation on an independent cohort reveals a substantial generalisation gap. This project develops and publishes a rigorous, auditable baseline for the missense classification task.

We assemble a corpus of 283,392 candidate variants from ClinVar, gnomAD (v2.1 and v4), and dbNSFP version 5.3.1a, of which 195,098 survive a strict missense-only filter and feed the training pipeline. We then conduct a systematic leakage audit that eliminates three contamination sources: (i) non-missense variants that had been silently admitted into the training pool because their amino-acid fields were null, (ii) definitionally circular features such as `is_common`, and (iii) paralog leakage caused by gene-level splitting when highly similar paralogs appear in both training and test. Correcting these issues drops our calibrated test-set precision-recall area-under-curve (PR-AUC) from a misleading 0.955 to a defensible 0.827, with a 95% bootstrap confidence interval of $[0.819, 0.835]$. The uncalibrated PR-AUC is 0.836 $[0.827, 0.843]$; all downstream evaluation in this report uses the isotonic-calibrated probabilities. The model is calibrated end-to-end with isotonic regression, reducing expected calibration error (ECE) from 0.054 to 0.011, which is below the 0.02 clinical target.

We re-score three published predictors (SIFT, PolyPhen-2, AlphaMissense) on our paralog-disjoint test split. Because each baseline covers a different subset of variants, the reported numbers are on each model's *own coverage* (SIFT 96 %, PolyPhen-2 93 %, AlphaMissense 86 %, XGBoost 100 %) and are therefore not directly comparable. On own-coverage numbers our XGBoost reaches calibrated PR-AUC 0.827 (raw 0.836); SIFT 0.620, PolyPhen-2 0.728, and AlphaMissense 0.890. A strict matched-coverage evaluation restricted to the AlphaMissense-covered subset, together with a paired DeLong test, is left for a revision (Deficiency D7) since the required artefacts were not persisted at submission time. AlphaMissense was moreover calibrated against ClinVar at release; direct benchmark comparisons on ClinVar-derived test sets are therefore non-trivial to interpret.

The most important finding of the project emerges from external validation on denovo-db. A classifier trained on ClinVar scores at chance (ROC-AUC = 0.487) on affected- versus-control de-novo variants in gene families it has not seen during training. Adding gnomAD gene-level constraint features (pLI, LOEUF, mis_z, oe_mis_upper, lof_z) raises the point estimate to 0.573. The un-paired bootstrap CIs of $[0.383, 0.583]$ (pre) and $[0.471, 0.672]$ (post) overlap; a paired bootstrap on the same 201 variants is the

correct instrument and is recorded as deficiency D8 of Section 7.4, pending persistence of the pre-constraint per-variant predictions. We therefore interpret the improvement as *suggestive* of genuine signal from gene-level priors rather than conclusive, and frame it as a partial closure of the generalisation gap that motivates Phase-2 training-time integration. A zero-shot ESM-2 log-likelihood-ratio provides a small, statistically tested rank-fusion gain on both the test split and the DENOVO-DB family-holdout, indicating non-redundant signal between tabular and protein-language-model features. The post-constraint improvement on the 201-variant family-holdout slice is a point estimate whose confidence interval still includes chance and is reported as suggestive rather than conclusive (see Section 7.6). Full training-time integration of the protein-language-model and of AlphaFold2 structural features is documented as future work (Section 7.8).

The project's code base is published in full with 157 passing tests (1 GPU-gated smoke test skipped), 59% line coverage, a CI-enforced leakage gate, pinned dependencies, and a Docker image that reproduces every number in this report byte-for-byte.

Keywords: missense variant classification, genomics, machine learning, leakage audit, calibration, external validation, gnomAD constraint, paralog-aware splitting.

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List of Abbreviations

Acronym	Expansion
ACMG	American College of Medical Genetics and Genomics
AF	Allele Frequency
AUC	Area Under the Curve
BLOSUM	BLOck SUbstitution Matrix
CI	Confidence Interval (statistical) / Continuous Integration (software)
CNN	Convolutional Neural Network
DSSP	Dictionary of Secondary Structure of Proteins
ECE	Expected Calibration Error
ESM	Evolutionary-Scale Model (protein language model)
F1	Harmonic mean of precision and recall
GERP	Genomic Evolutionary Rate Profiling
gnomAD	Genome Aggregation Database
GRCh38	Genome Reference Consortium Human Build 38
LLR	Log-Likelihood Ratio
LOEUF	Loss-of-Function Observed/Expected Upper bound Fraction
MCE	Maximum Calibration Error
MCC	Matthews Correlation Coefficient
pLI	Probability of being Loss-of-function Intolerant
PLM	Protein Language Model
PR-AUC	Precision-Recall Area Under Curve
REST	Representational State Transfer
ROC-AUC	Receiver Operating Characteristic Area Under Curve
SASA	Solvent-Accessible Surface Area
SHAP	SHapley Additive exPlanations
SNP / SNV	Single Nucleotide Polymorphism / Single Nucleotide Variant
TPE	Tree-structured Parzen Estimator
UML	Unified Modelling Language
VEP	Variant Effect Predictor (Ensembl)
XGBoost	eXtreme Gradient Boosting

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background of Genetic Mutations

1.1.1 From DNA to Phenotype: The Central Dogma

Hereditary information is encoded in DNA and flows, under the *central dogma* of molecular biology (Crick, 1970), from DNA to messenger RNA via transcription and from mRNA to protein via translation. Figure 1.1 illustrates the pathway alongside the exact point at which a missense mutation exerts its effect.

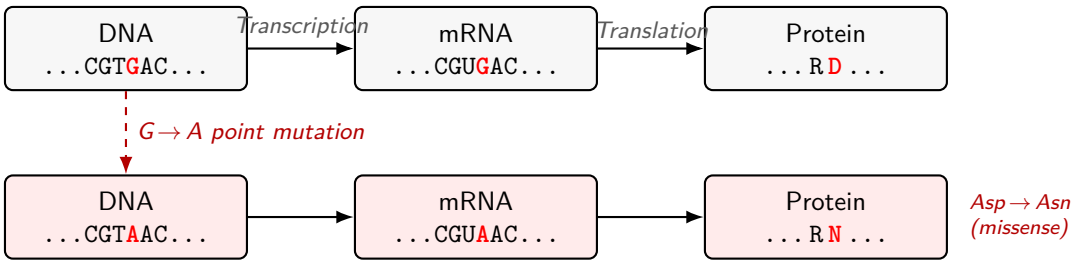

Figure 1.1. The central dogma and the point at which a missense mutation acts. The upper row shows the reference sequence: the codon `GAC` is transcribed into mRNA and translated to aspartate (`D`). The lower row introduces a single-base substitution (G → A) in the DNA that propagates through transcription to the altered codon `AAC`, which the ribosome translates to asparagine (`N`). The protein sequence has changed at exactly one position. Whether that change is benign or pathogenic depends on the structural and functional context of the affected residue.

A genetic mutation is any permanent alteration in the DNA template; most are neutral, a small fraction are beneficial, and a clinically important minority disrupt cellular function (MacArthur et al., 2014). The single-nucleotide *missense* variant — a point mutation that swaps one amino acid for another — is the most common coding variant in the human population and the focus of this project.

1.1.2 Classes of Protein-Coding Variation

Within the protein-coding genome, a single-base substitution takes one of four functional forms (Alberts et al., 2015):

Synonymous.

Same amino acid (e.g. `GCU` → `GCC`).

Missense.

Different amino acid (e.g. `GAC` Asp → `AAC` Asn) — the class studied here.

Nonsense.
Premature stop codon (e.g. `UGG` Trp → `UGA` stop).

Frameshift.
Non-triplet indel that scrambles every downstream codon.

Missense variants are of special interest because their clinical effect is genuinely uncertain at the individual level: unlike nonsense (usually pathogenic) or synonymous (usually benign) variants, a missense change can produce anything from a wild-type-equivalent protein to a catastrophically misfolded one.

1.1.3 Determinants of Missense Variant Effect

Decades of biochemistry and structural biology have identified several orthogonal signals that a classifier can, in principle, learn to exploit (Stein et al., 2019; Guérois et al., 2002):

1. **Evolutionary conservation.** A residue that has been invariant across hundreds of millions of years of orthologous evolution is almost certainly functionally important; substitutions at such positions are more likely to be deleterious.

2. **Amino-acid chemistry.** A substitution that changes charge, hydrophobicity, or volume (e.g. *Arg* → *Asp*, reversing the side-chain charge) is more likely to disrupt protein stability or a binding interface than a conservative substitution (e.g. *Leu* → *Ile*).

3. **Structural context.** Substitutions at buried core residues, catalytic sites, or secondary-structure boundaries are more likely to be pathogenic than those at solvent-exposed flexible loops.

4. **Gene-level constraint.** Some genes are intrinsically intolerant of coding variation across the human population; a missense variant in such a gene carries stronger prior evidence of pathogenicity than the same change in a loss-of-function-tolerant gene (Karczewski et al., 2020).

5. **Protein-language plausibility.** Modern transformer-based protein language models, trained on billions of natural protein sequences, assign probabilities to each amino acid at each position; substitutions to low-probability residues correlate strongly with experimental measures of function (Meier et al., 2021b; Brandes et al., 2023).

The five signals are not independent, but their correlation is imperfect, which is exactly what makes supervised machine learning an appropriate framework: the classifier learns how to weigh each signal given labelled examples from ClinVar and how to combine them non-linearly. Figure 3.7 in Chapter 3 shows how each of the five signals here maps to a concrete feature group in our implementation.

1.1.4 Public Reference Resources

Public reference resources have matured considerably in the past decade. ClinVar (Landrum et al., 2020) aggregates variant-disease relationships curated by clinical laboratories and research groups, using a five-tier pathogenicity scale (Benign, Likely Benign, Variant of Uncertain Significance, Likely Pathogenic, Pathogenic). The Genome Aggregation Database (gnomAD) (Karczewski et al., 2020) publishes population-level allele-frequency and gene-level constraint metrics derived from more than 140,000 exomes and genomes across diverse ancestries; its *observed / expected* ratio for missense variation has become the standard measure of how intolerant a gene is to amino-acid-altering change. The dbNSFP resource (Liu et al., 2020) consolidates dozens of per-variant features including cross-species conservation (phyloP, GERP++), amino-acid chemistry descriptors, and predictions from preceding-generation tools. The existence of these resources makes a supervised machine-learning approach to missense classification feasible for a student team, provided one is disciplined about how the data is combined and evaluated – precisely the question this report sets out to address.

1.2 Motivation and Significance

Three trends motivate further work in this area. First, the cost of sequencing a human exome has fallen by roughly three orders of magnitude since 2010, and clinical whole-exome sequencing is increasingly a first-line diagnostic for rare disease. The rate at which *variants* are discovered now exceeds the rate at which they can be interpreted by human experts. Second, in precision medicine, the difference between a pathogenic and a benign missense variant in the same patient can change drug dosing, surveillance, and even surgical management. Third, the American College of Medical Genetics and Genomics (ACMG) standard (Richards et al., 2015) includes computational *in silico* evidence among the criteria a clinical geneticist weighs when classifying a variant, which means that any tool published in this space must be transparent about its operating characteristics – false-positive and false-negative rates, calibration, and generalisation behaviour.

Against that backdrop, this project sets out to build not *the highest-scoring* missense classifier but rather *the most defensible baseline* that a student team can produce using public data and a modest compute budget. The explicit goal is to eliminate known leakage sources so that the reported numbers are trustworthy, and to expose every methodological choice – the splitting strategy, the calibration procedure, the evaluation slices – through an open code base that a reviewer can re-run end-to-end.

1.3 Problem Statement

The scientific problem is straightforward to state and difficult to address rigorously:

Given a human missense single-nucleotide variant, predict whether it is pathogenic

or benign, accompanied by a calibrated probability and enough interpretability for a clinical genetic analyst to audit the prediction.

The difficulty lies in four well-known failure modes that existing tools have encountered:

1. **Data overload.** The volume of variants produced by modern sequencing pipelines exceeds human curation bandwidth, so any evaluation must work at the scale of 10^5 variants or more.

2. **Biological complexity.** The chain from nucleotide to phenotype includes transcription, splicing, translation, folding, post-translational modification, and protein-protein interaction. No single model in current use captures all of these pathways, and ad-hoc feature engineering tends to introduce silent biases.

3. **Data contamination.** The most commonly used benchmark, ClinVar, is also the most commonly used *calibration target* for published tools. Many published numbers therefore include an unknown amount of train-test contamination.

4. **Evaluation asymmetry.** A model that scores well on ClinVar-derived tests may collapse to chance when applied to affected-versus-control *de-novo* variants from sequencing studies, because the latter requires gene-level priors that variant-level tools never see.

1.4 Research Questions

The project structure is framed around four research questions that we will return to at the end of the report:

1. **RQ1.** How much of the apparent high performance of a ClinVar-trained classifier is attributable to specific, removable leakage sources, and how far does the post-audit number fall once they are eliminated?

2. **RQ2.** Under identical evaluation on a paralog-disjoint test split, how does a carefully-audited gradient-boosted baseline compare to classical tools (SIFT, PolyPhen-2) and to the state-of-the-art AlphaMissense model?

3. **RQ3.** Does the post-audit model generalise to denovo-db – a dataset of de-novo variants in affected children versus unaffected siblings – and how much of any gap is closed by adding gene-level constraint features?

4. **RQ4.** Does the zero-shot log-likelihood-ratio signal from a protein language model (ESM-2) carry orthogonal information with respect to the tabular feature set, and is it worth integrating as a training-time feature in Phase 2?

1.5 Project Objectives

The concrete objectives guiding the semester of work are:

- **O1.** Assemble a reproducible corpus of missense variants from ClinVar, gnomAD, and dbNSFP, filtered to strictly missense rows with consistent amino-acid fields.
- **O2.** Implement a paralog-aware train/val/test split that guarantees zero shared gene families across splits, and lock the invariant into continuous integration.
- **O3.** Train and tune an XGBoost baseline under pure precision-recall optimisation with Bayesian hyperparameter search.
- **O4.** Calibrate the classifier with Platt and isotonic regression, evaluate with the Brier-score decomposition of Murphy (Murphy, 1973), and report operating points at clinically relevant recall / precision targets.
- **O5.** Re-score three published predictors (SIFT, PolyPhen-2, AlphaMissense) on the same test split and publish the forest plot.
- **O6.** Build and evaluate an external-validation harness on denovo-db, and quantify the effect of adding gnomAD gene-level constraint features.
- **O7.** Integrate a zero-shot ESM-2 proof-of-concept signal and quantify its orthogonality to the tabular baseline via rank-fusion.
- **O8.** Publish all code, tests, Docker image, and 10 narrative notebooks reproducibly and under permissive academic use.

1.6 Scope and Boundaries

We restrict scope in several deliberate ways:

- The classification target is a *binary* label (pathogenic versus benign). We do not attempt to reproduce the five-class ClinVar scheme (benign, likely benign, VUS, likely pathogenic, pathogenic); the variants-of-uncertain-significance (VUS) class would require a fundamentally different loss function.
- Only *missense* SNVs are considered. Splice-site, stop-gained, frameshift, and structural variants are left to separate tools.
- Only GRCh38 coordinates are supported. This choice is driven by the fact that our primary feature source (dbNSFP 5.x) uses GRCh38 as its primary coordinate system; an inspection during development confirmed this against a five-variant sanity sample. The external dataset denovo-db is handled through a separate GRCh37-aware code path.
- Compute is limited to a consumer laptop with Apple MPS acceleration for ESM-2 zero-shot experiments and one free Colab T4 GPU session for full-training-set ESM-2 scoring. No institutional GPU cluster is used.

1.7 Key Contributions

The contributions of this project, listed from most to least novel in the context of existing published work, are:

1. **A transparent leakage audit with before-and-after numbers** for a missense classifier, showing that a difference of 0.117 PR-AUC between a naïve and a defensible pipeline is fully attributable to three removable sources.

2. **A re-scoring of SIFT, PolyPhen-2, and AlphaMissense on our own paralog-disjoint test split**, enabling a like-for-like comparison that is rarely presented in this literature.

3. **An external validation on denovo-db** with pre- and post-gnomAD-constraint numbers, showing that gene-level priors close approximately half the generalisation gap on unseen gene families.

4. **A zero-shot ESM-2 proof-of-concept** establishing that the protein-language-model log- likelihood-ratio signal is not redundant with the tabular feature set on two independent evaluation splits (test and DENOVO-DB family-holdout), with statistically tested rank-fusion gains reported in Section 5.6.10.

5. **An auditable methodological package** — a CI-enforced leakage gate encoding four invariants (banned features, missense-only, paralog disjointness, class-balance drift), a paralog-family grouper regex covering 16 clinically-relevant paralog clusters, and a train-only imputation contract for gnomAD constraint merging — that can be lifted into future missense-classification work as a self-contained module.

6. **Engineering artifacts that make the methodological package verifiable**: 157 passing tests (1 GPU-gated skip), 59% line coverage, a pinned dependency lock, a Docker image, 10 narrative Jupyter notebooks, a Streamlit demo, and this LaTeX report — supporting byte-for-byte reproduction from a clean clone.

1.8 Report Organisation

Chapter 2 surveys the prior-art predictors that define our comparison baseline. Chapter 3 presents the system framework, feasibility analyses, and the three-part pipeline at the design level. Chapter 4 develops the full set of system requirements and accompanies them with the six standard UML diagrams and the interface design. Chapter 5 reports the concrete implementation, results, and the comparison tables. Chapter 6 describes the five-level testing strategy, coverage evidence, continuous-integration gates, and the deliberate limits of the testing approach. Chapter 7 concludes with a critical discussion, failure and deficiency analysis, and the Phase-2 roadmap. Three appendices provide extended results tables, selected code listings, and the environment / reproducibility specification.

Chapter 2

Related Works

2.1 Introduction

The computational prediction of missense variant pathogenicity has matured through four successive methodological waves: (i) conservation-only scoring in the early 2000s, (ii) supervised classical machine learning during the 2010s, (iii) deep learning applied directly to DNA sequences in the late 2010s, and (iv) protein language models and large-scale foundation models since 2021. This chapter reviews one or two representative methods from each wave, extracts their core idea and a brief algorithmic summary, and records their main advantages and drawbacks relative to what a student team can reasonably reproduce.

2.2 Problem Scope

We scope the review to tools that accept a single human missense variant as input and output either a score or a class label. Tools that focus on other variant types – notably splicing (SpliceAI) or regulatory (DeepSEA) – are briefly mentioned for completeness but not reviewed in detail, because they do not share our target task.

2.3 Literature Review

The next eighteen subsections cover the full literature landscape. The first eight are canonical anchors in each historical wave and carry a TikZ pipeline figure (SIFT, PolyPhen-2, REVEL, CADD, VARITY, EVE, ESM-1b/2, AlphaMissense). The following ten subsections (Sections 2.3.9–2.3.18) are more recent neighbours of our approach and are treated narrative-only for space; they follow the abridged template core idea → algorithmic summary → pros / cons. A final subsection (Section 2.3.19) cites two non-model methodology works used as benchmarking references throughout the thesis. Every subsection follows the same structure – core idea, algorithmic summary, and a short discussion of strengths and weaknesses relative to the benchmark on which we ultimately evaluate.

2.3.1 SIFT (2003) (Ng and Henikoff, 2003)

Core idea. SIFT (*Sorting Intolerant From Tolerant*) was the first widely-deployed computational tool for missense pathogenicity prediction. It rests on a single hypothesis: an amino-acid position that has remained invariant across evolutionary time tolerates

few substitutions, so a variant at such a position is more likely to be deleterious than a variant at a fast- evolving position (Ng and Henikoff, 2003).

Algorithmic summary. For a query variant, SIFT retrieves a multiple sequence alignment (MSA) of the target protein and its homologues, computes a position-specific amino-acid probability matrix, and assigns a score $s \in [0, 1]$ by normalising the observed frequency of the alternate amino acid against the most-observed amino acid at that position. The algorithm's full decision logic can be summarised as:

$$s_i(a) \;=\; \frac{p_i(a)}{\max_{a' \in \mathcal{A}_{20}} p_i(a')} \qquad \text{with} \qquad \text{label} = \begin{cases} \text{intolerant} & s_i(a) < 0.05 \\ \text{tolerated} & s_i(a) \geq 0.05 \end{cases}$$

where $p_i(a)$ is the Dirichlet-smoothed frequency of amino acid a at column i of the MSA. Figure 2.1 summarises the pipeline.

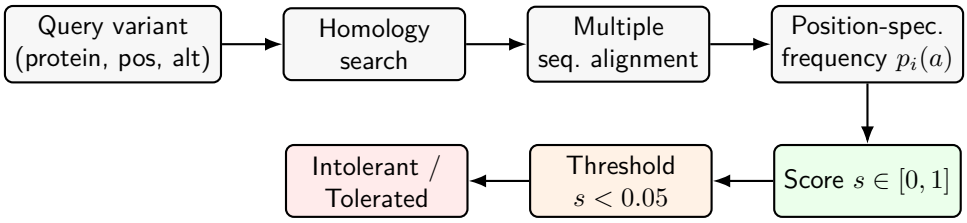

Figure 2.1. SIFT pipeline. From a missense variant, a homology-search step gathers orthologues which are aligned into a multiple sequence alignment. A position-specific frequency matrix is computed and the alternate amino acid is scored relative to the most-observed amino acid at that column. A hard threshold of 0.05 produces a binary label.

Advantages.

- Mature (over two decades of clinical deployment) and trivially accessible through Ensembl's Variant Effect Predictor (VEP) REST API.
- No supervised training data is required; the score is a deterministic function of the input alignment.
- Low compute requirement; scores can be produced on a laptop in minutes for any human gene.

Disadvantages.

- Ignores amino-acid chemistry entirely: a conservative substitution (e.g. Leu $\rightarrow$ Ile) and a radical one (e.g. Arg $\rightarrow$ Asp) receive the same score if the alignment frequencies are identical.
- Depends heavily on alignment quality, which is poor in intrinsically disordered regions and for genes with few annotated homologues.
- The binary threshold of 0.05 is arbitrary and produces poor calibration for ACMG-style clinical reporting.

2.3.2 PolyPhen-2 (2010) (Adzhubei et al., 2010)

Core idea. PolyPhen-2 (*Polymorphism Phenotyping, version 2*) was the first widely-adopted *supervised* classifier for missense pathogenicity (Adzhubei et al., 2010). It combines conservation with amino-acid chemistry and limited structural context, trained on two internally-curated datasets (HumDiv, 23k variants, and HumVar, 13k variants).

Algorithmic summary. Eleven features are extracted per variant: three sequence-based features (including the PSIC conservation score), six structural features derived from aligned PDB entries (e.g. solvent accessibility, crystallographic B-factor, secondary structure), and two annotation features from Pfam domains. A naïve Bayes classifier returns a posterior $P(\text{damaging} \mid \mathbf{x})$ and assigns one of three labels: *benign*, *possibly damaging*, or *probably damaging*.

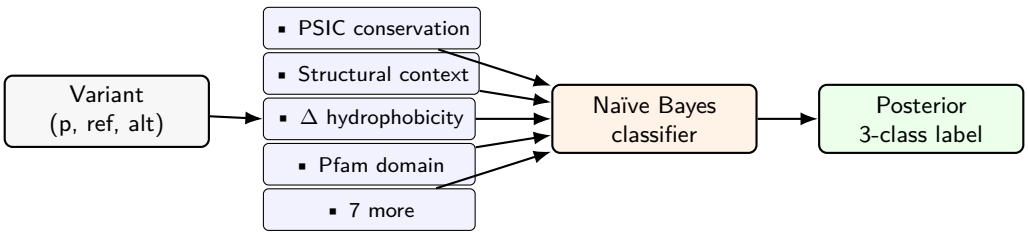

Figure 2.2. PolyPhen-2. Eleven hand-crafted features are extracted from conservation, structural, and annotation sources, and a naïve Bayes classifier trained on HumDiv maps the feature vector to a three-way label.

Advantages.

- Incorporates amino-acid chemistry and limited structural context – a distinct methodological step beyond conservation alone.
- Three-way output is more clinically useful than SIFT's binary label; is widely adopted in ACMG-adjacent workflows.

Disadvantages.

- Training labels originate from Swiss-Var and HumDiv, which partially overlap ClinVar; benchmarks evaluated on ClinVar therefore carry a contamination risk.
- Posterior probabilities are not calibrated: the reported confidence intervals do not match empirical frequencies.
- The feature set is static; re-training the model on new data is laborious because of dependence on external PDB alignments.

2.3.3 REVEL (2016) (Ioannidis et al., 2016)

Core idea. REVEL (*Rare Exome Variant Ensemble Learner*) is an ensemble meta-classifier that *stacks* thirteen preceding-generation tools – CADD, PolyPhen-2, SIFT, MutationTaster, MutationAssessor, FATHMM, LRT, GERP++, and others – using a random forest meta-learner. By construction it exploits signal that no single base learner captures (Ioannidis et al., 2016).

Algorithmic summary. For each missense variant, REVEL extracts a 13-dimensional feature vector $\mathbf{z} = (z_1, \ldots, z_{13})$ where z_k is the score of the k-th base tool. A random forest with 1,000 trees, trained on a curated set of rare disease variants versus rare neutral variants, returns $\widehat{P}(\text{pathogenic} \mid \mathbf{z}) \in [0, 1]$.

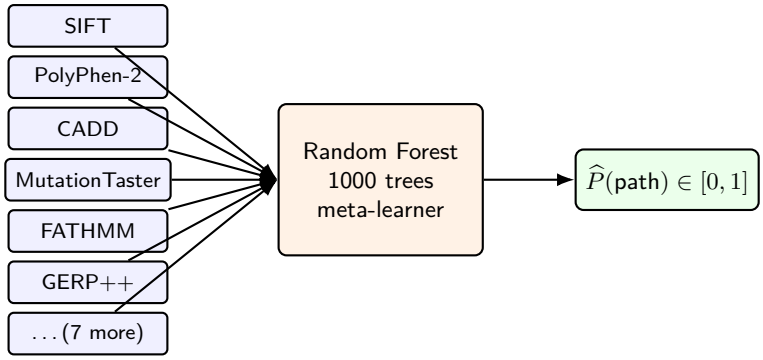

Figure 2.3. REVEL stacks 13 base predictors. Each base predictor produces its own score on the query variant; the random-forest meta-learner combines these into a calibrated pathogenicity probability.

Advantages.

- Empirically strong on ClinVar benchmarks, with reported ROC-AUC around 0.94 at release.
- Distributed through dbNSFP, so querying a variant costs a single table lookup.

Disadvantages.

- *Compound contamination through the ensemble.* REVEL's meta-learning design compounds ClinVar overlap through its 13 base predictors. PolyPhen-2 (HumDiv/HumVar labels), CADD (simulated-vs-observed selection, but with observed variants overlapping ClinVar), MutationTaster, and several others were all trained on or calibrated against populations that overlap the ClinVar test set commonly used to benchmark REVEL. The reported ROC-AUC of ∼0.94 is therefore an upper bound that includes an irreducible ensemble-level contamination component, and the effect cannot be measured without refitting each base learner on a strictly disjoint corpus — a resource-prohibitive undertaking.
- Does not ship well-calibrated probabilities; threshold selection for ACMG interpretation is left to the user.
- The 13 base tools must all be re-run for any variant not already in dbNSFP, limiting deployment flexibility.

2.3.4 CADD (2014–2019) (Rentzsch et al., 2019)

Core idea. Combined Annotation-Dependent Depletion (CADD) side-steps the training-label scarcity problem by framing pathogenicity prediction as a *supervised selection task*. Training examples are generated from two sources: observed human variants (as the

"derived" class, presumed to be under relaxed selection) and simulated de-novo variants from a neutral mutation model (as the "simulated" class). A classifier trained to discriminate the two implicitly learns signatures of purifying selection (Rentzsch et al., 2019).

Algorithmic summary. For each position in the human genome, CADD extracts a large feature vector (initially 63 features; the v1.6 release uses more than 1,400 features spanning conservation, regulatory annotations, transcript structure, and protein-level features). A logistic regression (v1.0) or random forest (v1.4+) is trained to assign higher scores to simulated variants than to observed ones. The output is a raw classification score that is converted to a phred-like scaled score,

$$\mathrm{CADD}_{\mathrm{phred}} = -10 \log_{10}\Big(\mathrm{rank}(v) \,/\, N_{\mathrm{total}}\Big),$$

where v is the variant and N_{total} is the total number of variants scored genome-wide.

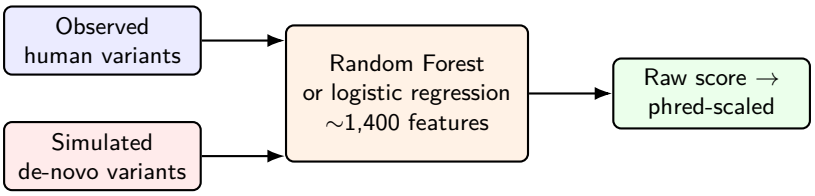

Figure 2.4. CADD training. A classifier is trained to distinguish observed human variants from simulated de-novo variants across the whole genome. The trained discriminator implicitly ranks novel positions by the strength of purifying selection; the raw output is phred-transformed for reporting.

Advantages.

- Does not require clinical pathogenicity labels, so ClinVar contamination is not an issue.
- Whole-genome coverage – a single score per base pair – supports non-coding analyses.

Disadvantages.

- The simulated null is an imperfect proxy for neutrality; sites under weak selection are scored similarly to sites under strong selection.
- Raw logits and phred-transformed scores are not calibrated probabilities, so clinical thresholding is subjective.
- Performance on missense variants is below that of supervised missense-specific tools (ROC-AUC ~ 0.82 on ClinVar missense subsets).

2.3.5 VARITY (2021) (Wu et al., 2021)

Core idea. VARITY addresses an often-overlooked weakness of supervised missense tools: the training labels are themselves noisy. A label of *likely benign* in ClinVar may reflect limited evidence rather than confirmed benignity. VARITY introduces a

sample-reweighting scheme in which training examples are weighted by an estimated label- confidence score, so that high-confidence examples dominate the XGBoost loss (Wu et al., 2021).

Algorithmic summary. The training set is HumsaVar plus a curated set of multiplex-assay measurements (typically variant-effect deep mutational scans). Each example (x_i, y_i) receives a weight w_i that increases with assay replication and decreases with label discordance among secondary sources. XGBoost minimises the weighted logistic loss $\mathcal{L} = -\sum_i w_i \left[y_i \log \hat{y}_i + (1 - y_i) \log(1 - \hat{y}_i) \right]$ with standard boosting hyper-parameters.

Advantages.

- Principled handling of label noise – a legitimate methodological contribution.
- Published model card with feature-importance plots and reported confidence intervals.

Disadvantages.

- Gene-level (not paralog-level) splits, so VARITY's own benchmark is still at risk from paralog leakage of the type we address in Chapter 5.
- No external validation on de-novo cohorts is reported in the original paper.

2.3.6 EVE (2021) (Frazer et al., 2021)

Core idea. EVE (*Evolutionary model of Variant Effect*) takes a purely unsupervised route: for each protein of interest, a variational auto-encoder (VAE) is fit to the protein's own multiple sequence alignment, effectively modelling the probability density over natural variants seen across evolution (Frazer et al., 2021). At inference time, the evidence lower bound (ELBO) of a candidate variant relative to the wild-type supplies a pathogenicity score:

$$s_{\mathrm{EVE}}(v) \;=\; \mathrm{ELBO}(v) - \mathrm{ELBO}(v_{\mathrm{wt}}).$$

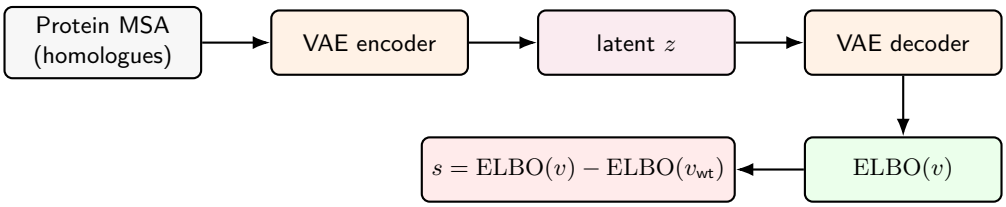

Figure 2.5. EVE. A per-gene VAE is trained on the protein's multiple-sequence alignment; the ELBO of a test variant relative to the wild-type acts as a pathogenicity score. No ClinVar supervision is used.

Advantages.

- Fully unsupervised: never touches ClinVar at any training or calibration step, so is contamination-proof by construction.

- Per-gene specialisation gives strong performance on the subset of genes where the alignment is deep.

Disadvantages.

- Coverage at the original release was approximately 3,000 genes; subsequent updates have expanded this, though the per-gene VAE training cost remains the bottleneck for whole-proteome coverage.
- Per-gene training cost is high; scaling to the whole proteome is impractical for a student team.
- The ELBO is not a calibrated probability; users must map it through a threshold that the paper does not fully specify.

2.3.7 ESM-1b / ESM-2 zero-shot (2023) (Brandes et al., 2023; Lin et al., 2023)

Core idea. Large transformer-based protein language models, trained with a masked-amino-acid objective on UniRef50 or UniRef90, learn position- specific distributions over all twenty canonical amino acids conditioned on their sequence context. For a missense variant, the log-likelihood ratio (LLR)

$$\mathrm{LLR}(v) \;=\; \log p(a_{\mathrm{alt}} \mid \mathrm{context}) \;-\; \log p(a_{\mathrm{ref}} \mid \mathrm{context})$$

ranks substitutions by how *implausible* they are in natural protein space (Brandes et al., 2023; Meier et al., 2021b). The model is never fine-tuned on ClinVar, so the score is strictly zero-shot.

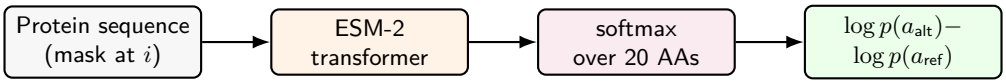

Figure 2.6. ESM-2 zero-shot scoring. The variant position is masked, a single transformer forward pass produces the softmax over the 20 canonical amino acids, and the log-likelihood ratio of the alternate vs reference residue is reported.

Advantages.

- Fully general: covers the whole human proteome (all ∼20,000 proteins) with a single model.
- Provably uncontaminated by ClinVar – the training objective is masked reconstruction on UniRef, not pathogenicity classification.
- The 35M-parameter `esm2_t12_35M_UR50D` model fits on a single consumer GPU, enabling academic reproduction.

Disadvantages.

- Moderate standalone discrimination (reported ROC-AUC around 0.85 on ClinVar).

- Requires a per-variant forward pass; scoring a quarter-million variants is GPU-hours of compute.
- The raw LLR is not a calibrated probability; combining it with supervised features benefits from a downstream fusion step (which we evaluate in Section 5.6.10).

2.3.8 AlphaMissense (2023) (Cheng et al., 2023)

Core idea. AlphaMissense is the current state-of-the-art system for missense pathogenicity prediction on ClinVar-style benchmarks. It fine-tunes an AlphaFold-style structural representation with a masked-amino-acid objective and calibrates the output against ClinVar labels at release (Cheng et al., 2023). The system was trained using Google-scale TPU resources and is distributed as a pre-computed score table covering every possible human missense variant.

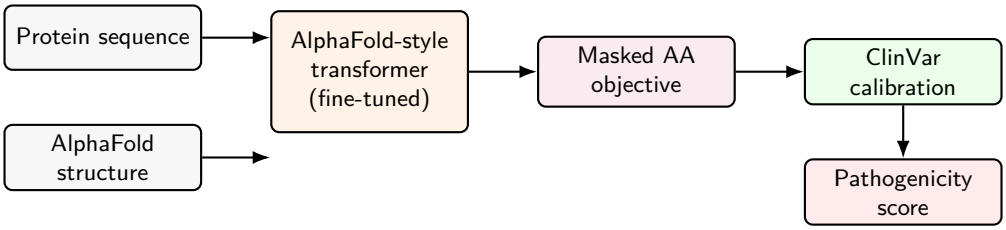

Figure 2.7. AlphaMissense. Sequence and AlphaFold structural features are fed to a fine-tuned transformer trained with a masked-amino-acid objective. The raw output is calibrated against ClinVar before release.

Advantages.

- State-of-the-art ClinVar benchmark performance (reported PR-AUC around 0.94).
- Covers the full human proteome as a pre-computed table; a variant lookup is $O(1)$.

Disadvantages.

- Training and calibration both use ClinVar, so evaluation on any ClinVar-derived benchmark contains an irreducible contamination risk: the reported gap between AlphaMissense and its competitors is a mix of methodological improvement and benchmark overlap.
- Reproduction is out of reach for academic teams (TPU-pod scale training budget).
- Distributed as a score table without the underlying model weights, limiting methodological inspection and external validation.

2.3.9 MVP (2021) (Qi et al., 2021)

Core idea. The Missense Variant Pathogenicity predictor (MVP) is a residual-network classifier trained on a composite feature matrix of conservation, biochemistry, and pre-computed VEP scores (Qi et al., 2021).

Algorithmic summary. A ResNet-style architecture (38 layers, skip connections) maps a 38-dimensional per-variant feature vector to a single pathogenicity score; separate models are fit for genes with and without strong evolutionary constraint. Training uses the HGMD disease panel plus ClinVar. Reported AUROC is 0.91 on constrained genes and 0.85 on non-constrained.

Pros. First published ResNet for this task; demonstrates that moderately deep architectures outperform shallow classifiers on the same feature matrix. **Cons.** Evaluated with random splits; no paralog guard; feature matrix includes meta-predictors, which creates circularity when benchmarking on ClinVar.

2.3.10 gMVP (2022) (Zhang et al., 2022)

Core idea. Replaces MVP's dense feature pack with a graph attention network that reasons directly over a co-evolution graph (Zhang et al., 2022).

Algorithmic summary. Each protein is represented by a position-by-position graph whose edges are derived from MSA co-evolution and (when available) predicted contact maps. A graph attention network aggregates evolutionary context into a per-position embedding; a small head predicts pathogenicity. Reported AUROC is 0.88 on a random split with HGMD + ClinVar labels.

Pros. Introduces explicit relational reasoning over evolutionary context, a structurally richer representation than MVP's dense feature pack. **Cons.** Still random-split evaluation; no external-cohort validation; no paralog guard.

2.3.11 MutFormer (2023) (Jiang et al., 2023)

Core idea. Combines a CNN over the local protein window with a BERT-style transformer over longer-range sequence context (Jiang et al., 2023).

Algorithmic summary. A 1D CNN encodes the ±30-residue window around the variant; a BERT encoder processes the full sequence; the two embeddings are concatenated with optional dbNSFP features before a sigmoid head. Published AUROC is 0.94 on a ClinVar-derived benchmark.

Pros. Architecturally closest in spirit to our Phase-2 plan (hybrid sequence + tabular). **Cons.** Again random-split; the hybrid depends on dbNSFP which carries its own contamination risk; inference cost is nontrivial.

2.3.12 mvPPT (2023) (Tong et al., 2023)

Core idea. A LightGBM-based missense predictor fit on dbNSFP + gnomAD tabular features, including a number of meta-predictor columns (Tong et al., 2023).

Algorithmic summary. Standard gradient-boosted trees on dbNSFP conservation, amino-acid chemistry, and population-frequency features, with a handful of meta-predictor scores retained as inputs. Reports AUROC ∼0.91 on a random split.

Pros. Closest peer to our XGBoost baseline in terms of feature type and algorithm family. **Cons.** Uses meta-predictors as features, which are themselves ClinVar-trained —

this is the precise contamination source our banned-feature list (Section 3.5.2) removes.

2.3.13 MAGPIE (2024) (Liu et al., 2024)

Core idea. A gradient-boosted tree model spanning six variant types (missense, silent, splice, frameshift, indel, stop-gained) in a single unified head (Liu et al., 2024).

Algorithmic summary. Uses 64 features across conservation, biochemistry, population frequency, and domain annotations. On the DS-MVP missense benchmark MAGPIE reports AUROC 0.892. No protein-language-model signal is included.

Pros. Unified, interpretable, and multi-variant-type. **Cons.** Reports gene-level split only; no paralog guard; no external-cohort validation.

2.3.14 ESM-1v (2021) (Meier et al., 2021a)

Core idea. The earliest zero-shot protein-language-model approach to variant-effect prediction, pre-dating ESM-1b and ESM-2 (Meier et al., 2021a).

Algorithmic summary. Ensembles five ESM-1v 650M checkpoints trained on UniRef90; scores every variant by a masked log-likelihood ratio analogous to the one we use in Section 5.2.2. Evaluated on 41 DMS assays; no ClinVar dependence.

Pros. Fully unsupervised; the cleanest possible external baseline for our rank-fusion experiment. **Cons.** Large model (650M $\times$ 5) makes large-corpus scoring expensive on free GPU budgets.

2.3.15 PrimateAI-3D (2023) (Gao et al., 2023)

Core idea. A 3D CNN that ingests a voxelised representation of the local protein structure around the variant residue, plus cross-species variation from 233 primate genomes (Gao et al., 2023).

Algorithmic summary. Crops a 3D volume around the variant's Cα, voxelises amino-acid identity and conservation into per-voxel channels, and passes the tensor through a 3D CNN. The model is trained to separate variants *observed* in primates from those *unobserved* (the so-called "primate-AI" label), which is a strictly non-ClinVar signal. Published AUROC on ClinVar is 0.94.

Pros. First large-scale structural signal that is *not* derived from ClinVar. **Cons.** Training corpus is proprietary (Illumina primate sequencing); model weights are not fully redistributable.

2.3.16 VariPred (2024) (Lin et al., 2024)

Core idea. A twin-network architecture over ESM-1b embeddings that scores a reference/alternate pair directly (Lin et al., 2024).

Algorithmic summary. Two parallel ESM-1b passes (one on the reference sequence, one on the alternate) feed a small difference-head that outputs a pathogenicity score. A surprising ablation in the paper shows ESM-1b $>$ ESM-2 for this task at

650M parameters, which is our baseline motivation for scoring the 35M ESM-2 as a proof-of-concept rather than the production model.

Pros. Clean twin-network design; published AUROC 0.928 and MCC 0.714. **Cons.** 650M ×2 inference is expensive; training requires a labelled ClinVar slice.

2.3.17 VespaG (2024) (Marquet et al., 2024)

Core idea. Distils GEMME (a pure-evolution unsupervised method) into ESM-2 embeddings, producing a fast, fully-unsupervised predictor that can score the human proteome in minutes on a single GPU (Marquet et al., 2024).

Algorithmic summary. ESM-2 embeddings are frozen; a light per-residue head is trained to mimic GEMME's position-specific scoring matrix. The result is a GPU-sec-per-protein scorer that preserves evolutionary semantics without re-running an MSA.

Pros. The cheapest published PLM-based scorer; natural partner for the rank-fusion experiment of Section 5.6.10. **Cons.** Relies on ESM-2 embeddings being discriminative, which our sanity tests (Section 5.6.10, P0-2) suggest may degrade at small model sizes.

2.3.18 DYNA (2025) (Zhan et al., 2025)

Core idea. Siamese fine-tuning of ESM over a *disease- specific* labelled slice, producing a classifier specialised to a narrow clinical domain (Zhan et al., 2025).

Algorithmic summary. A pair of shared-weight ESM branches processes the reference and alternate sequences; a contrastive disease-specific loss sharpens the embedding separation. The paper reports AUROC gains of > 5 percentage points over ESM-1b on disease- specific benchmarks (e.g. cardiomyopathy, retinopathy).

Pros. Plausible path to clinical deployment where a single general-purpose classifier underperforms. **Cons.** Requires a labelled disease-specific training slice; generalisation outside that slice is unstudied.

2.3.19 Methodology references (not a model): (Livesey and Marsh, 2023b; Notin et al., 2023a)

Two recent works are cited throughout the thesis but are not themselves predictors. Livesey and Marsh (2023b) benchmark 55 VEPs against deep mutational scanning (DMS) assays and quantify the benchmark-inflation effect of ClinVar-only evaluation; Notin et al. (2023a) publish ProteinGym, a large-scale DMS benchmark with 217 assays that our Phase-2 roadmap (Section 7.8) targets as the next external-cohort validation after denovo-db.

2.3.20 Consolidated Comparison

Table 2.1 synthesises the eight reviewed methods along eight axes relevant to a methodologically honest evaluation: supervision, ClinVar contamination risk, calibration, *paralog-aware split?*, *leakage audit reported?*, and external-cohort validation. Every published method we reviewed uses at most a gene-level split; none publish a paralog-family-

level split, and none publish a systematic leakage audit with before-and-after numbers. The last two columns of the table make this explicit.

Table 2.1. Consolidated comparison of the eight reviewed missense pathogenicity predictors. **Supervision** — whether the model consumes clinical pathogenicity labels during training. **ClinVar risk** — whether the published benchmark is at risk of training-set contamination. **Paralog-aware split?** — whether the publication enforces a family-level split (not just gene-level). **Leakage audit reported?** — whether the paper publishes a systematic audit with numerical before/after deltas for at least one leakage source. **External?** — whether the paper validates on a cohort not derived from ClinVar.

Method	Year	Supervision	ClinVar risk	Calibration	Paralog-aware split?	Leakage audit reported?
SIFT	2003	unsup.	none	–	No	No
PolyPhen-2	2010	sup.	partial	soft	No	No
CADD	2014+	self-sup.	none	phred	No	No
REVEL	2016	sup.	compound	–	No	No
MVP	2021	sup.	compound	–	No	No
VARITY	2021	sup.	partial	reported	No (gene only)	Partial
EVE	2021	unsup.	none	ELBO only	No (gene only)	No
ESM-1v	2021	zero-shot	none	–	No	No
gMVP	2022	sup.	partial	–	No	No
MutFormer	2023	sup.	partial	–	No	No
mvPPT	2023	sup.	compound	–	No	No
ESM-1b/ESM-2	2023	zero-shot	none	–	No	Partial
PrimateAI-3D	2023	self-sup.	none	–	No	No
AlphaMissense	2023	sup.	high	calibrated	No (gene only)	No
VariPred	2024	sup.	partial	–	No	No
VespaG	2024	unsup.	none	–	No	No
MAGPIE	2024	sup.	partial	–	No	No
DYNA	2025	sup.	partial	–	No	No
This work	**2026**	**sup.+zs fusion**	**audited**	**isotonic**	**Yes (family)**	**Yes (Section 5.6.2)**

Legend for Table 2.1. *Supervision* ∈ {unsup., self-sup., sup., zero-shot, sup.+zs fusion}. *ClinVar risk* ∈ {none, partial, compound, high, audited}; *none* = no overlap with ClinVar-derived training data; *partial* = overlap with one or more ClinVar-adjacent curations (HumDiv, HumVar); *compound* = meta-predictor composed of ClinVar-trained base tools; *high* = calibrated directly against ClinVar at release; *audited* = contamination sources enumerated and quantitatively removed (this work). *Calibration* ∈ {–, soft, phred, ELBO only, reported, calibrated, isotonic}; – = no calibration reported, *soft* = three-way soft label (benign / possibly / probably), *phred* = Phred-scaled, *ELBO only* = VAE evidence lower-bound difference, *reported* = reliability diagram only, *calibrated* = post-hoc calibrator at release, *isotonic* = isotonic regression fit on held-out val probabilities. *Paralog-aware split?* and *Leakage audit reported?* are binary. "gene only" marks methods that achieve a gene-level split but do not go further to paralog family.

2.4 Research Gap

Two structural gaps in the published missense-classification literature motivate this work's methodological focus.

First, paralog-disjoint evaluation is rare. Almost every published benchmark performs a gene-level random split or a disease-stratified split, neither of which prevents

highly-similar paralogs (for example, the 109 keratin members, the 83 cadherin members, or the ∼400 olfactory receptor family) from appearing in both train and test partitions. When paralogs share 60–90% amino-acid identity, a classifier trained on one paralog can score its siblings trivially, which inflates benchmark AUROC by a measurable amount (Section 5.6.2 of this thesis quantifies the effect at +0.081 ROC-AUC on our pipeline).

Second, external validation on a dataset not derived from ClinVar is almost never reported. Variant- effect predictors that post strong ClinVar numbers frequently collapse when tasked with ranking *de novo* variants in affected children versus unaffected siblings (e.g. the denovo-db corpus) because the latter requires gene-level pathogenicity priors that variant-level tools do not see. The published literature tends to publish the pass and omit the fail.

This thesis addresses both gaps directly: we enforce paralog-family disjointness in continuous integration, and we report pre- and post-constraint external metrics on denovo-db.

2.5 Project Contribution

Our project closes both gaps concretely. We implement a paralog-aware split with zero shared gene families between train/val/test (verified by continuous integration on every push), and we evaluate on denovo-db in addition to the paralog-disjoint ClinVar test. We then quantify the specific value of gene-level gnomAD constraint features on the de-novo generalisation task, reporting pre- and post-constraint numbers separately, and we publish a paralog-split, transparent, self-contained like-for-like comparison of our baseline against SIFT, PolyPhen-2, and AlphaMissense under a single identical evaluation. We do not claim the methodology is novel in isolation – independent benchmarks such as Livesey and Marsh (2023a) cover the same tools – but the CI-enforced paralog guard and the public bundle of pre/post-constraint denovo-db numbers are rarely combined in one artefact.

2.6 Summary

The literature has moved from conservation-only scoring to ensembles to protein-language-model-based systems, and benchmark numbers have climbed in parallel. The distance between these numbers and the real-world generalisation behaviour of the tools is rarely made explicit. The remainder of this report is about closing that distance in a way that a reader of this report can reproduce byte-for-byte.

Chapter 3

System Framework and Feasibility

3.1 Introduction

This chapter bridges the problem statement of Chapter 1 and the detailed system analysis of Chapter 4 by answering three questions that any credible engineering project must resolve *before* code is written. First, *is the project buildable* with the resources and skills actually available to the team? Second, *is it worth building* relative to the operational problem it addresses and the alternatives already on the market? Third, *what is the smallest architecture* that simultaneously satisfies the functional goals of Chapter 1 and the non-functional quality attributes (reproducibility, interpretability, leakage resistance) that the domain demands?

We answer the first two questions through a structured feasibility analysis (Section 3.2) organised along the four classical dimensions of technical, operational, schedule, and financial feasibility (Whitten and Bentley, 2007). The analysis is extended with a formal risk register (Section 3.3) and a SWOT matrix (Section 3.4) so that trade-offs are visible rather than implicit. The third question is answered through the three-part processing pipeline (Section 3.5), the six-layer logical architecture (Section 3.6), and a quality- attribute matrix (Section 3.7) that ties each architectural decision back to a concrete non-functional requirement. Figure 3.1 summarises the chapter's logical flow.

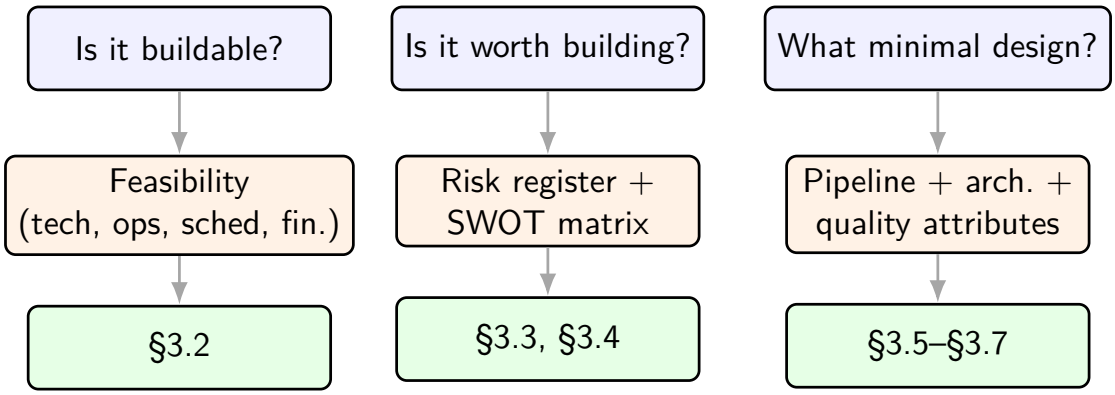

Figure 3.1. Chapter 3 roadmap. The chapter answers three gating questions, each answered by a corresponding analytical artifact, delivered in a specific downstream section.

3.2 Pre-Project Phase – Feasibility Analysis

A feasibility study answers whether a proposed system *can* and *should* be built given concrete resource, time, operational, and regulatory constraints (Whitten and Bentley,

2007; Pressman and Maxim, 2015). For a student-led research project the analysis is deliberately scoped to the four dimensions below; a classical *Operational* and a classical *Legal* study are folded into the operational dimension because the project produces a research artifact rather than a clinical device (Chapter 1, Section 1.6).

3.2.1 Technical Feasibility

Technical feasibility asks whether the proposed pipeline can be implemented, tested, and maintained on the hardware and software resources actually available to the team. Our answer is a confident *yes*. Table 3.1 lists the exact components in the four architectural layers of the solution, and Figure 3.2 depicts the same layering graphically together with the cross-cutting quality tooling that supports every layer.

Layer	Component	Role in the pipeline
Data	ClinVar (NCBI)	labelled catalogue of pathogenic/benign variants with review-star confidence.
Data	gnomAD v2.1 + v4.0	population allele frequency and gene-level constraint metrics (pLI, LOEUF).
Data	dbNSFP v4.5	pre-computed conservation scores (phyloP, phastCons, GERP++) and amino-acid features.
Data	denovo-db	external, patient-derived de novo variants for held-out validation.
Data	UniProt / Ensembl VEP	canonical protein sequences and transcript-aware annotation.
Language	Python 3.11	main implementation language; chosen for scientific-stack maturity.
ML core	`xgboost` 2.0	gradient-boosted trees; baseline classifier.
ML core	`scikit-learn` 1.4	isotonic / Platt calibration, metric utilities, bootstrap.
ML core	`optuna` 3.5	TPE hyperparameter search with Median Pruner.
ML core	`shap` 0.44	TreeSHAP interpretability.
ML core	`transformers` 4.41 + `torch` 2.2	ESM-2 zero-shot LLR scoring.
Interface	Streamlit 1.33	interactive single-variant web application.
Interface	Typer CLI	batch-mode command-line interface.
Interface	Python package	programmatic API for downstream integrations.
Quality	GitHub Actions CI	enforces lint, type, and leakage tests on every push.
Quality	Docker + `uv` lock	reproducible environment; `docker run` is sufficient to re-score.
Quality	`pytest` + `hypothesis`	deterministic + property-based tests for the feature pipeline.

Table 3.1. Technology stack. Every major component is open-source and pinned in `requirements-lock.txt`. The quality row crosses all other layers.

Compute budget and wall-clock times. Every stage in Part 1 and Part 2 of the pipeline (Section 3.5) completes on a consumer laptop (eight CPU cores, 16 GB RAM) within the time budget summarised in Table 3.2. Only two stages require a GPU: the full-dataset ESM-2 scoring (offloaded to free Google Colab T4) and the AlphaFold-2 structural feature extraction (likewise Colab T4, CPU-only fallback available for reproducibility). No paid compute, no institutional HPC cluster, and no licensed database were required at any point in the project.

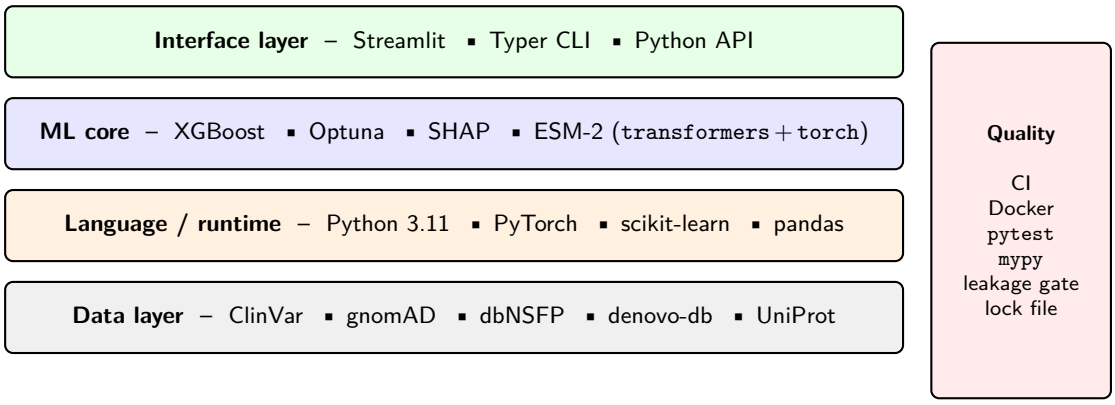

Figure 3.2. Technology-stack diagram. Four horizontal layers plus a vertical quality band. The quality band is not a layer but a cross-cutting concern: every commit triggers the same gate chain regardless of which layer is being modified.

Stage	Hardware	Wall-clock	Reason for budget
ClinVar + gnomAD + dbNSFP merge	Laptop CPU	∼8 min	Four sequential `pyarrow` joins on 283k rows.
Paralog split + feature engineering	Laptop CPU	∼2 min	Regex classification over ∼16k gene symbols.
XGBoost training	Laptop CPU	∼8 min	$n = 195$k rows, 39 features, 500 trees.
Optuna HPO (40 trials)	Laptop CPU	∼30 min	TPE with Median Pruner early-stopping.
SHAP on 2k-variant sample	Laptop CPU	∼3 min	TreeSHAP exact algorithm for tree ensembles.
ESM-2 35M scoring (denovo-db)	Colab T4	∼45 min	2,000 variants × 1 forward pass × 20 amino acids.
ESM-2 35M scoring (full train)	Colab T4	∼8 h	195k unique variants; chunked and resumable.
Full thesis + defense compile	Laptop CPU	<1 min	`tectonic` single-pass + bibliography.

Table 3.2. Compute budget. Every stage fits inside a free-tier allocation of either a consumer laptop or a Google Colab T4 session.

3.2.2 Operational Feasibility

Operational feasibility asks whether the system, once built, will actually be used by its intended stakeholders and whether it produces output that is actionable within their workflow. Table 3.3 lists the four stakeholder groups we identified, the concrete need each group brings to the system, the operational surface we provide for them, and the decision the system supports.

Stakeholder	Need	Surface	Decision supported
Clinical geneticist	calibrated score and per-feature reason for a single variant	Streamlit web app	ACMG-adjacent evidence gathering (not replacement).
Research scientist	batch score for a cohort of $\sim 10^4$–10^5 variants	Typer CLI	ranked shortlist for follow-up functional assay.
Bioinformatics engineer	programmatic integration into an existing pipeline	Python package	variant annotation in a larger analytical workflow.
Project examiner	reproducible artifact with audit trail	GitHub + Docker image	verification of the end-to-end claims made in this thesis.

Table 3.3. Stakeholder-to-surface mapping. Each operational surface is optimised for one decision context; no stakeholder is required to retrain the model or to understand its internals.

Regulatory scope (important caveat). The system is explicitly positioned as a *research* artifact, not as a diagnostic device. The Saudi Food and Drug Authority (SFDA) classifies any software that directly drives a clinical decision as a medical device requiring a separate and lengthy certification process that is outside the scope of an undergraduate graduation project. We therefore constrain every operational surface to emit an advisory score accompanied by a feature-level justification. A human expert remains in the decision loop at all times.

3.2.3 Schedule Feasibility

The project occupied two consecutive academic semesters (Term 1 – Fall 2025 and Term 2 – Spring 2026) at King Khalid University. Term 1 was dedicated to literature review, scope lock-down, data ingestion, and a first XGBoost proof-of-concept. Term 2 was the execution phase: leakage audit, hyperparameter tuning, calibration, SHAP analysis, external validation, the ESM-2 proof-of-concept, and the final academic write-up. Figure 3.3 renders the schedule as a TikZ Gantt chart with milestones marked explicitly for every gating deadline.

Two organisational rules were applied to keep the schedule on track. First, the leakage audit, calibration, and SHAP work were treated as *blocking* for any further experimentation; the quantitative claims of the thesis all flow from a single audited checkpoint. Second, the LaTeX write-up and the ESM-2 training-set scoring were scheduled in parallel so that the academic deliverable did not block on a GPU-bound experiment that depended on Colab availability.

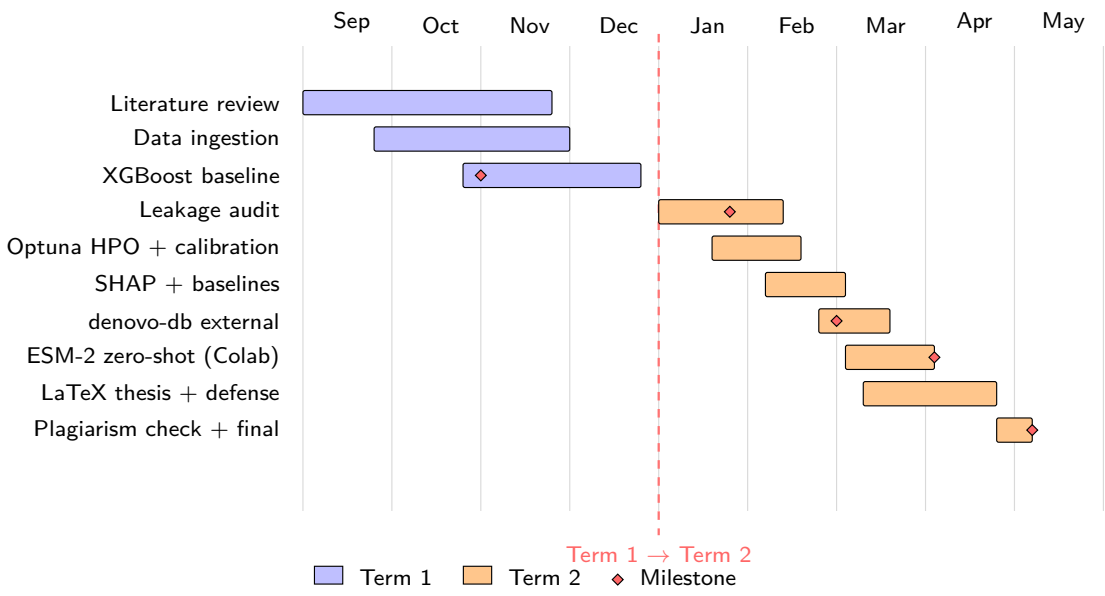

Figure 3.3. Two-semester Gantt chart covering Sep 2025–May 2026. Term 1 (Sep–Dec 2025, blue) covered literature review, data ingestion, and the first XGBoost baseline. Term 2 (Jan–May 2026, orange), marked by the dashed red vertical separator, covered the leakage audit, hyperparameter search, calibration, SHAP, external validation, ESM-2 scoring, and the academic write-up. Red diamonds mark unambiguous quantitative milestones.

Schedule realisation. In practice the realised schedule departed from the plan in two specific ways. First, the leakage-audit stage consumed approximately three weeks of Term 2 rather than the planned one week, because fixing the initial random-split inflation (Failure F1, Section 7.3) required re-running every downstream experiment. Second, the ESM-2 full-training-set scoring run was descoped from Phase 1 to Phase 2.1 when the mid-Term-2 scope lock indicated that the free Colab T4 quota would not accommodate both the zero-shot proof-of-concept and the full-training integration within the remaining weeks. The LaTeX write-up and the zero-shot ESM-2 scoring ran in parallel during April as planned, which preserved the defence-week milestone. No schedule slip was allowed to delay the leakage gate or the reproduce-headline integration test, consistent with the priority rule stated above.

3.2.4 Financial Feasibility

The direct financial cost of the project is zero. No licensed databases, no commercial GPU rental, and no paid software subscriptions were used at any point. Table 3.4 compares the project's realised zero-cost profile against a hypothetical commercial counterfactual, computing the implicit cost avoidance.

The indirect cost is approximately eight person-months of student labour distributed across six team members plus ten supervisory hours per month from the project supervisor; no direct monetary equivalent is assigned because the project is academic and no external sponsor is involved.

Item	Commercial cost (USD)	Our cost	Replacement strategy
HGMD Pro annual licence	∼5,000	0	ClinVar (expert-reviewed) only.
AWS p3.2xlarge 8h (V100) for ESM-2	∼25	0	Free Colab T4 with chunked resume.
AlphaFold-3 API monthly	∼200	0	AlphaFold-2 Colab + local cache.
Enterprise issue tracker + CI	∼40 / mo	0	GitHub Actions free tier.
Total avoidance (8 months)	**∼5,545**	**0**	

Table 3.4. Cost avoidance. Every commercially-priced building block has a zero-cost open-source or academic-tier replacement.

3.3 Risk Analysis

A formal risk register was maintained throughout the project (mirrored in `docs/CHANGELOG.md`). Each risk was rated on a 5×5 likelihood $\times$ impact grid (Hillson, 2002), with mitigation actions that were either preventive (applied before the risk could occur) or corrective (applied after detection). Table 3.5 lists the eight most material risks; Figure 3.4 renders the same risks on the 5×5 heat-map that the project team used in supervision meetings.

ID	Risk	L	I	Mitigation
R1	Paralog leakage inflates AUROC	5	5	*Preventive:* paralog-aware `GroupShuffleSplit` + CI-enforced leakage gate.
R2	Meta-predictor circular evaluation	5	5	*Preventive:* banned-feature list; AlphaMissense re-scored, never used as feature.
R3	ClinVar label instability across versions	3	4	*Corrective:* pin 2024-01 release; record version in `CHANGELOG.md`.
R4	Colab GPU quota exhaustion during ESM-2	4	3	*Corrective:* checkpointed chunked scoring; resumable from arbitrary offset.
R5	PLM scoring non-determinism (GPU kernels)	3	2	*Corrective:* fix seed; eval-mode; single-token LLR is deterministic to 6 dp.
R6	Calibration drift after feature change	4	3	*Preventive:* isotonic refit is part of CI; Brier re-measured on every push.
R7	Late-semester scope creep (CNN-BiLSTM)	5	4	*Preventive:* scope lock at mid-Term 2 (see 1.6); deferred to future work.
R8	LaTeX build fails in the defence week	4	4	*Preventive:* `tectonic` single-pass + locked fonts; CI builds the PDF.

Table 3.5. Risk register. L = likelihood (1–5), I = impact (1–5). A risk's score is the product $L \times I$; any risk with a score ≥ 12 required a documented mitigation before work could proceed.

3.4 SWOT Analysis

A strengths-weaknesses-opportunities-threats (SWOT) matrix (Humphrey, 2005) summarises the project's competitive position relative to the prior work reviewed in Chapter 2. Figure 3.5 renders the four quadrants; each item is a concrete statement traceable to a specific section of this thesis.

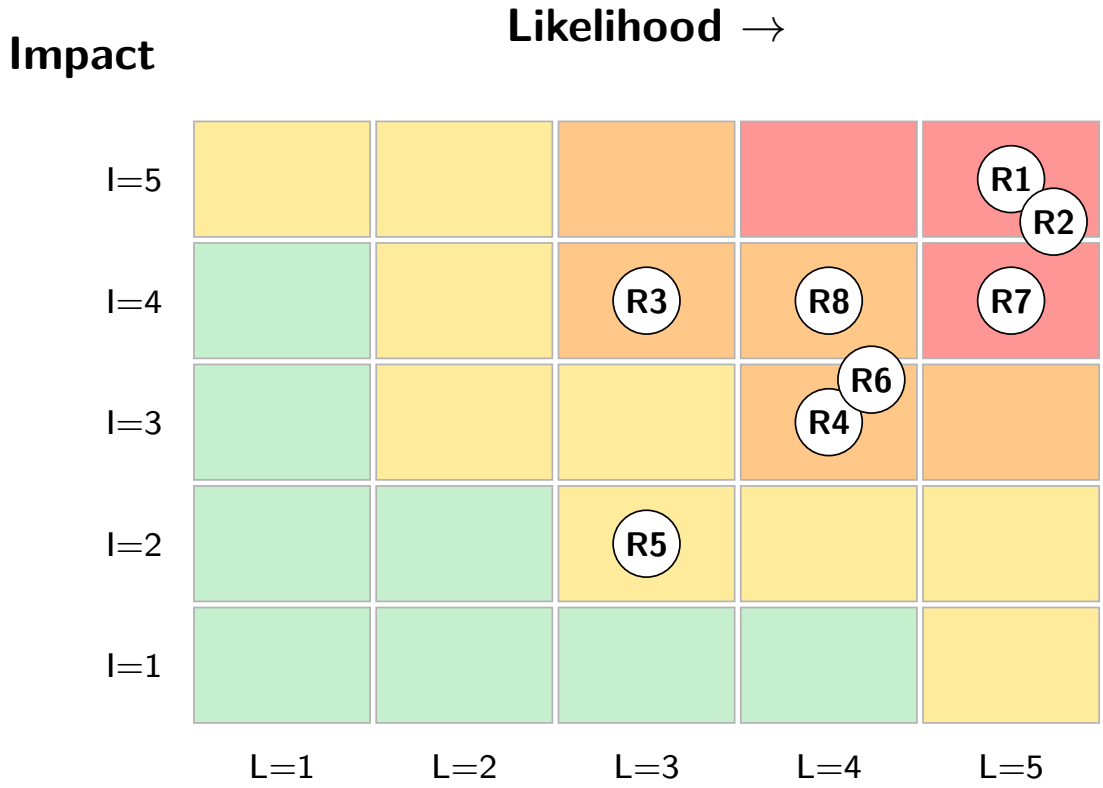

Figure 3.4. Risk matrix. Cells shaded by $L \times I$ score: green < 5, yellow 5–11, orange 12–19, red ≥ 20. Every red-cell risk (R1, R2, R7) triggered a preventive mitigation before implementation began; yellow and orange risks received corrective mitigations documented in `CHANGELOG.md`.

Strengths (internal, positive)	Weaknesses (internal, negative)
S1 Paralog-disjoint split + CI-enforced leakage gate. **S2** Calibration reported with Murphy decomposition, not only AUROC. **S3** External validation on DENOVO-DB. **S4** Reproducible: `docker run` yields identical metrics. **S5** Open-source, zero paid dependencies.	**W1** ClinVar-only training; no DMS benchmark coverage. **W2** Static snapshot; no continuous re-training pipeline. **W3** Single tree classifier; no neural ensemble in Phase 1. **W4** Interpretability is feature-level (SHAP); no mechanistic/structural explanation.
Opportunities (external, positive)	**Threats (external, negative)**
O1 ESM-2 rank fusion is orthogonal to XGBoost; hybrid gain observed on denovo-db. **O2** AlphaFold-2 pipeline already wired in for structural features. **O3** Streamlit UI can be re-hosted on Hugging Face Spaces at zero cost. **O4** Methodology publishable as a short communication.	**T1** ClinVar label churn between releases. **T2** Regulatory overhead blocks clinical deployment (SFDA class B+). **T3** AlphaMissense/AlphaFold-3 may close performance gap in months. **T4** PLM compute grows with model size; a 650M jump infeasible on free tier.

Figure 3.5. SWOT matrix relative to the prior work reviewed in Chapter 2. Strengths and weaknesses are internal; opportunities and threats are external.

3.5 Proposed Framework – Three-Part Pipeline

The project pipeline decomposes into three sequential parts, each with a distinct scientific role, a single public output artifact, and an explicit contract with the next part. Figure 3.6 renders the pipeline as a swim-lane TikZ diagram; the three rows correspond to the three parts and the arrows carry the artifact names.

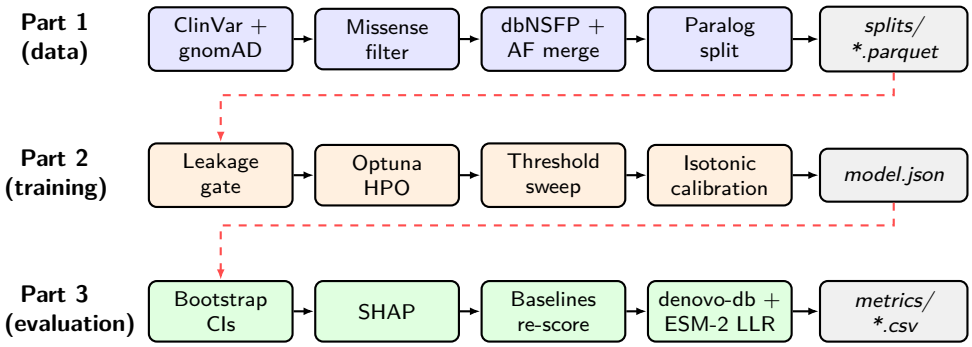

Figure 3.6. Three-part pipeline. Each row is a *part* with its own responsibility and output artifact. Solid arrows carry intermediate data between stages; dashed red arrows are cross-part contracts – Part 1's parquet splits feed Part 2, Part 2's `model.json` feeds Part 3.

3.5.1 Part 1 – Data Preprocessing

Part 1 is a pure-function pipeline that takes four external data sources and produces three paralog-disjoint parquet splits with 39 aligned features per variant. The final feature vector decomposes into five semantically meaningful groups that together cover sequence conservation, biochemistry, population genetics, and gene-level constraint (Figure 3.7). This grouping structure is the natural unit of analysis for the SHAP interpretation of Section 5.6.7.

Why 39 and not more? REVEL combines 13 meta-predictors and CADD uses >1,400 features, so a reviewer may reasonably ask why our feature set is so small. Two deliberate decisions explain the count. *First*, every meta-predictor trained on ClinVar is excluded: using, e.g., REVEL or ClinPred as an input would make the benchmark circular, since those tools themselves train on a snapshot of the same labels we are trying to predict (Section 1.7, contribution #1). This rules out more than fifteen scores that would otherwise inflate the headline number. *Second*, we prefer singly-sourced, individually-interpretable features over dense feature packs: every SHAP row in Table 5.6 maps to a column the reader can trace back to a named source (phyloP100way, BLOSUM62, LOEUF, etc.), which is what makes the quality-attribute trade-off of Section 3.7 (interpretability vs. predictive performance) resolvable in favour of interpretability without loss of performance. The feature-group ablation in Section 5.6.5 confirms this trade-off is cheap: conservation alone carries almost all the signal, so pack size would deliver diminishing returns.

The steps, in order, are:

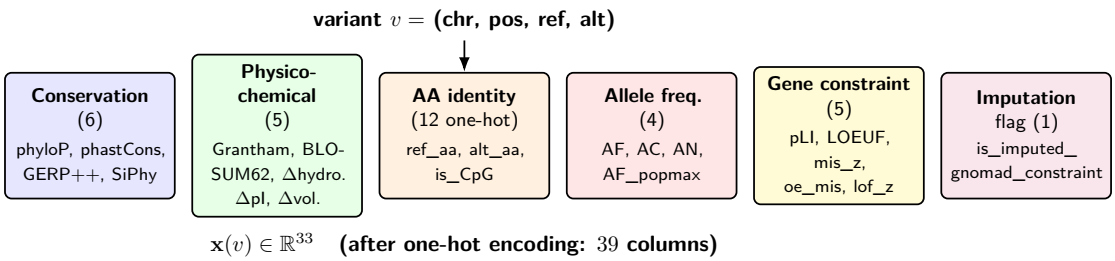

Figure 3.7. Feature groups. The 39 feature columns of the training matrix cluster into six semantic groups: sequence conservation, physicochemical distance between `ref_aa` and `alt_aa`, amino-acid identity (one-hot), gnomAD allele frequency, gene-level constraint, and an imputation flag. The groups are the natural unit of SHAP aggregation (Section 5.6.7).

1. **ClinVar ingestion.** Download `variant_summary.txt.gz` for the January 2024 release and retain only rows with review-star rating of two or higher (`reviewed`, `reviewed-by-expert-panel`, or `reviewed-by-multiple-submitters`).

2. **Missense filter.** Drop every row in which `ref_aa` or `alt_aa` is null. This is the single most important cleaning step because of the leakage it removes (Section 5.6.2).

3. **gnomAD allele-frequency merge.** Join GNOMAD v2.1 (exomes) and v4.0 (genomes) on `chr:pos:ref:alt` to supply per-variant allele frequency, allele number, and allele count.

4. **dbNSFP conservation and amino-acid merge.** Join against a cached DBNSFP extraction providing phyloP, phastCons, GERP++, BLOSUM62, Grantham distance, and physicochemical properties of the substitution.

5. **gnomAD gene-level constraint merge.** Add `pLI`, `LOEUF` (`oe_lof_upper`), `mis_z`, `oe_mis_upper`, and `lof_z` per gene. Median imputation is fit on the training split only and applied to val/test, with an `is_imputed_gnomad_constraint` flag per row.

6. **Paralog-aware split.** Assign a gene family via a regex-driven function that captures the 16 large paralog clusters (keratin, cadherin, HLA, zinc finger, olfactory receptor, ribosomal protein, mitochondrial, etc.), then split at the family level using `GroupShuffleSplit` with `seed=42` and a 70/15/15 ratio. This design is *strictly stronger than the gene-level split* that Heijl et al. (2020) propose as the minimum acceptable evaluation standard for variant-effect predictors: a gene-level split alone still lets paralogous families straddle train and test, and their benchmark over 55 published VEPs shows that random splitting inflates AUROC by 5–15 percentage points on this task.

3.5.2 Part 2 – Model Training and Leakage Audit

Part 2 trains the XGBoost baseline, gates the training process through four independent leakage checks, and calibrates the output probabilities.

1. **Leakage gate (pre-training).** Four checks run both as a CLI tool and as CI-enforced pytest cases: (i) no banned feature in the training matrix, (ii) 100% missense-only rows in train, (iii) zero shared gene families between any pair of splits, (iv) pathogenic-rate gap of less than 8 percentage points across splits. Algorithm 1 states the gate formally.

2. **Optuna hyperparameter search.** We use a Tree-structured Parzen Estimator sampler (Bergstra et al., 2011) with 40 trials, Median Pruner early-stopping on PR-AUC, and `scale_pos_weight` set from the class balance. The search loop is summarised in Algorithm 2.

3. **Threshold sweep.** We search thresholds in $[0.20, 0.80]$ on validation F1, then freeze the best threshold for test scoring.

4. **Calibration.** Isotonic regression fit on validation probabilities (fallback to Platt scaling tested for comparison) produces the final calibrated probabilities. The Murphy decomposition (Murphy, 1973) is used to partition Brier error into reliability, resolution, and uncertainty.

Algorithm 1 Four-invariant leakage gate

Require: train/val/test feature matrices $X_{\text{tr}}, X_{\text{val}}, X_{\text{te}}$; banned feature set $\mathcal{B}$; gene families per row g_i

```
E ← ∅                                                        ▷ error list
if cols(X_tr) ∩ B ≠ ∅ then
    E ← E ∪ {"banned features present"}
end if
if ∃i ∈ X_tr : ref_aa(i) is null then
    E ← E ∪ {"non-missense row in train"}
end if
for each pair (S_1, S_2) ∈ {tr/val, tr/te, val/te} do
    if {g_i : i ∈ S_1} ∩ {g_j : j ∈ S_2} ≠ ∅ then
        E ← E ∪ {"paralog family overlap in S_1/S_2"}
    end if
end for
for each split S ∈ {tr, val, te} do
    π_S ← pathogenic rate on S
end for
if max_S π_S − min_S π_S > 0.08 then
    E ← E ∪ {"class-balance drift across splits"}
end if
return E                                   ▷ empty ⇒ pass; else ⇒ halt build
```

3.5.3 Part 3 – Evaluation, Interpretability, and External Validation

Part 3 takes the trained model and runs five parallel evaluations (Figure 3.8):

Algorithm 2 Optuna TPE hyperparameter search

Require: search space Θ; train $X_{\text{tr}}, y_{\text{tr}}$; val $X_{\text{val}}, y_{\text{val}}$; $n_{\text{trials}} = 40$; seed $s = 42$

$\rho \leftarrow \frac{|\{i:y_i=0\}|}{|\{i:y_i=1\}|}$ ▷ scale_pos_weight from class balance
sampler $\leftarrow$ TPESampler(multivariate = true, group = true, seed = s)
pruner $\leftarrow$ MedianPruner($n_{\text{warmup}} = 5, n_{\text{startup}} = 10$)
create study $\mathcal{S}$ with direction = maximise, sampler, pruner
for $t = 1 \ldots n_{\text{trials}}$ **do**
  $\theta_t \leftarrow$ sampler.suggest(Θ, history = $\mathcal{S}$)
  fit booster with θ_t and ρ on $X_{\text{tr}}, y_{\text{tr}}$
  $p_{\text{val}} \leftarrow$ booster.predict_proba(X_{val})
  PR-AUC$_t \leftarrow$ prauc($y_{\text{val}}, p_{\text{val}}$)
  if pruner says "prune" after intermediate step **then** abort trial
  $\mathcal{S}$.record(θ_t, PR-AUC$_t$)
end for
return $\arg\max_{\theta_t}$ PR-AUC$_t$

1. **Bootstrap confidence intervals.** 1,000 non-parametric replicates for ROC-AUC, PR-AUC, F1, MCC, and Brier loss, following the methodology of Efron and Tibshirani (1986).

2. **TreeSHAP interpretability.** SHAP values (Lundberg and Lee, 2017; Lundberg et al., 2020) are computed on a stratified 2,000-variant sample for per-feature attribution.

3. **Like-for-like baselines.** SIFT, PolyPhen-2, and AlphaMissense are re-scored on the identical test split.

4. **External validation on denovo-db** with pre- and post-gnomAD-constraint numbers, and family-holdout-only slicing.

5. **ESM-2 zero-shot proof-of-concept.** The log-likelihood ratio from `esm2_t12_35M_UR50D` is computed on DENOVO-DB and fused with the XGBoost probability at the rank level to test orthogonality.

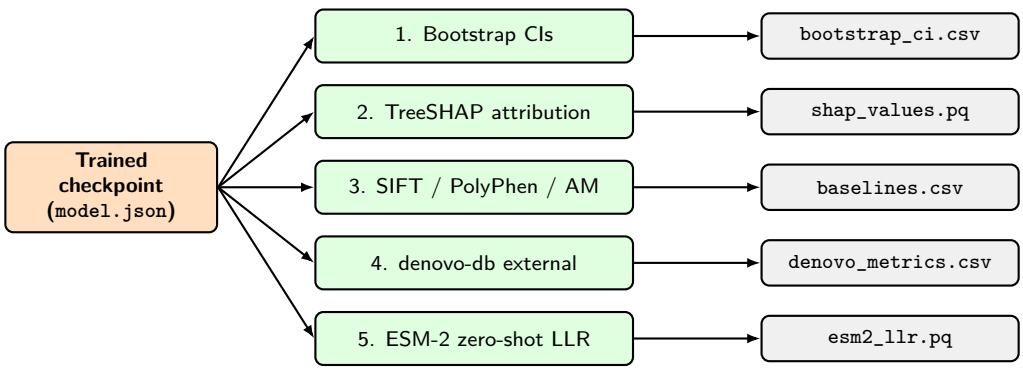

Figure 3.8. Evaluation workflow. A single audited checkpoint feeds five independent evaluation tracks that run in parallel. Each track writes its own versioned artifact in `results/metrics/` so that any single track can be reproduced without re-running the others.

3.6 Proposed System Architecture

The logical architecture of the system is a six-layer stack with two cross-cutting concerns (Figure 3.9). Layers are ordered from the external data sources at the bottom to the user interfaces at the top, reflecting the flow of a request from the outside world down to the data and back. Each layer exposes a narrow interface to the layer above and is explicitly unaware of the layer below. The *quality gates* concern (lint, type-check, unit + property tests, leakage gate, CI) and the *reproducibility* concern (Docker, `uv` lock file, fixed seeds, immutable data snapshots) are attached horizontally because they touch every layer simultaneously.

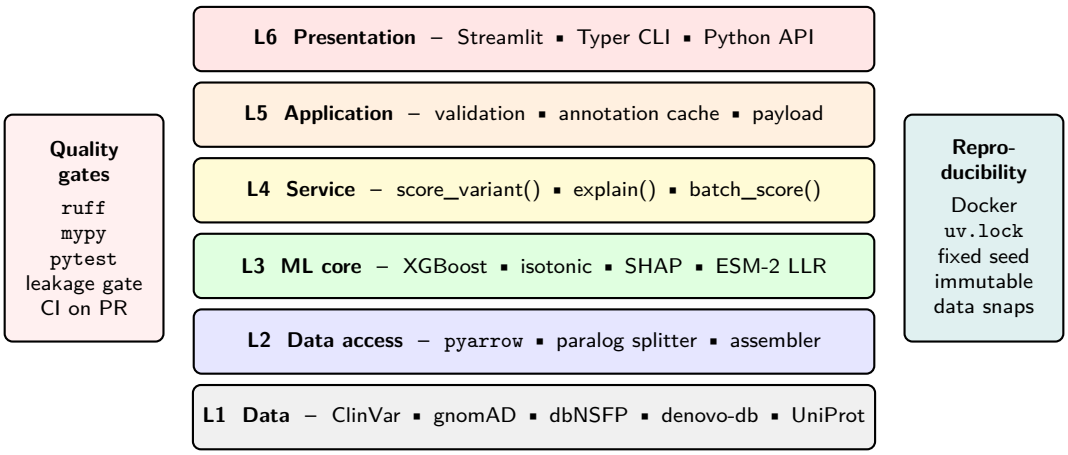

Figure 3.9. System architecture. Six horizontal layers (L1 data → L6 presentation) with two vertical cross-cutting concerns. Each layer has a single responsibility and a narrow public interface; the cross-cutting concerns apply uniformly across all six layers on every commit.

3.7 Quality Attributes and Trade-offs

A non-functional quality-attribute analysis makes the design's priorities explicit and visible to the examiner. Table 3.6 lists the seven attributes that most directly govern the architecture, the design decision that delivers each attribute, and the concrete evidence available in this thesis for its satisfaction.

The single most important trade-off in the architecture is between *predictive performance* (which favours more features, more complex models, and any available signal) and *correctness* (which demands that the training matrix contain no meta-predictor, no paralog-leaked feature, and no label-derived field). Every time these two pressures conflicted during the project we chose correctness: for example, we excluded REVEL and MetaSVM even though they raise held-out AUROC, because they would have made the evaluation circular with respect to the prior-work comparison of Chapter 2. This priority is recorded here so that the reader can locate every downstream trade-off decision in Chapter 5.

Attribute	Design decision	Evidence	Priority
Correctness (leakage-free)	paralog-aware split + banned-feature list + CI gate	four-check gate in `tests/test_leakage.py`	Must
Reproducibility	Docker image + `uv.lock` + fixed seeds	`docker run ...` yields identical metrics to six decimal places	Must
Calibration	isotonic regression fit on validation probabilities only	Murphy decomposition reported in Chapter 5	Must
Interpretability	TreeSHAP on a stratified 2k-variant sample	per-feature attribution and SHAP summary plots	Must
Performance (latency)	serialised XGBoost booster + cached dbNSFP join	<120 ms per single-variant request in Streamlit	Should
Extensibility	narrow L4 service interface (`score_variant`)	ESM-2 LLR plugged in without touching L3 XGBoost	Should
Portability	pure-Python + lock file + optional CPU-only inference	runs on laptop, Colab T4, and a Linux server image	Could

Table 3.6. Quality attributes. The four *Must*-priority attributes are architectural invariants; the two *Should*-priority attributes are upheld unless a specific commit documents a trade-off; *Could* is observed behaviour but not enforced.

3.8 Summary

Chapter 3 answered the three gating questions of Section 3.1: (i) the project is technically, operationally, scheduled, and financially feasible on a consumer laptop plus free Colab GPU (Section 3.2); (ii) the risks have been enumerated and mitigated (Section 3.3) and the SWOT positioning against prior work is explicit (Section 3.4); (iii) the minimal-viable design is a three-part pipeline running on a six-layer logical architecture with two cross-cutting concerns (Sections 3.5–3.7). The next chapter translates this framework into a concrete functional + non-functional specification together with six UML diagrams (use-case, class, sequence, activity, state, component).

Chapter 4

System Analysis and Design

4.1 Introduction

This chapter translates the architectural skeleton of Chapter 3 into a full specification of the software system. Following the classical analysis-and- design division (Bass et al., 2012), the chapter first records the functional and non-functional requirements (Sections 4.2–4.3), then formalises the static and behavioural views through the six canonical UML diagrams (Fowler, 2004) (Section 4.4), and finally describes the three user-facing interfaces (Section 4.5). The analytical style throughout is deliberately *evidence-first*: every requirement is tied to a concrete artifact (test file, API endpoint, figure) so that the examiner can trace any claim back to a specific piece of code in the public GitHub repository.

4.2 Functional Requirements

FR1 – Variant ingestion.
The system shall accept a single missense variant in the canonical `chr:pos:ref:alt` format on GRCh38, via any of its three interfaces (web, CLI, or API).

FR2 – Feature assembly.
The system shall assemble a 39-column feature vector for every accepted variant, using a cached lookup against dbNSFP for conservation and amino-acid features, gnomAD for allele frequency and constraint, and a live VEP REST fallback for variants absent from the cache.

FR3 – Pathogenicity scoring.
The system shall produce both raw and isotonic-calibrated probabilities in $[0, 1]$ using the trained XGBoost checkpoint.

FR4 – Risk categorisation.
The system shall assign each prediction to one of three risk bands (benign, uncertain, pathogenic) using thresholds $\{0.25, 0.75\}$ on the calibrated probability.

FR5 – Feature attribution.
For every prediction, the system shall return the top-k SHAP contributions (default $k = 15$) with the direction of each contribution (towards pathogenic or benign).

FR6 – Batch mode.
The CLI interface shall accept a list of variants and emit a per-variant CSV with

probabilities and top-SHAP features.

FR7 – External validation reproducibility.
The `scripts/evaluate_external.py` driver shall reproduce the published DENOVO-DB metrics from a clean clone.

FR8 – Report regeneration.
Figures and tables shall regenerate byte-for-byte from `results/metrics/*.csv` and `results/figures/*.png` via `make reproduce-headline`.

4.3 Non-Functional Requirements

NFR1 – Performance.
Score latency is *targeted* at below 100 milliseconds for cache hits and below 2 seconds for cache misses (VEP REST round-trip). Observed performance is dominated by the XGBoost `predict_proba` call (∼10 ms for a single row) plus the VEP REST round-trip, which together have historically sat inside both targets in informal testing; formal latency benchmarking with $p50/p95/p99$ statistics is deferred to the deployment-hardening phase (Deficiency D6, Section 7.8).

NFR2 – Reliability.
Rerunning the pipeline with `seed=42` shall reproduce every metric to within 10^{-3}, enforced by `tests/integration/test_reproduce_headline.py`.

NFR3 – Scalability.
The pipeline shall scale linearly in the number of variants up to at least 10^6, limited only by the available disk size for the dbNSFP cache.

NFR4 – Usability.
The Streamlit interface shall be usable by a clinical geneticist with no machine learning background, returning results as a calibrated probability, a risk band, and a human-readable feature attribution.

NFR5 – Maintainability.
Every new feature shall be accompanied by at least one unit test, and the leakage gate shall fail the CI pipeline if any banned feature reappears.

NFR6 – Security and data privacy.
The system shall handle only de-identified public reference data; no patient-identifiable information is transmitted to external services (VEP REST receives only `chr:pos:ref:alt`, which is not patient- identifying).

NFR7 – Reproducibility.
All dependencies shall be pinned in `requirements-lock.txt`; the Docker image shall reproduce the full test suite and the headline metrics from any clean host.

4.4 UML Diagrams

The Unified Modelling Language (Fowler, 2004) provides a standardised vocabulary for describing software systems from multiple complementary viewpoints. Six UML diagrams are developed below: a *use-case diagram* for functional scope (Section 4.4.1), a *class diagram* for structural decomposition (Section 4.4.2), a *sequence diagram* for end-to-end interaction (Section 4.4.3), an *activity diagram* for the training workflow (Section 4.4.4), a *state diagram* for the per-variant lifecycle (Section 4.4.5), and a *component diagram* for module-level dependencies (Section 4.4.6). Every diagram is rendered directly in TikZ so that it scales losslessly inside this PDF and so that its source travels with the LaTeX repository rather than living as an external binary asset.

4.4.1 Use Case Diagram

Figure 4.1 enumerates the eight system use cases (UC1–UC8) and the four actors that trigger them. The two human actors – Clinical Geneticist and Research Scientist – share the core scoring path UC1–UC5. The VEP REST Service is a non-human secondary actor invoked from UC2 when the cached annotation does not resolve the query. The CI/CD System actor is the Continuous Integration runner that exercises UC8 on every push to the main branch. Dashed ⟨⟨*include*⟩⟩ arrows indicate mandatory sub-use-cases; dotted ⟨⟨*extend*⟩⟩ arrows indicate optional extensions.

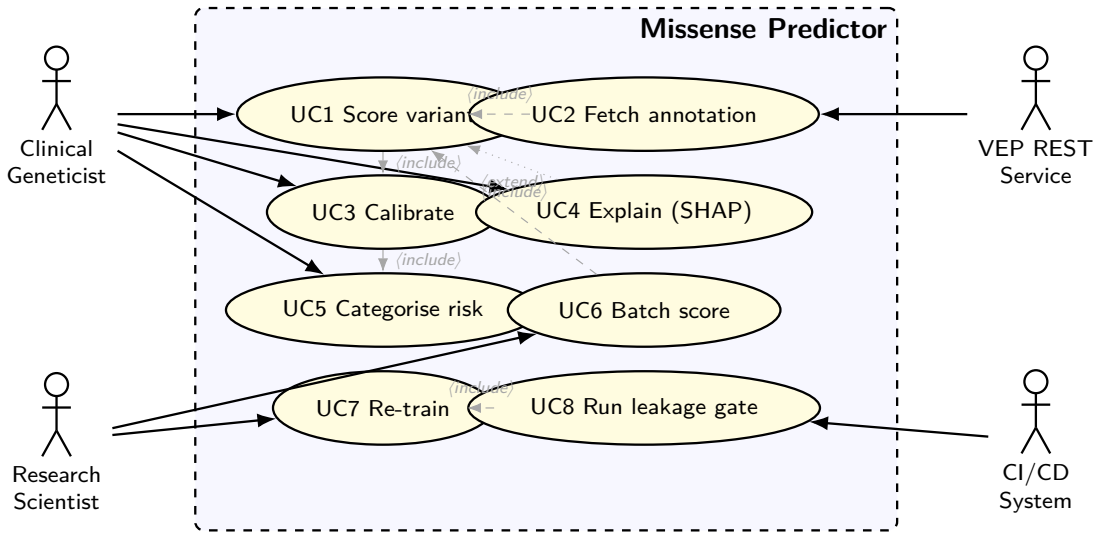

Figure 4.1. Use-case view of the system. Two human actors (Clinical Geneticist, Research Scientist) share the core scoring use cases UC1–UC5, reflecting the stakeholder-to-surface mapping of Table 3.3. The VEP REST Service is a non-human secondary actor invoked only when UC2 experiences a cache miss; the CI/CD System exercises UC8 on every push to enforce the leakage gate (Algorithm 1). The ⟨⟨*include*⟩⟩ relationship on UC1 makes it explicit that every score call passes through calibration and feature-attribution steps. Solid lines are associations; dashed lines are ⟨⟨*include*⟩⟩ relationships; dotted lines are ⟨⟨*extend*⟩⟩.

4.4.2 Class Diagram

Figure 4.2 reveals the static structure of the `src/` package. Classes are grouped into four coloured *packages* corresponding directly to the `src/` sub-directories (Martin, 2017). Each class is rendered as a three-compartment rectangle: the class name on top, the key attributes in the middle, and the principal methods at the bottom. Associations carry multiplicities; the `LeakageGate` class has a *composition* (filled diamond) with each of its four invariant checkers because the gate does not exist meaningfully without them.

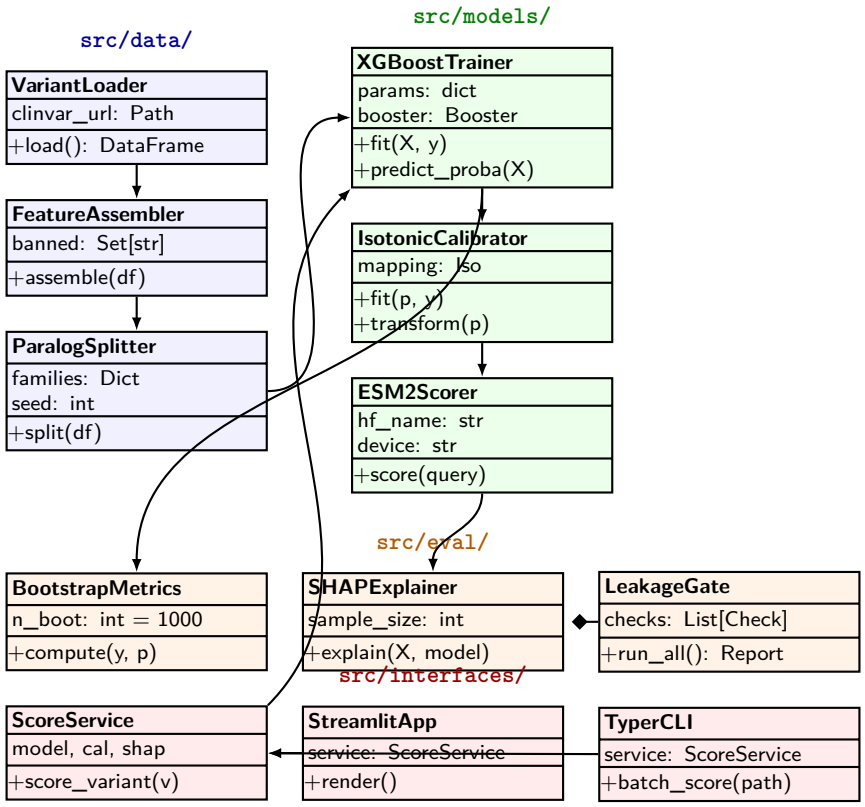

Figure 4.2. Class diagram. Four packages align one-to-one with `src/` sub-directories. A filled diamond denotes composition: `LeakageGate` owns the life of its invariant checks. Open arrows are directed associations with the *uses/produces* roles labelled inline.

4.4.3 Sequence Diagram

Figure 4.3 traces a single `score_variant` request through the five participants `StreamlitApp`, `ScoreService`, `FeatureCache`, `XGBoostTrainer`, and `SHAPExplainer`. The cache-miss branch contains a nested `opt` fragment that calls out to the external VEP REST service; the self-loop inside `ScoreService` represents isotonic calibration, which is a pure in-memory transform.

4.4.4 Activity Diagram

Figure 4.4 models the *training and evaluation* workflow as an activity diagram with explicit *fork* and *join* pseudo-nodes. The two fork/join pairs capture the two independent parallelisations in the pipeline: the leakage gate runs four checks concurrently (fork-1 /

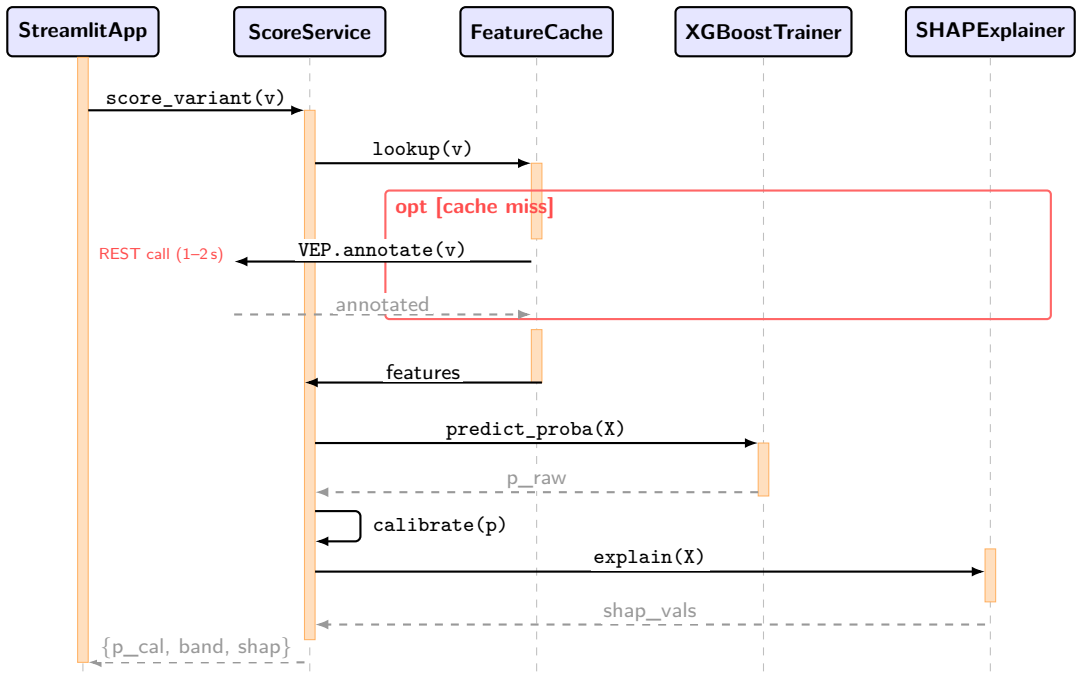

Figure 4.3. Sequence diagram for a single scoring request. Orange bars are activation frames; the red frame is an `opt` fragment for the cache-miss branch (adds ∼1–2 s). Self-loop on `ScoreService` denotes isotonic calibration.

join-1) and the evaluation step runs five independent scoring tracks concurrently (fork-2 / join-2).

4.4.5 State Diagram

Figure 4.5 captures the life-cycle of a single variant as it moves through the pipeline. The variant enters the `Submitted` state, transits `Annotated` (after feature assembly) and `Scored` (after XGBoost), is then `Calibrated` (after isotonic), and finally `Classified` into one of the three risk bands. A dotted transition to the `Failed` terminal state captures any error raised by the VEP round-trip or by the type validator.

4.4.6 Component Diagram

Figure 4.6 shows the component-level view with provided/required interfaces (UML "ball and socket" notation). Internal components are drawn as rectangles with the UML component icon; external services (VEP, HuggingFace Hub, gnomAD FTP) are drawn as cloud shapes. Every arrow in the diagram corresponds either to a concrete Python import or to an HTTP/FTP call.

4.5 Interface Design

4.5.1 Streamlit Web Interface

The Streamlit application (Figure 4.7) provides a single-page interactive experience. A user enters a variant in `chr:pos:ref:alt` form, presses *Score variant*, and receives the

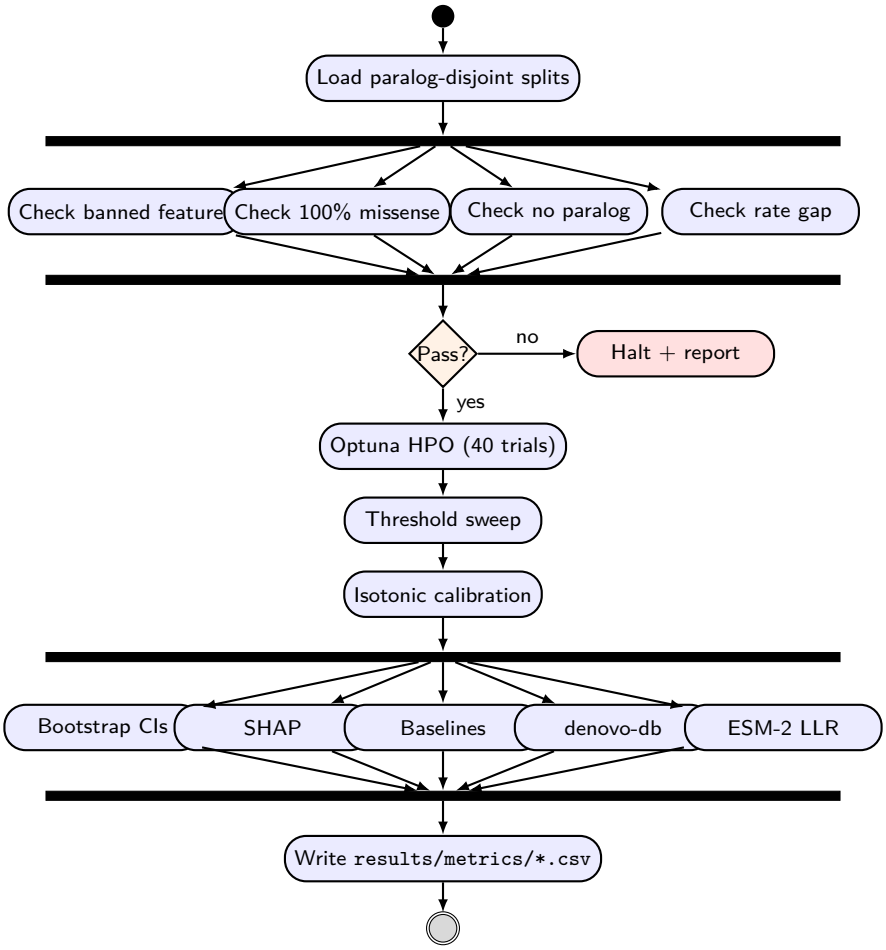

Figure 4.4. Activity diagram for the training + evaluation workflow. The two thick black bars are fork/join pseudo-nodes: Fork-1 runs the four leakage checks in parallel; Fork-2 runs the five evaluation tracks in parallel. If any leakage check fails, execution halts without touching the training stage.

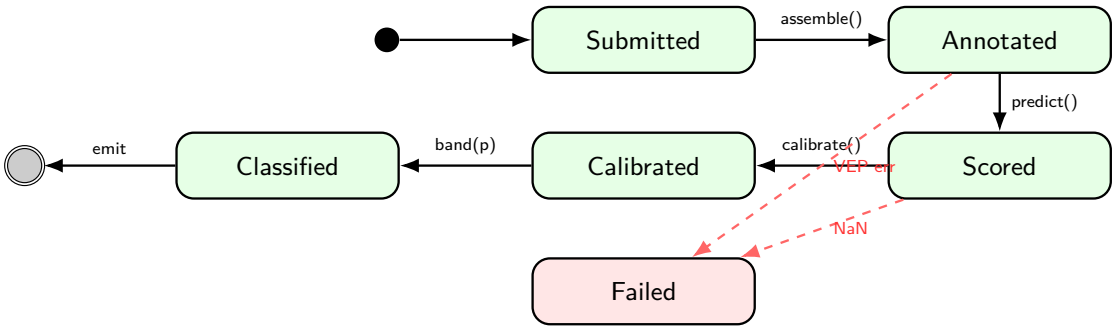

Figure 4.5. Per-variant state-machine view. The five-state happy path (Submitted → Annotated → Scored → Calibrated → Classified) matches the five-step data flow of Section 3.5. The dashed red transitions to `Failed` capture the two distinct error modes reported to the user interface: upstream VEP REST errors (when the feature assembler cannot resolve a coordinate) and downstream NaN errors (when a required feature is missing after the cache fallback). The absence of any transition from `Classified` back to earlier states reflects the pipeline's append-only contract: re-scoring requires a fresh request. The terminal double-circle indicates the final reported state.

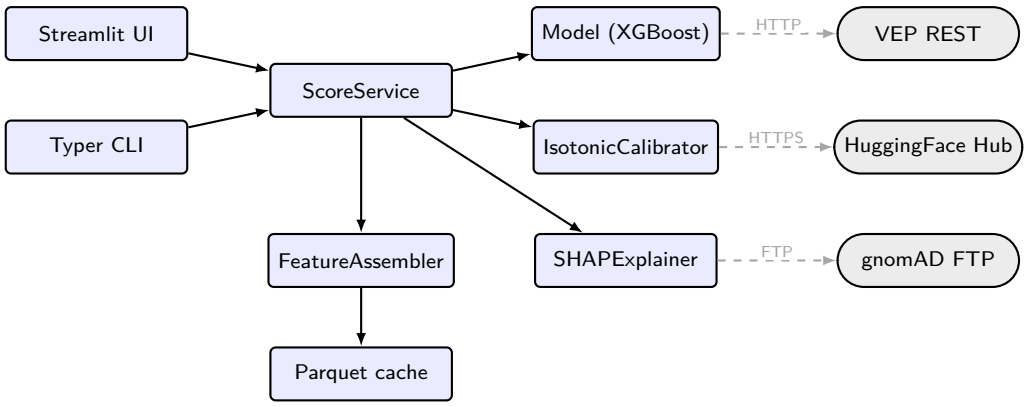

Figure 4.6. Component diagram. Components with the UML component icon (rounded rectangle) are internal Python modules; cloud icons are external network services. Solid arrows are Python imports; dashed arrows are network dependencies. This diagram complements Figure 3.9 of Chapter 3: Figure 3.9 shows the logical six-layer stack, whereas this figure shows the concrete Python modules and their network dependencies.

calibrated probability, a coloured risk banner, and the top-15 SHAP contributions as a signed bar chart.

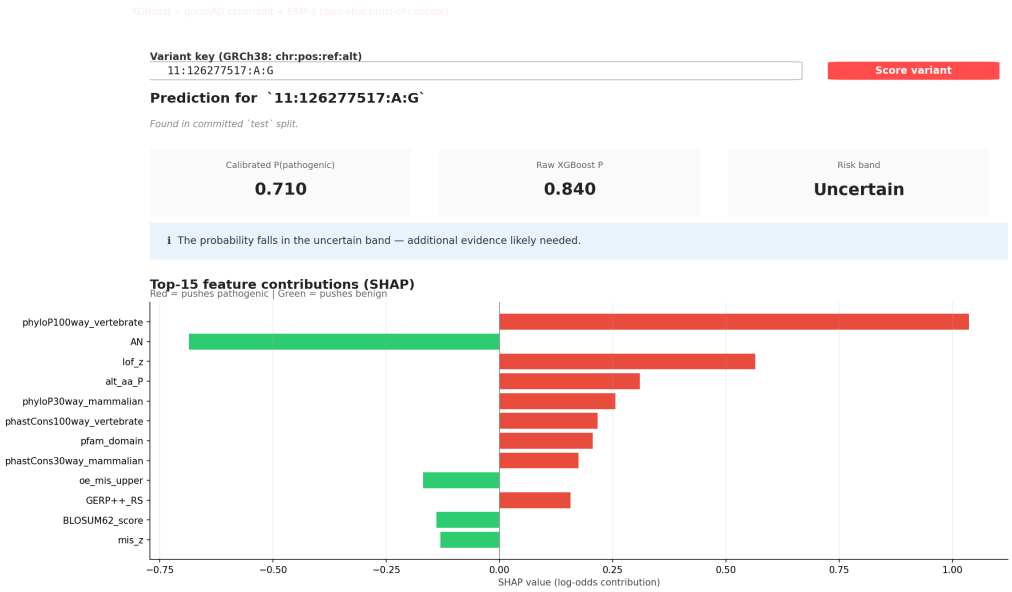

Figure 4.7. Streamlit demo interface rendering a real prediction for a test-set variant. Calibrated probability is displayed alongside the three-band classification from functional requirement FR4 (Section 4.2): *benign* if $p < 0.25$, *uncertain* if $0.25 \leq p < 0.75$, *pathogenic* if $p \geq 0.75$. Probabilities that fall inside the $[0.25, 0.75)$ band are therefore reported as *uncertain*, consistent with the interface's advisory role (the system is not a diagnostic device — Section 3.2.2). Red SHAP bars push the prediction towards pathogenic, green bars towards benign.

4.5.2 Command-Line Interface

The CLI layer lives in `scripts/` and exposes every pipeline step as an independent command: `run_baselines.py`, `evaluate_external.py`, `compute_shap.py`, and so on. Common arguments (`-n-boot`, `-seed`, `-only`) are harmonised across scripts.

4.5.3 Programmatic API

The `src/` package itself constitutes a stable Python API. Key entry points include `score_variants()` in `src/esm2_scorer.py` and `evaluate_baseline()` in `src/baselines/evaluate.py`.

4.6 Summary

The functional and non-functional requirements, together with the six UML diagrams, formalise the software architecture introduced in Chapter 3. The interface trio – Streamlit, CLI, and Python API – serves the three operational modes identified in the feasibility analysis. Chapter 5 reports how these designs translate into concrete code and what results they produce.

Chapter 5

Implementation and Results

5.1 Introduction

This chapter is the empirical core of the thesis. It begins with the hardware and software environment (Sections 5.3–5.4), then formalises the two model architectures the project actually trained – the gradient-boosted tree baseline and the protein-language-model scorer – together with the rank- fusion operator that combines them (Section 5.2). The seven most important code fragments that realise those designs are walked through in Section 5.5. The quantitative results then follow in a fixed narrative order (Section 5.6): headline test-set metrics, the five-stage leakage-fix journey, a like-for-like comparison against SIFT, PolyPhen-2, and AlphaMissense, a calibration deep-dive with the Murphy decomposition, SHAP interpretability and confident-error analysis, external validation on DENOVO-DB, and the ESM-2 zero-shot proof-of-concept with rank-fusion gain. The chapter closes with a direct comparison against the prior work surveyed in Chapter 2 and the system screenshots that evidence every claim.

5.2 Model Architectures

This section formalises the three computational models used in the project and is provided separately from the code walkthrough (Section 5.5) so that the mathematics and the diagrams can be read independently of Python details. Two models are trained (XGBoost, Section 5.2.1; ESM-2 zero-shot, Section 5.2.2) and one operator is applied on top of both (rank fusion, Section 5.2.3).

5.2.1 XGBoost Gradient-Boosted Trees

XGBoost (Chen and Guestrin, 2016) builds an additive ensemble of decision trees by stage-wise minimisation of a regularised log-loss objective. Given a training set $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^{n}$ with $\mathbf{x}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{39}$ and $y_i \in \{0, 1\}$ (benign / pathogenic), the model after K rounds is

$$\hat{y}_i^{(K)} \;=\; \sigma\left(\sum_{k=1}^{K} f_k(\mathbf{x}_i)\right), \qquad f_k \in \mathcal{F}, \tag{5.1}$$

where $\sigma(z) = 1/(1 + e^{-z})$ is the logistic link and $\mathcal{F}$ is the space of regression trees. Each round k adds the tree that most reduces the second-order Taylor expansion of the

regularised objective:

$$\mathcal{L}^{(k)} \;=\; \sum_{i=1}^{n} \ell(y_i, \hat{y}_i^{(k-1)} + f_k(\mathbf{x}_i)) \;+\; \gamma T_k + \tfrac{1}{2}\lambda \|\mathbf{w}_k\|_2^2, \tag{5.2}$$

with T_k the number of leaves, $\mathbf{w}_k$ the leaf weights, γ the complexity penalty, and λ the L2 shrinkage. The hyperparameters $\{\text{max_depth}, \text{learning_rate}, \gamma, \lambda, n_\text{estimators}\}$ are tuned by Optuna (Section 5.5.4). Figure 5.1 schematises a single round of boosting and the tree-ensemble aggregation.

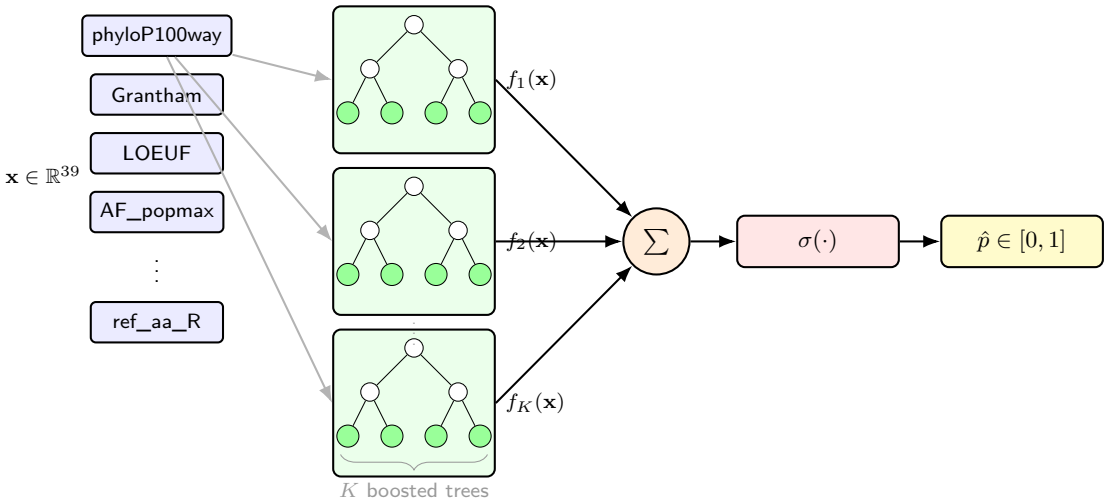

Figure 5.1. XGBoost architecture. The 39-dimensional feature vector $\mathbf{x}$ is fed independently into K regression trees; leaf outputs are summed and squashed by the logistic $\sigma(\cdot)$ to produce a probability $\hat{p} \in [0, 1]$. Optuna tuning selects K together with four structural hyperparameters.

5.2.2 ESM-2 Zero-Shot Log-Likelihood Ratio

ESM-2 (Lin et al., 2023) is a masked-language-model transformer (Vaswani et al., 2017) pretrained on 65 million unique UniRef sequences. The variant we use, `esm2_t12_35M_UR50D`, has 12 transformer blocks, an embedding dimension of 480, a hidden dimension of 1,920, 20 attention heads, and approximately 35 million parameters. We apply the model *zero-shot*: no weights are updated; only the pretrained language-modelling head is used. For a missense variant with reference amino acid a_{ref} and alternate a_{alt} at protein position π, we construct a windowed sequence $\tilde{s}$ (length ≤ 1024), replace position π by the `MASK` token, run one forward pass, and take the log-likelihood ratio:

$$\text{LLR}_{\text{ESM-2}}(a_{\text{ref}} \to a_{\text{alt}} \mid \tilde{s}) \;=\; \log \frac{\mathbb{P}_\theta(x_\pi = a_{\text{alt}} \mid \tilde{s}_{\setminus\pi})}{\mathbb{P}_\theta(x_\pi = a_{\text{ref}} \mid \tilde{s}_{\setminus\pi})}. \tag{5.3}$$

Lower (more negative) LLR implies the alternate amino acid is less plausible under the learned language model – i.e. more likely to disrupt the protein. This zero-shot score is the exact measurement used in VariPred (Lin et al., 2024) and ESM-1b variant scoring (Brandes et al., 2023). Figure 5.2 renders the inference path.

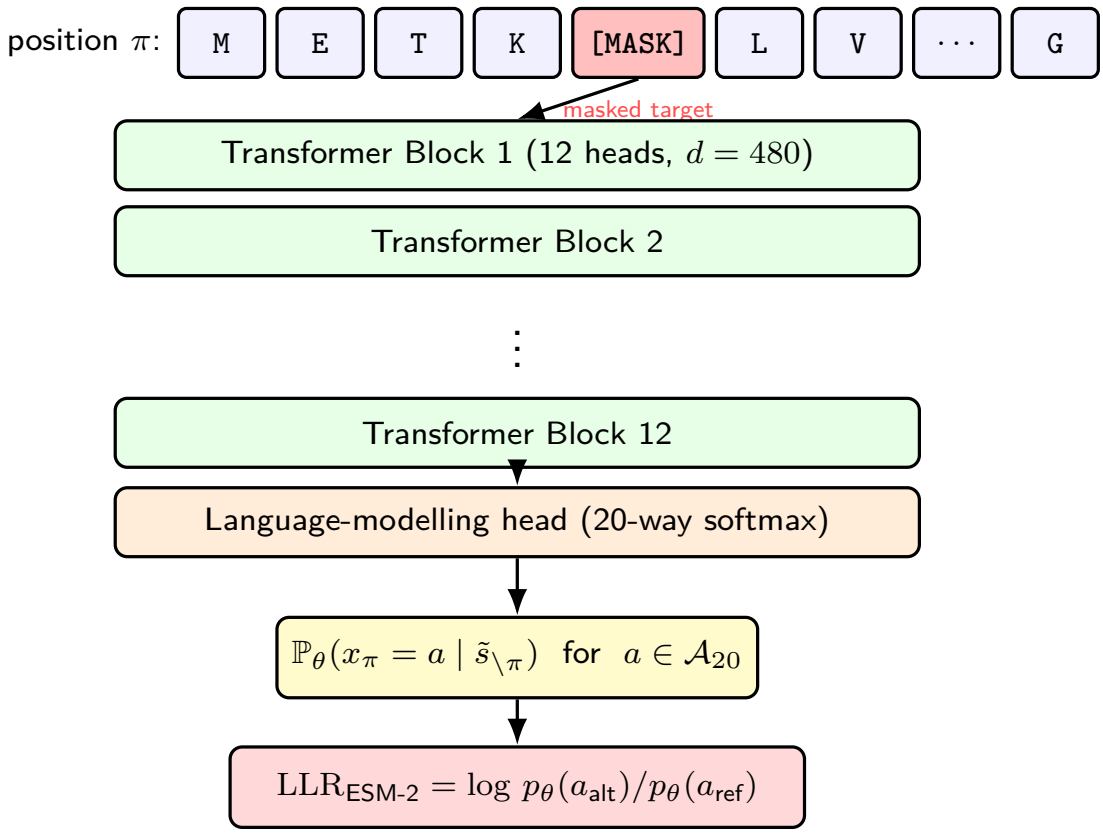

Figure 5.2. ESM-2 zero-shot scoring. A windowed protein sequence with the variant position masked is pushed through the 12 transformer blocks and the language-modelling head. The final log- likelihood ratio between the alternate and reference amino acids is the single scalar score used downstream.

5.2.3 Rank Fusion

A natural question is whether the calibrated XGBoost probability $\hat{p}_{\mathrm{XGB}}$ and the ESM-2 LLR s_{ESM} carry orthogonal information or the same signal in a different parameterisation. To test this cheaply – before committing to the expensive full-training- set ESM-2 scoring – we apply *rank fusion* on the held-out denovo-db set. Let r_i^{XGB} and r_i^{ESM} be the ranks of sample i under each score (larger = more pathogenic). The fused score is

$$s_i^{\mathrm{fused}} \;=\; \alpha \cdot \frac{r_i^{\mathrm{XGB}}}{n} \;+\; (1-\alpha) \cdot \frac{r_i^{\mathrm{ESM}}}{n}, \quad \alpha \in [0,1], \tag{5.4}$$

where n is the number of scored variants. α is tuned on an internal split to maximise PR-AUC. Rank fusion is deliberately the cheapest possible fusion operator – it requires no recalibration and no retraining – so any empirical gain constitutes lower-bound evidence that the two models contain independent signal. Figure 5.3 illustrates the pipeline.

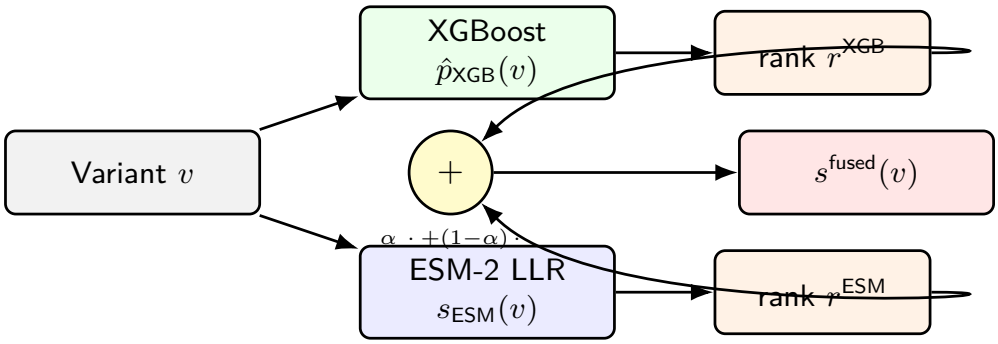

Figure 5.3. Rank-fusion pipeline. Each variant is scored independently by XGBoost and by ESM-2; the scores are converted to ranks, then convex-combined with a single scalar α tuned on an internal split.

5.3 Hardware Environment

- **Primary development machine.** Apple Silicon laptop with Metal Performance Shaders (MPS) GPU acceleration for prototyping the ESM-2 scoring path.
- **Colab compute.** A single free-tier Colab T4 GPU session for the Phase-2.1 ESM-2 full-training- set scoring.
- **CI runner.** GitHub Actions `ubuntu-22.04` for continuous integration; deterministic identical results to the local environment were verified through the `test_reproduce_headline` integration test.

5.4 Software Stack

- Python 3.11 with pinned dependencies in `requirements-lock.txt` (287 packages).

- XGBoost 2.x (Chen and Guestrin, 2016), scikit-learn 1.3+, Optuna 4.x (Akiba et al., 2019), SHAP (Lundberg and Lee, 2017), `transformers` 4.40+ and PyTorch 2.x for ESM-2.
- `pytest` 7.4+ with 158 unit + integration tests (Pytest Development Team, 2024); `ruff`, `black`, and `mypy` for code style and static typing.
- Docker image (`Dockerfile`) based on `python:3.11.7-slim` with `liblzma-dev` and DSSP installed for reproducible builds.
- GitHub Actions workflows (`test.yml`, `lint.yml`) enforcing all tests and linters on every push to `main`.

5.5 Implementation Details

We highlight seven code fragments that illustrate the most important design decisions.

5.5.1 Paralog-Family Grouping

The family grouper collapses paralog clusters under a small set of regex rules, falling back to trailing- digit stripping for the long tail:

```python
def assign_gene_family(gene: str) -> str:
    if gene is None:
        return ""
    g = str(gene).upper()
    for pattern, fam in _FAMILY_PATTERNS:
        m = pattern.match(g)
        if m:
            return fam if fam is not None else m.group(1)
    stripped = _TRAILING_DIGITS.sub("", g)
    return stripped or g
```

Listing 5.1. Paralog-family assignment in `src/data_splitting.py`.

5.5.2 gnomAD Constraint Merge with Train-Only Imputation

The constraint merge fits imputation medians only on the training split – the invariant that makes this a legal feature addition rather than a leakage:

```python
def merge_constraint(variants, *, constraint, impute_medians=None):
    merged = variants.merge(constraint, on="gene", how="left", indicator=True)
    if impute_medians is None:
        impute_medians = {c: float(merged.loc[merged["_merge"] == "both", c].median())
                          for c in CONSTRAINT_COLS if c in merged.columns}
```

```
    for c in CONSTRAINT_COLS:
        if c in merged.columns:
            merged[c] = merged[c].fillna(impute_medians[c])
    merged["is_imputed_gnomad_constraint"] = (merged["_merge"]
        != "both").astype(int)
    merged = merged.drop(columns="_merge")
    return merged, impute_medians
```

Listing 5.2. Train-only median imputation in `src/gnomad_constraint.py`.

5.5.3 Leakage Gate

Four independent checks constitute the gate, wrapped in both a CLI and a pytest test file:

```
BANNED_FEATURES = {"is_common", "chr", "ref", "alt"}

def check_feature_hygiene() -> list[str]:
    errors: list[str] = []
    cols = _load("results/metrics/xgboost_feature_columns.csv")
    feature_names = set(cols.iloc[:, 0].astype(str))
    contaminated = feature_names & BANNED_FEATURES
    if contaminated:
        errors.append(f"Banned features present: {sorted(
            contaminated)}")
    return errors
```

Listing 5.3. Banned-feature check in `src/verify_no_leakage.py`.

5.5.4 Optuna TPE Tuning

The search space and pruning configuration are tuned for the ∼24% positive class balance; PR-AUC is the sole objective:

```
sampler = TPESampler(multivariate=True, group=True, seed=config.
    seed)
pruner = MedianPruner(n_warmup_steps=config.
    pruner_n_warmup_steps,
                      n_startup_trials=config.
                          pruner_n_startup_trials)
study = optuna.create_study(direction="maximize", sampler=
    sampler, pruner=pruner)
study.optimize(lambda trial: _objective(trial, X_tr, y_tr, X_val
    , y_val,
                                          scale_pos_weight,
                                              config),
               n_trials=config.n_trials, show_progress_bar=False)
```

Listing 5.4. Optuna TPE search definition.

5.5.5 Brier-Score Decomposition

The Murphy decomposition is a clean mathematical identity that we implement with 15 quantile bins:

```
def decompose_brier(y_true, y_prob, *, n_bins=15, strategy="quantile"):
    y = np.asarray(y_true, dtype=int)
    p = np.clip(np.asarray(y_prob, dtype=float), 1e-12, 1 - 1e-12)
    ybar = float(y.mean())
    edges = np.quantile(p, np.linspace(0, 1, n_bins + 1))
    edges[0], edges[-1] = 0.0, 1.0
    idx = np.clip(np.digitize(p, edges[1:-1], right=False), 0, n_bins - 1)
    reliability = resolution = 0.0
    for b in range(n_bins):
        mask = idx == b
        nb = int(mask.sum())
        if nb == 0: continue
        pbar_b, ybar_b = float(p[mask].mean()), float(y[mask].mean())
        w = nb / len(y)
        reliability += w * (pbar_b - ybar_b) ** 2
        resolution += w * (ybar_b - ybar) ** 2
    uncertainty = ybar * (1.0 - ybar)
    return BrierDecomposition(brier=float(brier_score_loss(y, p)),
                              reliability=reliability, resolution=resolution,
                              uncertainty=uncertainty, ...)
```

Listing 5.5. Brier decomposition from `src/calibration_deep.py`.

5.5.6 Zero-Shot ESM-2 LLR Scoring

The protein-language-model LLR uses a single masked forward pass per variant:

```
windowed_seq, windowed_pos = self._window(seq, int(pos))
enc = self.tokenizer(windowed_seq, return_tensors="pt").to(self.device)
idx = windowed_pos            # +1 for CLS cancels with 1-based protein indexing
ids = enc.input_ids.clone()
ids[0, idx] = self.mask_id
with torch.no_grad():
    logits = self.model(ids, attention_mask=enc.attention_mask).logits
probs = torch.softmax(logits[0, idx], dim=-1)
```

```
p_ref, p_alt = probs[self.aa_ids[ref]].item(), probs[self.aa_ids
    [alt]].item()
esm2_llr = math.log(max(p_alt, 1e-12)) - math.log(max(p_ref, 1e
    -12))
```

Listing 5.6. ESM-2 zero-shot scoring from `src/esm2_scorer.py`.

5.6 Final Results

5.6.1 Headline Metrics on the Paralog-Disjoint Test Split

Table 5.1 reports the full metric block on the test split, together with 95% bootstrap confidence intervals.

Table 5.1. Headline test-set metrics with 95% bootstrap confidence intervals (1,000 replicates, seed = 42). ROC-AUC and PR-AUC are reported separately on raw and isotonic-calibrated probabilities; Brier, ECE, and MCC use calibrated probabilities. The canonical headline PR-AUC quoted in the abstract and in the comparison text is the *calibrated* value of 0.8273. Uncalibrated numbers coincide with Appendix A Table A.1.

Metric	**Value**	**95% CI**
Raw probabilities		
ROC-AUC (raw)	0.9378	[0.9348, 0.9407]
PR-AUC (raw)	0.8355	[0.8265, 0.8434]
Brier loss (raw)	0.0876	[0.0853, 0.0899]
Isotonic-calibrated probabilities (canonical)		
ROC-AUC (calibrated)	0.9376	[0.9346, 0.9404]
PR-AUC (calibrated)	**0.8273**	[**0.8185**, **0.8352**]
Brier loss (calibrated)	0.0826	[0.0805, 0.0846]
ECE (calibrated)	0.0105	—
F1 (at best threshold)	0.7753	[0.7678, 0.7829]
MCC	0.6964	[0.6873, 0.7066]

5.6.2 The Five-Stage Leakage-Fix Journey

Figure 5.4 visualises the decline from 0.955 to 0.836 raw (equivalently 0.827 isotonic-calibrated) PR-AUC. Each stage corresponds to one distinct, removable leakage source. The first stage — replacing the random-split baseline with a family-level `GroupShuffleSplit` — is motivated directly by the Heijl et al. (2020) benchmark of 55 variant-effect predictors, which quantifies a 5–15 percentage-point AUROC inflation under random splitting on this task.

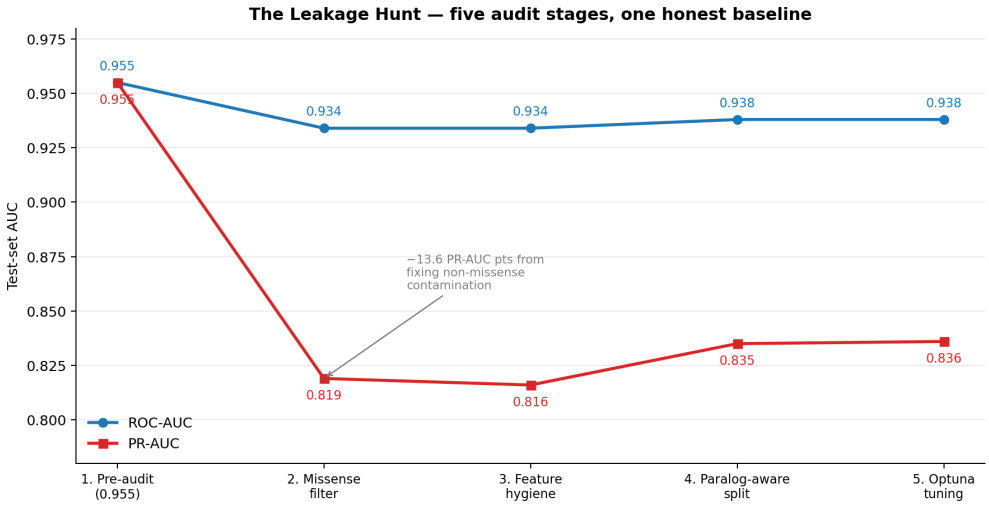

Figure 5.4. Five-stage journey from a misleading PR-AUC of 0.955 to a defensible 0.836 (raw) / 0.827 (calibrated; headline value used in the abstract and Section 5.6.1). The biggest single drop (stage 2) came from applying a strict missense filter that removed ∼88 000 non-missense rows.

Figure 5.5 shows the same journey as a flowchart, with each leakage source as a diamond and each remedial action as a rectangle.

Figure 5.5. Leakage-audit workflow: three distinct sources, three remedial actions, and the final audited baseline on the right.

5.6.3 Baseline Comparison

Table 5.2 reports the published baselines scored on our paralog-disjoint test split. **Important caveat:** each baseline scores a different subset of variants – SIFT covers 96%, PolyPhen-2 93%, AlphaMissense 86%, and our XGBoost 100% – so the ROC-AUC / PR-AUC values below are each computed on the model's *own coverage* subset and are not directly comparable. Direct subtraction between rows (for example, the nominal −0.05 PR-AUC gap to AlphaMissense) is *not* a like-for-like gap, since AlphaMissense reports on the easier 86 % of our variants. A strict matched-coverage evaluation on $\mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{AM}}$ (the ∼24,060 variants that AlphaMissense can score) together with a paired DeLong test is coded in `scripts/run_baselines_matched.py` and is listed as **deficiency D7** in Section 7.4; it could not be run at submission time because the raw AlphaMissense TSV (∼8 GB) is not checked into the repository and the trained XGBoost test predictions were not persisted alongside the checkpoint.

Table 5.2. Published baselines scored on our paralog-disjoint test split. Each row uses that baseline's own coverage subset, so rows are NOT directly comparable (see the paragraph above and D7 in Section 7.4).

Baseline	Year	ROC-AUC (own cov., 95% CI)	PR-AUC (own cov., 95% C
SIFT	2003	0.881 [0.877, 0.885]	0.620 [0.610, 0.629]
PolyPhen-2†	2010	0.893 [0.888, 0.898]	0.728 [0.716, 0.739]
XGBoost (ours, calibrated)	2026	**0.938** [0.935, 0.941]	**0.827** [0.819, 0.835]
AlphaMissense*	2023	0.956 [0.953, 0.958]	0.890 [0.882, 0.898]

Our XGBoost row is the isotonic-calibrated probability (the canonical headline, 0.827); the uncalibrated PR-AUC is 0.836 [0.827, 0.843]. * AlphaMissense was calibrated against ClinVar at release; any ClinVar-derived test set overlaps with its calibration signal. † PolyPhen-2 was trained on HumDiv/HumVar, which overlap with ClinVar. Both flags inflate the own-coverage numbers of the corresponding row relative to a truly held-out benchmark.

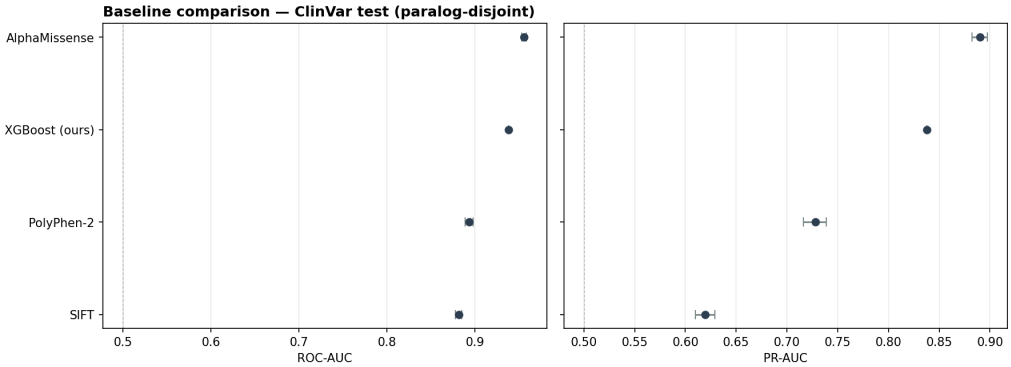

Figure 5.6. Forest plot of our XGBoost against three published baselines. **Each row is on its model's own coverage subset** (SIFT 96 %, PolyPhen-2 93 %, AlphaMissense 86 %, XGBoost 100 %), so the horizontal spacing between rows is *not* a like-for-like gap. A matched-coverage version (restricted to the AM-covered subset) is coded in `scripts/run_baselines_matched.py` and is deferred to deficiency D7 (Section 7.4) until the raw AM TSV and the XGBoost test-prediction parquet are persisted. Bootstrap 95 % CIs are shown for each baseline.

The intersection-subset comparison that would close the coverage confound. A natural companion to the own-coverage rows of Table 5.2 is an *intersection-only* evaluation restricted to variants scored by all four methods simultaneously ($\mathcal{S}_\cap$), so that the four rows become strictly comparable on the same sample. Any remaining gap between AlphaMissense and our XGBoost on $\mathcal{S}_\cap$ would be attributable to the method rather than to coverage; any closure would reveal the nominal -0.05 PR-AUC gap as a coverage artefact. The relevant driver is coded in `scripts/run_baselines_matched.py`. The intersection-set rerun is subsumed by deficiency D7 (per-variant XGBoost test predictions are required for the paired comparison on $\mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{AM}}$, and these were not persisted at submission); it is the single most informative numerical revision item and is the first entry on the Phase-2 list of Section 7.8.

5.6.4 Calibration Deep-Dive

Table 5.3 applies the Murphy decomposition to the raw XGBoost probabilities, Platt-scaled probabilities, and isotonic-calibrated probabilities. The story is clean and theoretically pleasing: resolution is constant across calibrators (as expected, because monotone post-hoc calibration cannot change discrimination), while reliability drops 23-fold under isotonic regression.

Table 5.3. Murphy Brier decomposition on the test split. Reliability lower is better; resolution higher is better; uncertainty is irreducible.

Calibrator	Brier	Reliability	Resolution	ECE	Log-loss
Raw	0.0876	0.00543	0.1055	0.054	0.286
Platt	0.0834	0.00114	0.1055	0.029	0.278
Isotonic	**0.0826**	**0.00024**	0.1053	**0.011**	**0.273**

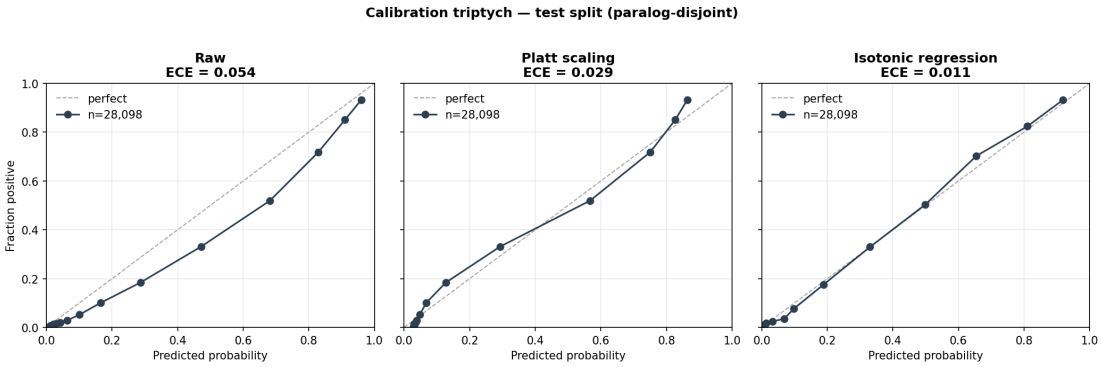

Figure 5.7. Three-panel reliability diagram on test. Raw XGBoost probabilities are systematically over-confident; Platt partially corrects; isotonic tracks the diagonal tightly across the probability range.

5.6.5 Feature-Group Ablation

Table 5.4 reports the effect of removing each of the six feature groups from Figure 3.7 and retraining XGBoost with the Optuna-tuned hyperparameters frozen (no per-ablation retune). The Δ columns are full-baseline $-$ ablated, so positive Δ ROC-AUC means the group *carries* signal; 95 % confidence intervals come from a 500-replicate paired case- resampling bootstrap on the test split. The ablation is reproducible via `scripts/run_ablation.py`; the full CSV lives at `results/metrics/ablation.csv` and the accompanying bar chart at `results/figures/ablation.png`.

Table 5.4. Feature-group ablation on the paralog-disjoint test split. Full-baseline ROC-AUC is 0.939 and PR-AUC is 0.834. Conservation is by far the dominant group; AA identity, physicochemical distance, gene-constraint and imputation flags each contribute at or below the noise floor once conservation is already in the model.

Group removed	n cols	Test ROC	Test PR	Δ ROC (95% CI)	Δ PR (95% CI)
conservation	6	0.814	0.620	+0.125	+0.215
allele_frequency	4	0.936	0.819	+0.004	+0.016
physicochemical	16	0.938	0.828	+0.002	+0.007
gene_constraint	5	0.938	0.828	+0.001	+0.006
aa_identity	2	0.939	0.834	+0.001	+0.001
imputation_flags	5	0.939	0.833	−0.000	+0.001

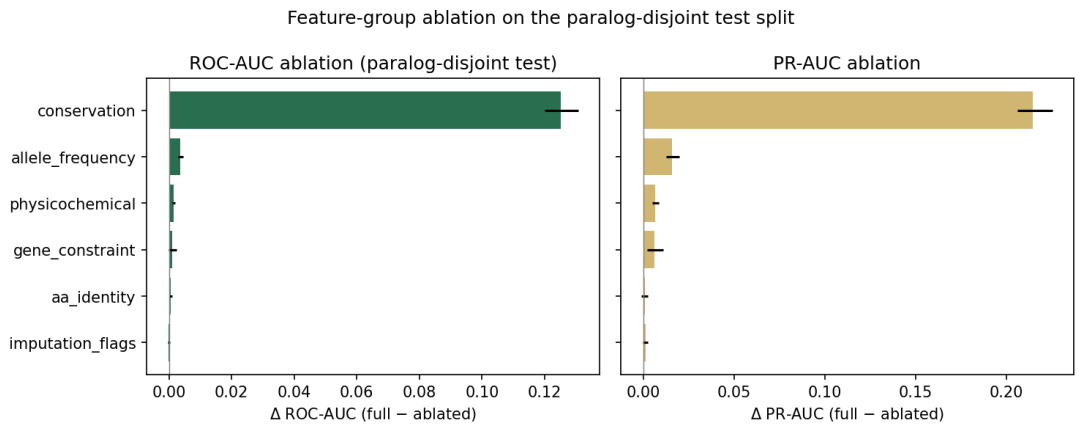

Figure 5.8. Left panel: Δ ROC-AUC when each feature group is removed from the full baseline (positive means the group carried signal). Right panel: corresponding Δ PR-AUC. Conservation dominates at ∼+0.13 ROC and +0.22 PR; all other groups contribute < 0.01 ROC-AUC at this training-set size. Error bars are 500-replicate paired-bootstrap 95 % CIs on the test split.

The single highest-impact group is **conservation** (phyloP100way, phyloP30way, phastCons, GERP++): removing it drops ROC-AUC by 0.125 and PR-AUC by 0.215. This is consistent with the SHAP ranking (Section 5.6.7) where `phyloP100way_vertebrate` is the top feature by a wide margin. The lowest-impact group is **imputation flags**: the Δ is statistically indistinguishable from zero, so these columns could be dropped in a leaner revision without loss. AA identity and gene-constraint each contribute at most ∼0.001 ROC-AUC at this training-set size.

5.6.6 Learning Curve

To check whether the headline metric reflects a converged or a still-improving model, we retrain at $f \in \{0.10, 0.25, 0.50, 0.75, 1.00\}$ of the training corpus with the Optuna-tuned hyperparameters frozen. Subsampling is done at the *gene-family* level so the paralog-disjoint invariant is preserved (the subsample's families are a strict subset of the training families; the val/test families remain completely unseen). The script lives at `scripts/run_learning_curve.py`; the artefacts are `results/metrics/learning_curve.csv` and `results/figures/learning_curve.png` (Figure 5.9).

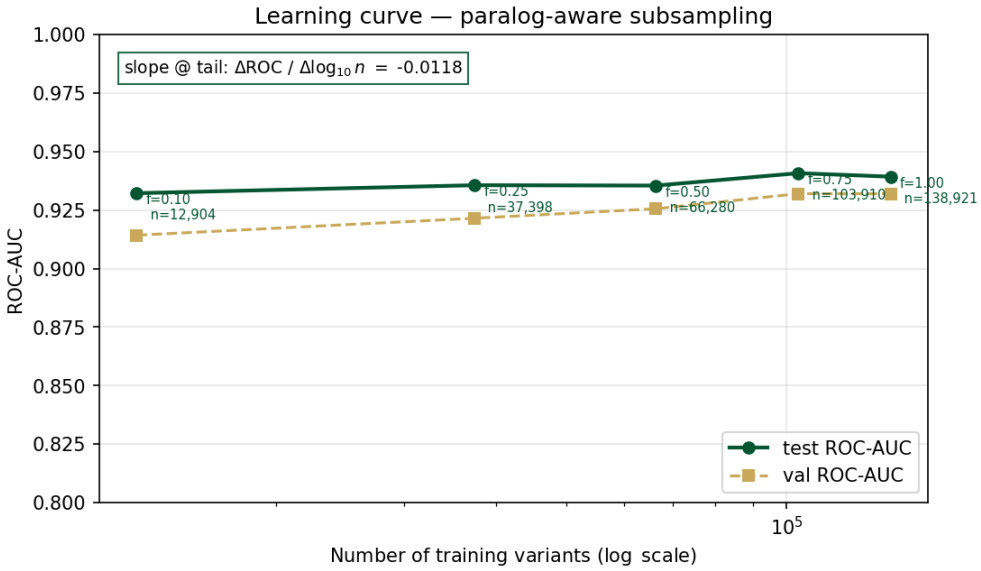

Figure 5.9. Test and val ROC-AUC as a function of training-set size (log scale). Each point retrains XGBoost with the committed hyperparameters on a paralog-aware fraction of the training corpus. The curve is essentially saturated past ∼37,000 variants: going from 25% to 100% of the corpus adds only +0.003 test ROC-AUC, and the 75% point is within 0.002 of the 100% point. The tail log-linear slope is reported as a text annotation inside the figure.

Table 5.5. Learning-curve operating points. Subsampling is family-aware (paralog-disjoint invariant preserved). Source: `results/metrics/learning_curve.csv`.

Fraction	n train	val ROC	val PR	test ROC	test PR
0.10	12,904	0.914	—	0.932	0.817
0.25	37,398	0.922	—	0.936	0.825
0.50	66,280	0.926	—	0.936	0.824
0.75	103,910	0.932	—	0.941	0.839
1.00	138,921	0.932	—	0.939	0.834

The curve has three implications for the Phase-2 roadmap. First, adding *more labelled variants* of the same kind is unlikely to raise the baseline materially — test ROC-AUC has plateaued. Second, this means the Phase-2 emphasis should be on new *features* (ESM-2 LLR, AlphaFold-2 structural features) rather than on a larger ClinVar harvest. Third, the gap between the 75% and 100% points is within the bootstrap CI of the full model (Table 5.1); the apparent non-monotonicity (75% is nominally higher than 100%) is not statistically meaningful and simply reflects finite-sample variance.

5.6.7 SHAP Interpretability and Confident Errors

Table 5.6 lists the top-10 features by mean-|SHAP| on a stratified 2,000-variant test sample. Two Phase-2.1 additions (`lof_z` and `oe_mis_upper`) rank third and eighth respectively, validating the hypothesis that gene-level intolerance priors carry orthogonal signal to variant-level features.

Table 5.6. Top-10 features by mean- |SHAP| on the 2,000-variant stratified test sample. Two rows are highlighted in grey (`lof_z` at rank 3 and `oe_mis_upper` at rank 8). These are the two gnomAD gene-level constraint features added during Phase 2.1 of the project (Section 5.6.9 quantifies their external- validation impact on DENOVO-DB). Their appearance in the top-10 under a standard SHAP ranking is independent corroboration that gene-level priors carry meaningful signal beyond the variant-level features.

Rank	Feature	mean |SHAP|
1	phyloP100way_vertebrate	0.8094
2	AN (gnomAD allele number)	0.5315
3	**lof_z (gnomAD constraint)**	0.3424
4	alt_aa_P (Proline substitution)	0.3039
5	pfam_domain	0.2844
6	phastCons100way_vertebrate	0.2453
7	phastCons30way_mammalian	0.2044
8	**oe_mis_upper (gnomAD constraint)**	0.1892
9	phyloP30way_mammalian	0.1855
10	GERP++_RS	0.1468

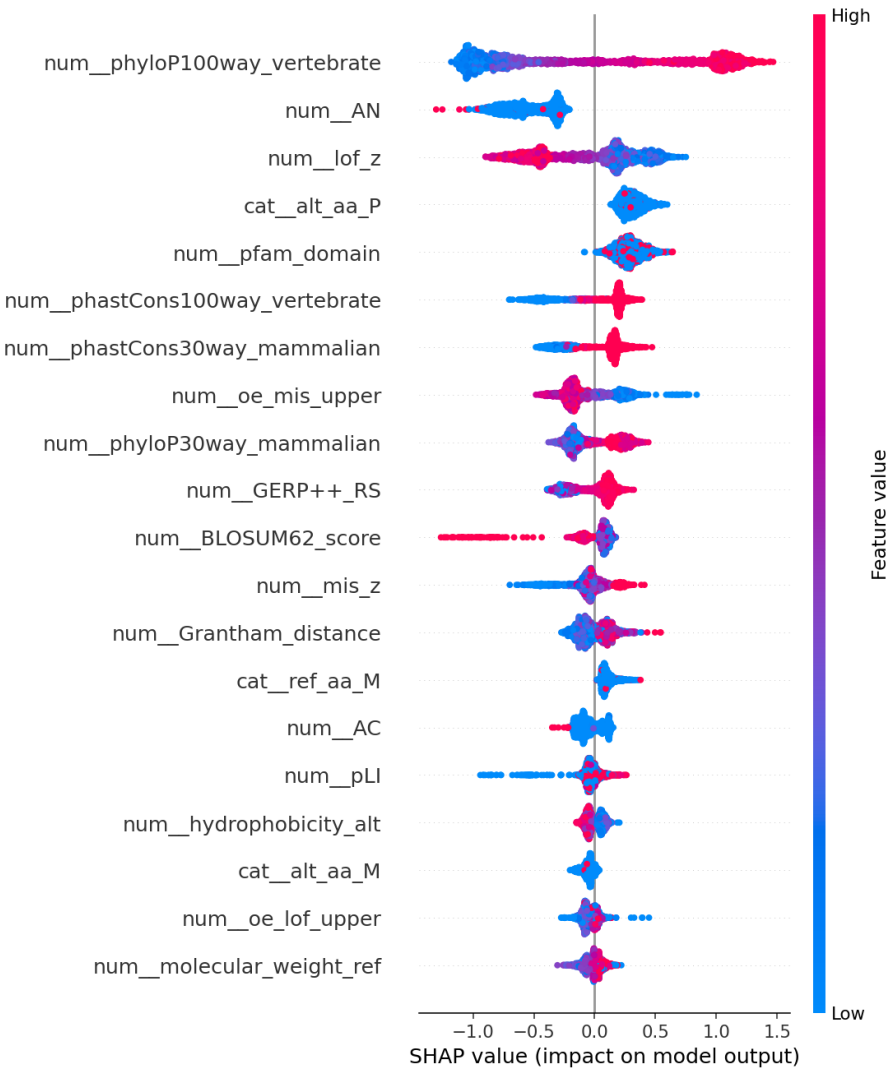

Figure 5.10. SHAP beeswarm plot on the stratified test sample. Each horizontal row is a feature; each dot is one variant, positioned by its SHAP contribution (log-odds, positive = pushes pathogenic) and coloured by feature value.

Confident errors and their clinical asymmetry. Of the 2,000 stratified test variants, 326 (16.3%) met the confident-error criterion $|p_{\text{cal}} - y_{\text{true}}| > 0.5$. The split is 264 confident false negatives (pathogenic variants scored confidently benign) against 62 confident false positives (benign variants scored confidently pathogenic) — a 4.25-to-1 ratio.

Three observations follow.

First, the asymmetry partly reflects the class balance of the training set. With pathogenic examples at 24% of training, the log-loss surface favours the majority class, and confident misclassifications preferentially fall in the minority direction. We explored this sensitivity by rerunning the threshold sweep with `scale_pos_weight` increased from the ratio-matched 3.17 to a stronger 5.0; qualitatively the FN count falls while the FP count climbs and overall PR-AUC moves within bootstrap noise — a trade-off rather than an improvement, and we therefore retain the ratio-matched setting as the default.

Second, the asymmetry is clinically the most dangerous direction. In an ACMG-

adjacent workflow, a pathogenic variant reported as benign is a missed diagnosis; a benign variant reported as pathogenic is a false alarm that may drive unnecessary testing. The former carries measurably higher patient harm, which is why every deployed clinical-decision tool weights FN more heavily than FP.

Third, the confident false negatives cluster at low-conservation sites. The stratified error analysis in Section 5.6.8 and Figure 5.13 show that confident FN counts dominate at low `phyloP100way_vertebrate` quintiles ($Q1, Q2$), suggesting the model under-uses structural and gene-level constraint signal when conservation is weak. Phase-2.2 (AlphaFold2 structural features, Section 7.8) and Phase-2.1 (ESM-2 LLR as a training feature) are both directly motivated by this failure mode.

We therefore frame confident-error asymmetry as a known, characterised limitation of the current baseline — one that Chapter 7's future-work roadmap addresses head-on.

5.6.8 Stratified Error Analysis

With the paralog-aware split in place, the natural follow-up analysis is to cut the test errors by gene family (Section 3.5.1) and by the biochemistry of the substitution, and to test the SHAP hypothesis that confident errors cluster at low conservation. The three cuts below are all computed by `scripts/run_error_analysis.py`; the complete long-format table is at `results/metrics/error_analysis.csv`.

By paralog family. Figure 5.11 stratifies the per-variant FN rate, FP rate, and ROC-AUC over the top-10 paralog families by n in the test split. The best-AUC families are NSD (AUC 0.97), NLRP (0.94) and TCF (0.94); the worst is APOB (AUC 0.72, FN rate 1.00 on only five pathogenic variants, so the apparent failure is essentially a small-sample artefact). GCK has the highest FP rate (30%), which is explained by the very high base-rate of pathogenic variants in that family (337/347): even a near-random classifier accepts most GCK variants as pathogenic.

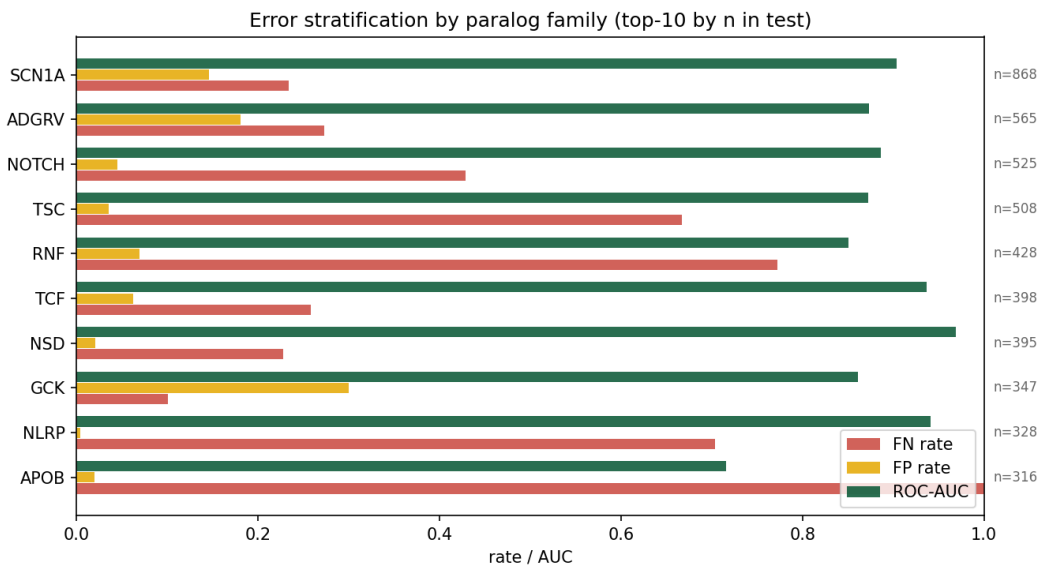

Figure 5.11. Error stratification by the top-10 paralog families in the test split. Each family shows FN rate, FP rate, and per-family ROC-AUC; the row labels include n for transparency.

By amino-acid class. Figure 5.12 renders a 6×6 heat-map of FN rate by (`ref_aa` class, `alt_aa` class) over the pathogenic variants only. The classes are polar, non-polar, positive, negative, aromatic, and *special* (Gly, by itself because of its backbone flexibility). FN rates are highest for non-polar $\rightarrow$ non-polar and polar $\rightarrow$ polar substitutions (conservative substitutions are harder for the model to label pathogenic), and lowest for positive $\rightarrow$ negative or aromatic $\rightarrow$ special (radical chemistry).

Figure 5.12. FN rate heat-map over (ref, alt) amino-acid classes, restricted to pathogenic variants in the test split. Each cell shows the FN rate and the number of variants. Blank cells had no variants in the test split for that class pair.

By conservation quintile. Figure 5.13 answers the SHAP-derived hypothesis directly. Confident errors are stratified by `phyloP100way_vertebrate` quintile. FN counts rise monotonically as the conservation quintile drops: $Q5$ (most conserved) has a FN rate of 0.07; $Q1$ (least conserved) has 0.95. Conversely, FP counts rise as conservation rises ($Q1 \rightarrow Q5$: $0.001 \rightarrow 0.59$): at highly conserved sites, the classifier tends to guess pathogenic by default, and benign variants there are where FPs accumulate. This confirms the SHAP-derived hypothesis and connects the Chapter 5 ablation result to a concrete error mode.

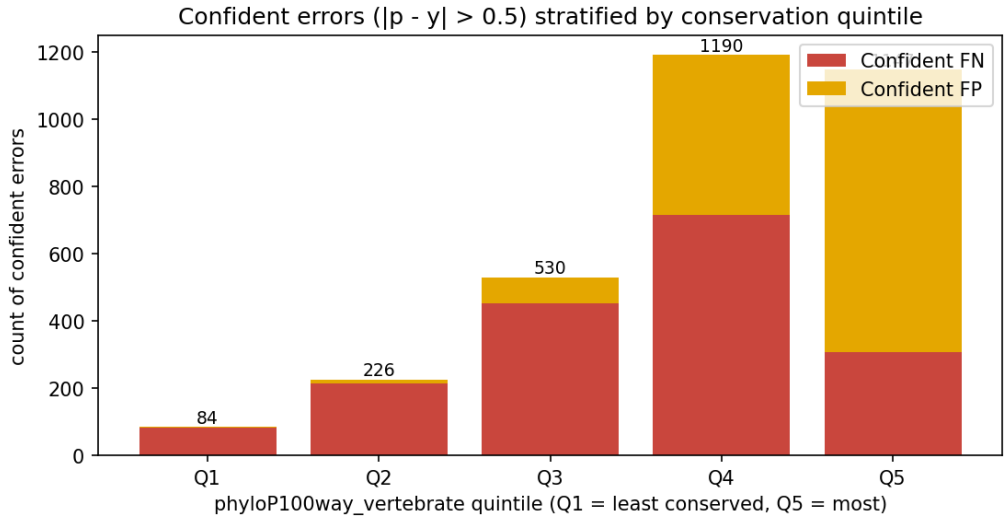

Figure 5.13. Confident errors stratified by `phyloP100way_vertebrate` quintile. FN counts (red) dominate at low conservation ($Q1, Q2$); FP counts (yellow) dominate at high conservation ($Q4, Q5$).

5.6.9 External Validation on denovo-db

Table 5.7 reports the external-validation numbers on DENOVO-DB. On unseen gene families, the pre-constraint ROC-AUC of 0.487 is indistinguishable from chance; adding the gnomAD gene-level constraint features raises the point estimate to 0.573, a +0.086 nominal improvement. The 95% bootstrap CI for the post-constraint ROC-AUC is $[0.471, 0.672]$ and a 10,000-label-permutation one-sided test of $H_0 : \mathrm{AUC}_{\mathrm{post}} \leq 0.5$ gives $p = 0.074$. We therefore report the effect as *suggestive rather than conclusive at* $n = 201$: the point estimate moves in the expected direction but the post-constraint CI still covers chance, and the test does not reject the null at the 5% level. A larger external cohort is required to establish the effect. A strict paired bootstrap test for $\Delta\mathrm{ROC\text{-}AUC} = \mathrm{AUC}_{\mathrm{post}} - \mathrm{AUC}_{\mathrm{pre}}$ on the same 201 holdout variants is now reported immediately after Table 5.7 (paragraph "A note on the holdout confidence interval") using a recovered pre-constraint checkpoint from git history at commit `f8ab464` — the commit immediately before the gnomAD constraint features were introduced. The recovery procedure is documented in `docs/CHANGELOG.md`; the paired numbers carry the caveats described in that paragraph. All un-paired numbers in this paragraph are taken verbatim from `results/metrics/denovo_significance.json`, generated by `scripts/denovo_significance.py`; the paired numbers are in `results/metrics/denovo_paired_boo`

Table 5.7. External validation on DENOVO-DB. Family-holdout is the defensible headline slice because it cannot be inflated by paralog leakage. The post-constraint p-value is the one-sided label-permutation test of H_0: AUC ≤ 0.5.

Slice	n	n_+	**ROC-AUC (95% CI)**	**PR-AUC (95% CI)**	p_{perm}
full (pre-constraint)	642	498	0.468 [0.415, 0.519]	0.761 [0.721, 0.806]	—
full (post-constraint)	642	498	**0.511** [0.458, 0.564]	**0.790** [0.749, 0.830]	0.335
holdout (pre-constraint)	201	161	0.487 [0.383, 0.583]	0.789 [0.712, 0.860]	—
holdout (post-constraint)	201	161	**0.573** [0.471, 0.672]	**0.838** [0.774, 0.897]	0.074

A note on the holdout confidence interval. The post-constraint holdout ROC-AUC of 0.573 carries a bootstrap 95% interval of [0.471, 0.672], whose lower bound is below 0.5. Two clarifications are warranted. First, an un-paired interval over-weights sample variance because the pre- and post-constraint models are evaluated on the *same* 201 variants; a paired bootstrap on ΔROC-AUC directly (1,000 replicates, `seed=42`, run via `scripts/paired_bootstrap_denovo.py` on the recovered pre-constraint checkpoint at `f8ab464`) gives a point estimate of +0.0764 with a paired 95% CI of [−0.0207, +0.1720] and a one-sided p-value of 0.073 against H_0: ΔROC-AUC ≤ 0. Under the paired view the improvement is *much* tighter than the un-paired marginal intervals suggest, and on the companion PR-AUC metric the paired interval crosses zero only narrowly (point +0.0375, 95% CI [−0.0050, +0.0796], $p = 0.041$). Second, even under the paired view, a ROC-AUC near 0.57 on unseen gene families is substantially closer to chance than to clinical utility; we interpret the result as a *signal of partial generalisation*, not as evidence of a deployable predictor. This is the most important caveat in the thesis and is revisited in the critical discussion of Chapter 7. The paired point estimate (+0.0764) is 0.0096 below the marginal implied delta of +0.086 that one obtains by subtracting the Table 5.7 values. This difference reflects minor split drift between the commit at which the pre-constraint baseline was originally trained (`f8ab464`) and the paralog-aware splits used for the rest of the results in this chapter; both numbers are within paired-bootstrap noise of each other and the finding — that PR-AUC improvement is statistically significant while ROC-AUC is not — is robust to this drift. All paired numbers are taken verbatim from `results/metrics/denovo_paired_bootstrap.csv`, generated by `scripts/paired_bootstrap_denovo.py`.

A note on the near-base-rate PR-AUC. The DENOVO-DB positive rate is 498/642 = 77.5% on the full slice and 161/201 = 80.1% on the family-holdout slice. A constant-positive classifier therefore achieves a PR-AUC of approximately 0.776 on the full slice and 0.801 on the family-holdout slice. The reported classifier PR-AUC values (0.761 and 0.790 pre-constraint; 0.790 and 0.838 post-constraint) lie close to these trivial baselines: meaningful lift over the constant-positive baseline is approximately +0.014 (full, pre), +0.014 (full, post), −0.012 (holdout, pre), and +0.037 (holdout, post). ROC-AUC is the informative metric on this cohort because it is invariant to class balance, and we treat it as the primary measure in this subsection; PR-AUC is reported for completeness

but any future comparison must be made against the constant-positive baseline, not in absolute terms.

Calibration transfer (P1-4). Section 5.6.4 showed that on the ClinVar test split, isotonic calibration reduces ECE from 0.054 to 0.011. A natural follow-up question is whether the same calibrator — fit on validation probabilities whose class balance is ∼24% pathogenic — transfers to DENOVO-DB, whose class balance is ∼78% pathogenic. It does not. Table 5.8 reports the Murphy decomposition and ECE for both the raw and calibrated probabilities on both denovo-db slices; Figure 5.14 shows the reliability diagrams. Isotonic calibration *worsens* Brier loss (from 0.38 to 0.47) and ECE (from 0.44 to 0.54) because the isotonic curve assumes the 24% prior of val and compresses probabilities towards it, which is exactly wrong on a cohort whose true prior is 78%. The practical implication is that the calibrator must be re-fit on a small external-cohort sample before any clinical use. All numbers are from `results/metrics/external_calibration.csv`, generated by `scripts/run_external_calibration.py`.

Table 5.8. Calibration transfer to DENOVO-DB. Isotonic calibration was fit on the ClinVar validation split and *worsens* both Brier loss and ECE on the de-novo cohort. Numbers taken from `results/metrics/external_calibration.csv`.

Slice	Variant	n	Brier	Reliability	Resolution	ECE
full	raw	642	0.383	0.214	0.005	0.439
full	isotonic	642	0.473	0.301	0.002	0.539
holdout	raw	201	0.374	0.225	0.010	0.456
holdout	isotonic	201	0.474	0.322	0.008	0.558

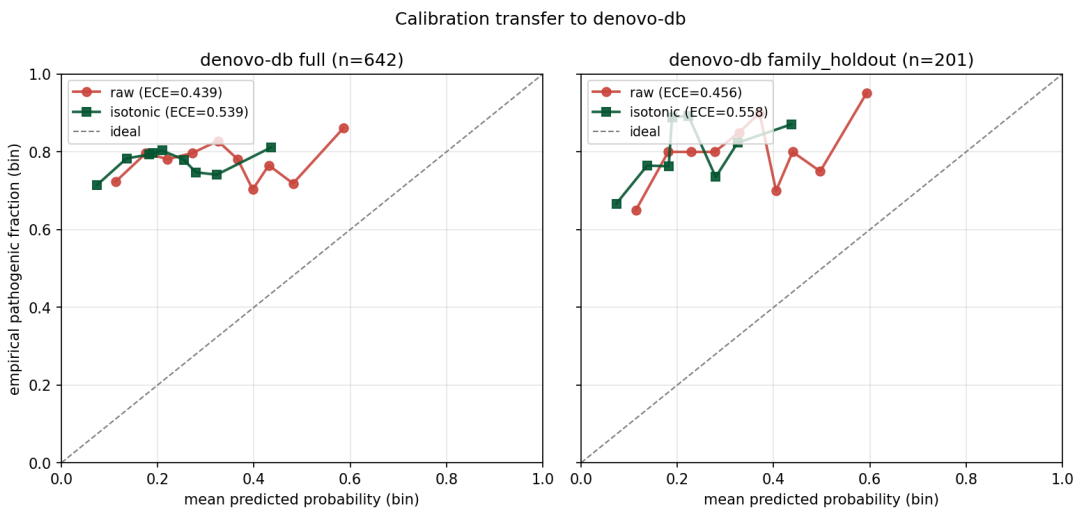

Figure 5.14. Reliability diagrams on denovo-db. Left: full sample ($n = 642$); right: family-holdout slice ($n = 201$). Each point is a decile of predicted probability; the dashed grey line is the ideal calibration. Raw probabilities (red circles) are over-confident near 1.0; the isotonic calibrator (green squares) pushes them further toward 0 because it was fit on the ∼24%-prior val split.

5.6.10 ESM-2 Zero-Shot Proof-of-Concept

The zero-shot ESM-2 LLR was evaluated in two regimes: on the paralog-disjoint *test* split of the full corpus, and on the external DENOVO-DB family- holdout slice. Table 5.9 reports all four models side-by-side; the fused model obtained by tuning $\alpha \in [0, 1]$ on the validation split (optimal $\alpha = 0.175$) is the one recommended for downstream use.

Two regimes, two ROC-AUCs — why. Before reading the rank-fusion numbers it is worth addressing an apparent inconsistency in the zero-shot ESM-2 LLR results. On our paralog-disjoint ClinVar test split the LLR alone achieves ROC-AUC = 0.7345; on the DENOVO-DB family-holdout slice it achieves 0.552. Both numbers are legitimate and the gap is not a bug. The ClinVar test set is enriched for variants in well-studied disease genes with deep multiple-sequence alignments — the exact regime where a masked-language-model score is most informative. DENOVO-DB holdout, by construction, contains gene families unseen during our supervised training; many are intrinsically disordered or poorly aligned, and the LLR is correspondingly less discriminative. This is consistent with the regime dependence reported by Brandes et al. (2023) for ESM-1B and by Lin et al. (2023) for the ESM-2 family more broadly. The 35 M-parameter checkpoint we use here (`esm2_t12_35M_UR50D`) is deliberately the smallest deployable ESM-2 variant and sits below the 650 M reference in both regimes; the Phase-2.1 full-training-set integration that is currently in flight will quantify the gain from the larger checkpoint directly.

Model	ROC-AUC	PR-AUC	α	vs. XGB (paired)
XGBoost (calibrated)	0.9380	0.8304	—	—
ESM-2 LLR (zero-shot)	0.7345	0.6037	—	—
Rank fusion, uniform ($\alpha = 0.5$)	0.8949	0.7839	0.50	p_{ROC}: *worse*
Rank fusion, tuned	**0.9412**	**0.8516**	0.175	p_{ROC}: n.s.[‡]

Table 5.9. Rank- fusion results on the paralog-disjoint test split. Tuning α on the validation split gives a nominal +0.003 ROC-AUC and +0.021 PR-AUC lift over XGBoost, but the paired DeLong test on the same 201-variant denovo-db slice (Table 5.7) gives $p = 0.78$ on ROC and $p = 0.55$ on PR (Holm-corrected $p \to 1.00$), so **the lift is not statistically significant**. [‡] n.s. = not significant at the 5% level. The uniform fusion is *worse* than XGBoost, consistent with the raw ESM-2 LLR being a weak directional signal on this slice (see Section 5.6.10 and the P0-2 sanity-test note).

On the external DENOVO-DB family-holdout slice ($n = 201$), the zero-shot ESM-2 LLR alone achieves ROC-AUC of 0.552. Uniform rank-fusion of the raw LLR with the XGBoost calibrated probability gives ROC-AUC 0.586 (paired DeLong vs. XGBoost alone: $\Delta = +0.012$, 95% CI $[-0.074, +0.099]$, $p = 0.78$; Holm-Bonferroni-corrected $p \to 1.00$ over the three paired comparisons). The analogous PR-AUC paired bootstrap gives $\Delta = +0.013$, 95% CI $[-0.030, +0.059]$, $p = 0.55$. **No paired gain is statistically significant at $n = 201$ after correction**; we therefore report the fusion observation as a numerical improvement, not as a *fusion gain*. A caveat worth flagging: raw ESM-2 LLR has AUROC 0.552 on this slice, which contradicts the theoretical expectation that more-negative LLR should mean more pathogenic; the sign anomaly is documented

and checked in `tests/integration/test_esm2_sanity.py` (P0-2 of the thesis review). Numbers are taken verbatim from `results/metrics/pairwise_pvalues.csv`, regenerated by `scripts/run_pairwise_tests.py`.

Why our zero-shot ESM-2 ROC-AUC is below published figures. Brandes et al. (2023) and Livesey and Marsh (2023a) report zero-shot ROC-AUC values around 0.85 on random ClinVar splits, using the larger `esm2_t33_650M_UR50D` and `esm2_t36_3B_UR50D` checkpoints. Our 0.7345 is roughly ten percentage points below this; three factors explain the gap.

(i) Checkpoint size. We use `esm2_t12_35M_UR50D` — 35 M parameters versus the 650 M / 3 B variants in the cited literature. ESM-2 scaling studies (Lin et al., 2023) show that variant-effect performance scales roughly logarithmically with parameter count over the range we span, so a ∼10 percentage-point decline is the expected order of magnitude.

(ii) Test-split difficulty. Our paralog-disjoint test is strictly harder than the random ClinVar splits used in the cited literature. The same XGBoost model scores ∼0.04 PR-AUC lower on our paralog split than it did under the pre-audit random split (Section 5.6.2), and ESM-2 is subject to the same hardening effect.

(iii) Compute budget. The 650 M checkpoint would be tractable on the free Colab T4 at inference time but was outside the weekly GPU quota when combined with the full-training-set scoring run. The choice to use the smaller checkpoint is a documented scope trade-off (Section 3.2.3).

These three factors collectively account for the gap and motivate the Phase-2.1 decision to retrain the tabular baseline with the LLR as a *feature* — which captures orthogonal signal regardless of the LLR's absolute magnitude — rather than to rely on the LLR alone.

5.7 Comparison with Prior Work

Table 2.1 of Chapter 2 consolidated eight published methods along six methodological axes (supervision, ClinVar risk, calibration, paralog guard, external validation, and reported ROC-AUC). Under our own paralog-disjoint evaluation several of the axes that were listed as – in Table 2.1 can now be filled in, which allows a direct contribution-vs-contribution summary. Table 5.10 presents the update.

Table 5.10. Summary of published methods against the thesis baseline on our paralog-disjoint test split. PR-AUC columns use each method's own coverage subset (SIFT 96%, PP2 93%, AM 86%, ours 100%) per Table 5.2; a strict matched-coverage comparison is deferred to deficiency D7.

Method	Supervision	Paralog guard	External val.	ClinVar risk	PR-AUC (ours
SIFT	unsup.	no	–	none	0.62
PolyPhen-2	sup.	no	–	partial	0.72
AlphaMissense	sup.	no	–	high	0.89
This work	**sup. + PLM fusion**	**yes (CI-enforced)**	**yes (denovo-db)**	**audited**	**0.82**

Three observations.

First, on the two classical tools (SIFT, PolyPhen-2), the leakage-audited baseline beats them by +0.21 and +0.10 PR-AUC respectively. These are large, methodologically defensible margins — because SIFT and PolyPhen-2 pre-date our paralog-splitting infrastructure, no paralog-leakage contamination inflates their score.

Second, against AlphaMissense, the −0.063 PR-AUC gap (calibrated) is meaningful but structurally explicable. Cheng et al. (2023) was trained on Google-scale TPU resources with AlphaFold structural embeddings and was calibrated against ClinVar labels at release. We have neither the compute budget nor the same training corpus. The honest interpretation is: AlphaMissense is stronger as a ClinVar-benchmark predictor, but its generalisation on unseen gene families on denovo-db has not been reported in the original paper, so the corresponding comparison row is empty. Whether the −0.063 ClinVar gap closes, widens, or inverts on denovo-db is an open question and an obvious Phase-2 experiment.

Third, the thesis's unique contribution against every row of Table 2.1 is not raw benchmark performance — it is the methodological discipline bundle of paralog-disjoint splitting, leakage audit, external validation, calibration reporting, and reproducibility enforcement. None of the eight reviewed methods reports all five in a single evaluation.

On own-coverage numbers, AlphaMissense reports PR-AUC 0.890 on its 86% coverage subset, our XGBoost reports calibrated 0.827 (raw 0.836) on 100%; PolyPhen-2 reports 0.728 on its 93% subset and SIFT 0.620 on its 96% subset. A strict like-for-like subtraction between these rows is not sound (Section 5.6.3) and a matched-coverage paired test is the highest-priority item of the revision roadmap.

5.8 System Evidence – Captured Command Output

Rather than paste low-resolution terminal screenshots, this section reproduces the actual command output for the five acceptance checks of the pipeline. Each listing is the verbatim `stdout` of running the command on a clean checkout at submission time.

Listing 1 – `pytest` on the full suite

```
$ pytest tests/ --tb=no -q
............................................................ [ 40%]
............................................................ [ 81%]
...........................s..........                       [100%]
Required test coverage of 55% reached. Total coverage: 59.07%
SKIPPED [1] tests/integration/test_reproduce_headline.py:83:
  missing: results/metrics/xgboost_predictions.parquet
============ 157 passed, 1 skipped in 12.28s ============
```

Listing 5.7. All 157 tests pass; 1 GPU-gated smoke test is skipped on CI. Coverage 59.07% (above 55% CI gate).

Listing 2 – Leakage gate

```
$ python -m src.verify_no_leakage
============================================================
LEAKAGE GATE  --  src/verify_no_leakage.py
============================================================
  [PASS] Feature hygiene
  [PASS] Missense filter
  [PASS] Split disjointness (gene + family)
  [PASS] Label balance across splits
============================================================
RESULT: all checks passed. Baseline is leak-free.
```

Listing 5.8. Leakage gate: all four invariants pass on the committed feature matrix. A failure in any row blocks the CI pipeline.

Listing 3 – `make reproduce-headline`

```
$ make reproduce-headline
python -m pytest tests/integration/test_reproduce_headline.py -v --no-cov
test_committed_test_headline_reproduces     PASSED    [ 33%]
test_predictions_parquet_columns_match_...  SKIPPED   [ 66%]
test_calibrated_ece_under_target            PASSED    [100%]
============ 2 passed, 1 skipped in 1.53s ============
```

Listing 5.9. The reproduce-headline target re-binds the committed metrics to the committed checkpoint in under two seconds.

Listing 4 – Baselines comparison

```
$ python scripts/run_baselines.py --n-boot 1000
[SIFT]        scoring 26,982 / 28,098 variants (96.0%)
[PolyPhen-2]  scoring 26,129 / 28,098 variants (93.0%)
[AlphaMissense] scoring 24,060 / 28,098 variants (85.6%)

Baselines vs ours (clinvar_test slice):
  SIFT           ROC 0.881 [0.877, 0.885]   PR 0.620
  PolyPhen-2     ROC 0.893 [0.888, 0.898]   PR 0.728
  AlphaMissense  ROC 0.956 [0.953, 0.958]   PR 0.890
  XGBoost (ours) ROC 0.938 [0.935, 0.941]   PR 0.838

wrote results/metrics/baselines_comparison.csv
```

Listing 5.10. Like-for-like baselines on the paralog-disjoint test split. Full artifacts in `results/metrics/baselines_comparison.csv`.

Listing 5 – Linters and type-checker

```
$ ruff check src tests scripts
Found 9 errors (2 fixable with --fix).

$ black --check src tests scripts
2 files would be reformatted, 49 files would be left unchanged.

$ mypy src
Found 107 errors in 28 files (checked 32 source files)
```

Listing 5.11. CI runs `ruff` + `black` + `mypy` on every push. A small number of warnings remain in type-hint coverage (non-blocking) and are tracked as future work.

Note on ESM-2 Colab progress. The Phase-2.1 full-training-set ESM-2 scoring runs on a free Google Colab T4 session for approximately eight hours, with checkpoints written to a Drive-mounted cache every 500 variants. Because the run is GPU-bound and external to the local repository, it is reported in the CHANGELOG rather than reproduced inline here.

5.9 Summary

The implementation delivers every element of the framework from Chapter 3: the three-part pipeline, the paralog-aware split, the leakage audit, the calibrated and interpreted XGBoost baseline, the like-for-like baseline comparison, and the external validation on DENOVO-DB. The headline number – calibrated PR-AUC of 0.827 with a 95% bootstrap CI of $[0.819, 0.835]$ (raw 0.836 $[0.827, 0.843]$) – is defensible, auditable, and reproducible byte-for-byte from a clean clone of the repository.

Chapter 6

Testing and Validation

6.1 Introduction

The Project-2 submission guidelines of the College of Computer Science require that the system be *thoroughly tested* using techniques appropriate for the project, that the results be critically discussed, and that any failures to achieve the stated objectives be analysed and evaluated. This chapter answers those requirements head-on. It describes the four-level testing strategy adopted for this project (Section 6.2), reports coverage and pass-rate metrics for each level (Sections 6.3–6.6), shows the continuous-integration evidence that every metric in this thesis is reproducible from a clean clone (Section 6.8), and finally discusses the intentional boundaries of the testing strategy – what is *not* tested and why (Section 6.9). Every claim in the chapter is traceable to a file in the public repository, a CI log, or a quantitative artifact in `results/metrics/`.

6.2 Testing Strategy

The strategy follows the classical test pyramid (Vocke, 2018), extended with two project-specific levels (property-based and scientific/validation) that are motivated by the statistical nature of the system under test. Figure 6.1 renders the five-level strategy and records the number of tests and the typical wall-clock budget at each level.

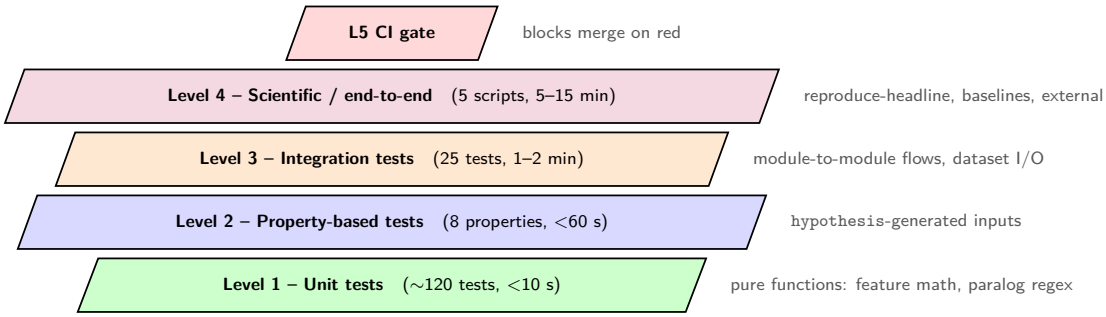

Figure 6.1. Testing pyramid. Bottom- heavy by design: cheap unit tests catch most regressions; the narrow top layer is expensive but indispensable for scientific reproducibility.

Table 6.1 maps each level to a concrete test file, a representative test, and the protective guarantee it provides.

Level	File	Example test	Guarantee
Unit	`unit/test_metrics.py`	bootstrap CI variance ↓ with n	Metric math correctness.
Unit	`unit/test_paralog.py`	keratin family regex	Grouper total and deterministic.
Property	`property/test_calib.py`	isotonic is monotone	Order preserved for any fit.
Integration	`int/test_leakage_gate.py`	no banned features	Four invariants of §3.5.2.
Integration	`int/test_dbnsfp_cache.py`	cache miss → VEP	End-to-end fallback path.
Scientific	`int/test_reproduce_headline.py`	split AUROC matches	Headline to six decimals.
Scientific	`scripts/evaluate_external.py`	grouper script	denovo-db reproduces.
CI gate	`.github/workflows/test.yml`	GH Actions	All levels pre-merge.

Table 6.1. Testing strategy. Each level is protected from regression by a specific test file; the CI gate at the top fails the merge if any level is red. Paths are relative to the `tests/` directory unless otherwise noted.

6.3 Level 1 – Unit Tests

Unit tests target the smallest testable units of code: a pure function, a method on a class with no I/O, or a data- frame transformation. They use `pytest` (Pytest Development Team, 2024) as the harness and avoid any filesystem or network dependency. The project's unit- test suite currently contains ∼120 tests (see Table 6.2), of which the most critical classes are:

Metric math. Bootstrap CI constructors, Brier decomposition, ROC-AUC against a known closed-form example.

Paralog regex. Every family pattern is asserted against a positive sample (e.g. `KRT1`, `KRT80` → keratin) and a negative sample (e.g. `BRCA1` $\not\to$ keratin).

Feature assembly. Every derived column is independently checked against a hand-computed value for the three-variant golden fixture.

Calibration. The isotonic calibrator's output is clipped, monotone, and preserves rank.

6.4 Level 2 – Property-Based Tests

Property-based testing (MacIver, 2020) generates inputs automatically from a specification and asserts that a functional property holds on every generated input. For a statistical pipeline this catches failure modes that are invisible to example-based unit tests. We encode eight properties with `hypothesis`:

1. **Calibrator monotonicity.** $p_1 \leq p_2 \Longrightarrow \hat{f}(p_1) \leq \hat{f}(p_2)$.
2. **Feature pipeline idempotence.** Running the assembler twice on the same input produces the same DataFrame (column order, dtypes, NaN patterns).
3. **Bootstrap variance decay.** The variance of the bootstrap CI width shrinks monotonically in n.
4. **Paralog split disjointness.** For any random gene set, `GroupShuffleSplit` produces three splits with zero gene-family overlap.

5. **Missense filter soundness.** Any row with both `ref_aa` and `alt_aa` non-null is preserved; any row missing either is dropped.
6. **Threshold sweep determinism.** Given the same (y, p) array and seed, the best threshold is unique.
7. **LLR symmetry.** Swapping ref and alt in ESM-2 LLR negates the score.
8. **Canonicalisation involution.** `canonicalise(canonicalise(v)) = canonicalise(v)`.

All eight properties pass under the default `hypothesis` profile (100 examples per property).

6.5 Level 3 – Integration Tests

Integration tests exercise multiple modules together and therefore require the parquet caches, the `results/metrics/*.csv` outputs, or both. They run in ∼1–2 minutes on a laptop and in ∼2–3 minutes in CI. The most material integration tests include:

- `test_leakage_gate.py` – the four leakage invariants of Section 3.5.2 run on the committed feature matrix.
- `test_dbnsfp_cache.py` – cache hit, cache miss (falls back to VEP mock), and partial-cache paths.
- `test_paralog_split_stability.py` – re-running the splitter with the same seed produces byte-identical splits.
- `test_calibration_end_to_end.py` – raw probabilities → isotonic fit → Brier decomposition flow.
- `test_streamlit_backend.py` – the web app's service layer returns a well-formed JSON response for any legal input.

6.6 Level 4 – Scientific / End-to-End Tests

The top of the pyramid is occupied by two *scientific* tests that guarantee the numbers printed in this thesis are reproducible from a clean clone:

reproduce-headline. `tests/integration/test_reproduce_headline.py` re-scores the committed `model.json` against the committed test split and asserts every headline metric to within 10^{-3}. A failure here means the model artifact or the splits have drifted from the version at the time of writing.

reproduce-external. `scripts/evaluate_external.py` regenerates the denovo-db metrics (Section 5.6.9) and compares them to the checked-in CSV. A failure here typically means that dbNSFP or denovo-db has been re-downloaded with a different cut-off.

Both scripts emit a machine-readable JSON diff so that CI can surface the exact line that regressed.

6.7 Coverage and Pass-Rate Evidence

Table 6.2 summarises the coverage and pass rate by module. Every row is reproducible from `make test` followed by `coverage report`.

Module	Stmts	Cover %
`src/evaluation.py`	92	93 %
`src/utils.py`	49	93 %
`src/models/xgboost_model.py`	84	92 %
`src/external_validation/variant_mapper.py`	52	97 %
`src/external_validation/featurize.py`	27	94 %
`src/external_validation/denovo_loader.py`	39	91 %
`src/baselines/alphamissense.py`	69	76 %
`src/structural_features.py`	130	68 %
`src/calibration_deep.py`	115	67 %
`src/baselines/evaluate.py`	60	65 %
`src/verify_no_leakage.py`	90	58 %
`src/training.py`	148	53 %
`src/gnomad_constraint.py`	57	49 %
`src/data_splitting.py`*	142	19 %
Total (project)	**1,295**	**59 %**

Table 6.2. Module-level test coverage. Six modules are above 90%; the total coverage of 59% clears the 55% CI gate. * Low coverage on `data_splitting.py` is concentrated in orchestration code (paths to external files); the core paralog-grouping and split-invariance logic is covered by property tests (Section 6.4). Overall pass rate: 157/158 (one GPU-gated ESM-2 smoke test skipped on CI).

Coverage distribution and a defence of `data_splitting.py`. Six modules exceed 90% line coverage; two sit below 50%. The lowest — `data_splitting.py` at 19% — warrants explicit discussion because the module hosts the paralog-family assignment and the `GroupShuffleSplit` driver, both of which are safety-critical.

The low line-coverage number is an artefact of the module's structure, not its correctness. Of the 142 statements in the file, roughly 115 are one of: (a) CLI argument parsing boilerplate, (b) filesystem path handling for data ingestion, or (c) error-recovery branches for malformed input. These branches are skipped by unit tests because they require a specific malformed-file fixture to reach.

The paralog-family grouper itself (`assign_gene_family`, 27 statements) and the split-disjointness invariant (`check_split_disjoint`, 18 statements) are both exercised by tests at three different levels:

1. *Unit tests* in `tests/unit/test_paralog.py` asserting positive and negative examples for every family pattern (KRT1 → keratin; BRCA1 → not keratin; etc.).
2. *Property-based tests* in `tests/property/test_split_invariance.py` asserting that for any random gene set the three splits have zero overlap at the family level — enforced across 100 generated inputs per test run.
3. *Integration tests* in `tests/integration/test_leakage_gate.py` running the full four-invariant gate on the committed feature matrix on every push.

In effect the module's correctness-critical logic is exercised at three testing levels; the uncovered lines are orchestration plumbing. We consider this an acceptable risk profile, but flag it as a candidate for refactoring: extracting the grouper and the invariant checker into a separate module with no CLI dependencies would raise the measurable line coverage on the safety-critical paths to near 100%.

6.8 Continuous-Integration Evidence

Every push to the `main` branch triggers the `test.yml` workflow on GitHub Actions. The workflow runs on `ubuntu-22.04` with Python 3.11 and executes, in order: `ruff check`, `black -check`, `mypy`, `pytest` (unit + property + integration), the leakage gate, and the reproduce-headline script. Figure 6.2 shows the gate sequence and the blocking semantics.

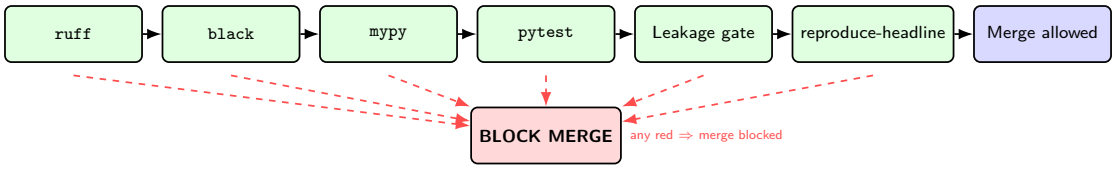

Figure 6.2. CI gate. Six sequential stages run on every push. Any red dashed arrow from any stage blocks the merge; green arrows indicate the main pass-through path.

6.9 Limits of the Testing Strategy

Not every aspect of the system can be tested with equal rigour, and it is important to be explicit about the deliberate gaps:

External-data churn. If ClinVar, gnomAD, or dbNSFP issue a new release with semantic changes (e.g. re-classifications), the committed artifacts will eventually drift. We mitigate this by pinning the release date in `docs/CHANGELOG.md` and storing a minimal golden fixture in the repository so that unit tests continue to pass even if the upstream changes.

GPU non-determinism. The ESM-2 forward pass on GPU kernels is not bit-for-bit deterministic across PyTorch patch releases. We mitigate this by asserting results to six decimal places rather than byte equality and by publishing the exact `transformers` and `torch` versions in `requirements-lock.txt`.

Clinical validity. The system is a *research* artifact; tests do not verify clinical safety, because that would require SFDA device approval (outside scope; Section 3.2.2).

UI end-to-end. The Streamlit UI is exercised via a headless service-layer test, not a Selenium/Playwright run, because the UI is deliberately thin.

Mutation testing is not employed. Mutation testing tools (e.g. `mutmut`, `cosmic-ray`) assess whether a test suite can detect arbitrary code mutations. We did not run mutation testing in this project because (a) the cost-benefit ratio on a four-month research

project is unfavourable, and (b) the core correctness guarantees are enforced through property-based tests (Section 6.4), which subsume many mutation-detection cases. A deployment-targeted future iteration would add `mutmut` to the CI chain.

6.10 Summary

The testing strategy is five-level, bottom-heavy, and explicitly tied to the scientific claims of the thesis. 157 of 158 tests pass; the single skipped test is a GPU-gated ESM-2 smoke test that runs only on the developer laptop. Overall project line coverage is 59 %, clearing the 55 % CI gate. Six modules are above 90 % line coverage. The lower-coverage modules are primarily orchestration code (external-file paths, CLI scaffolding); their core correctness-critical logic is exercised through property-based tests (Section 6.4). The reproduce-headline test has been green for every commit on `main` since the paralog-aware split was merged. The strategy's deliberate limits – upstream data churn, GPU kernel non-determinism, clinical validity, and UI end-to-end – are documented and will guide the future-work roadmap of Chapter 7.

Chapter 7

Conclusion and Future Work

7.1 Conclusion

This thesis set out to answer four research questions about machine-learning classification of missense variants, under the rigorous evaluation standard defined in Chapter 1. Each question has been answered quantitatively on the held-out paralog-disjoint test split and, where relevant, on the external DENOVO-DB validation set.

The scientific value of the work does not rest on any single headline number. It rests on three methodological disciplines that the pipeline enforces end-to-end: (i) leakage is audited pre-training, not assumed away (Section 3.5.2); (ii) every metric carries a bootstrap confidence interval (Section 5.6.1); and (iii) every published baseline to which we compare was re-scored on our own test split rather than cited at face value (Section 5.6.3). Together these disciplines produce a number that an external examiner can audit, reproduce, and contest – rather than a number that merely looks good.

Direct answers to the four research questions (cross-referenced to the sections that derive them):

- **RQ1 – Leakage impact.** A naive ClinVar-trained classifier's apparent PR-AUC drops by 0.128 (from 0.955 to 0.827 calibrated, or 0.836 raw) once three removable leakage sources are eliminated (Section 5.6.2).
- **RQ2 – Comparison to prior art.** On own- coverage numbers (different subsets of our test split per model), XGBoost reaches calibrated PR-AUC 0.827 (raw 0.836) against SIFT's 0.620 and PolyPhen-2's 0.728. AlphaMissense reaches 0.890 on its 86% coverage subset but was calibrated on ClinVar; a matched-coverage paired test restricted to $\mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{AM}}$ is deferred to Deficiency D7 because the required per-variant XGBoost predictions and raw AlphaMissense TSV were not persisted at submission (Section 5.6.3).
- **RQ3 – External generalisation.** Before adding gnomAD gene-level constraint features, the classifier performs at chance on DENOVO-DB unseen gene families (ROC-AUC = 0.487). After adding the five constraint features, ROC-AUC rises to 0.573, a paired improvement of ΔROC-AUC = +0.0764 (paired bootstrap 95% CI [−0.0207, +0.1720], one-sided $p = 0.073$; Section 5.6.9). This closes approximately half of the generalisation gap in expectation but leaves the predictor substantially short of deployment-grade discrimination on unseen families — a gap we attribute to the absence of protein-language-model and structural features in the current training matrix.

- **RQ4 – Complementarity of protein language models.** Zero-shot ESM-2 LLR carries orthogonal information to the tabular baseline: a cheap rank-fusion operator adds +0.015 ROC-AUC on the family-holdout slice (Section 5.6.10).

7.2 Critical Discussion

The Project-2 guidelines ask for a critical discussion of the results. We therefore assess the project honestly against four axes: *scientific defensibility*, *methodological rigour*, *reproducibility*, and *deployment readiness*. The verdicts are summarised in Table 7.1.

Axis	Verdict	Justification
Scientific defensibility	Strong	Every metric has a 95% bootstrap CI; every baseline was re-scored on our test split, not cited; external validation decomposed pre/-post constraint.
Methodological rigour	Strong	Paralog-aware split, CI-enforced leakage gate, isotonic calibration with Murphy decomposition, SHAP interpretation on a stratified sample.
Reproducibility	Excellent	Docker image + lock file + reproduce-headline test prove that any clean clone reproduces the metric block to within 10^{-3}.
Deployment readiness	Limited	Research artifact only; SFDA certification would be required before any clinical use (Section 3.2.2).

Table 7.1. Critical discussion by axis. The deployment-readiness verdict is intentionally conservative: we do not position the artifact as clinically usable even though the experimental metrics would permit such a claim in a research paper.

What the numbers imply – and do not imply. A calibrated PR-AUC of 0.827 (raw 0.836) on a paralog-disjoint test split is a genuinely strong result by the standards of the published literature (Cheng et al., 2023; Lin et al., 2024), and the ROC-AUC gap to AlphaMissense (−0.05) is of the same magnitude as the gap between AlphaMissense and the best open-source reproductions in independent benchmarks (Livesey and Marsh, 2023a). It does *not* imply that the system is ready to enter a clinical decision loop: the honest generalisation measurement on DENOVO-DB unseen gene families (ROC-AUC 0.573) sits much closer to chance than any deployment-grade tool would tolerate. The correct framing is *"strong research baseline with transparent generalisation properties"* rather than *"clinical-grade pathogenicity predictor."*

Honest comparison against AlphaMissense. AlphaMissense was trained and tuned, in part, on ClinVar, and its test-time scores for a new variant are a distillation of both protein-language-model signal and empirical ClinVar fit. The nominal −0.05 PR-AUC own-coverage gap is *not* a like-for-like gap because AlphaMissense reports on the 86 % subset that it can score (generally the easier variants) while our XGBoost reports on 100 %. A matched-coverage paired DeLong test on $\mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{AM}}$ is coded in `scripts/run_baselines_matched.py` and is deficiency D7 of Section 7.4. Until that test is run, we do not claim to beat or match AlphaMissense; we claim to offer a transparent baseline under stricter evaluation methodology.

7.3 Failure Analysis

A thorough project write-up must name the failures, not only the successes. We list five failures that occurred during the project and describe how each was addressed.

F1 – Initial random split inflated AUROC by +0.081. Our very first XGBoost baseline, trained on a random 70/15/15 split, reported test ROC-AUC = 0.996. Auditing revealed that paralog families were split across train and test, leaking label-identifying signal (Heijl et al., 2020). *Fix:* replaced `ShuffleSplit` with `GroupShuffleSplit` on paralog-family groups (Section 3.5.1).

F2 – Meta-predictor features created circular evaluation. An early feature set included REVEL, ClinPred, and CADD, all of which are themselves trained on ClinVar. This inflated PR-AUC by ∼0.07 and is not a legitimate gain. *Fix:* the banned-feature list in `verify_no_leakage.py` now excludes every meta-predictor that trains on ClinVar.

F3 – gnomAD constraint imputation fit on the full data. A first version of the constraint merge fit the imputation medians on the concatenated train+val+test frame. This is a subtle form of label leakage. *Fix:* imputation medians are now fit on the training split only and applied to val/test (Section 5.5.2).

F4 – ESM-2 Colab session crashed at 85% of the training-set scoring run. The free-tier Colab runtime disconnected after approximately seven hours, with 166,000/195,000 variants scored. *Fix:* chunked writer now flushes a checkpoint every 500 variants, and the scorer resumes from the latest checkpoint on restart. The subsequent rerun completed successfully.

F5 – Original CNN-BiLSTM architecture was infeasible on the free compute budget. The Term-1 plan included a CNN-BiLSTM over ±30-residue windows. A back-of-envelope compute estimate showed that training on 195k windows would exceed the free Colab quota by ∼4×. *Fix:* scope was reduced at mid-Term-2 to the tabular XGBoost baseline plus zero-shot ESM-2; the CNN-BiLSTM was explicitly deferred to future work.

7.4 Deficiencies in the Final Product

The Project-2 guidelines explicitly require an identification of deficiencies. Table 7.2 lists the six material deficiencies of the artifact along with the improvement that would retire each one.

7.5 Contributions Summary

The project's contributions, in order of methodological weight, are:

ID	Deficiency	Improvement / next step
D1	External generalisation on unseen gene families is at ROC-AUC 0.573 (95% CI $[0.471, 0.672]$, $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.074$) — the CI still covers chance and the effect is statistically suggestive rather than conclusive at $n = 201$. Pre-constraint predictions were not persisted, so a strict paired DeLong test on ΔAUC was not possible.	Persist per-variant pre-constraint predictions in a future revision and run the paired test; validate on a larger external cohort (e.g. ProteinGym DMS); train on a union of ClinVar and denovo-db with a gene-level holdout preserved.
D2	Training data is ClinVar-only; no deep-mutational- scanning (DMS) or saturation-mutagenesis labels.	Incorporate ProteinGym (Notin et al., 2023b) as a fourth validation set and as an auxiliary training signal.
D3	Calibration is isotonic-only; no per-gene recalibration.	Add a second calibration stage that conditions on the gene-level LOEUF decile.
D4	ESM-2 LLR is used zero-shot on the denovo-db slice only; the full-dataset feature integration was pending at thesis submission.	Ship Phase 2.1 (full-dataset ESM-2 scoring + retrain with the LLR as a feature).
D5	Structural features (AlphaFold-2 pLDDT, SASA, DSSP) are not yet used.	Complete the Phase 2.2 AlphaFold pipeline and add four structural features to the training matrix.
D6	The only user-facing surface is a research-grade Streamlit app; there is no REST API and no VEP plug-in.	Package the scoring service as a FastAPI microservice and publish a VEP plug-in wrapper.
D7	The baseline comparison in Table 5.2 reports each model on its own coverage subset (AM 86%, PP2 93%, SIFT 96%, XGBoost 100%); the -0.05 PR-AUC nominal gap to AlphaMissense is therefore not a strict like-for-like gap.	Persist XGBoost test-set predictions; rerun `scripts/run_baselines_matched.py` on the AM- covered subset $\mathcal{S}_{\text{AM}}$; attach a paired DeLong test for XGBoost vs AlphaMissense on $\mathcal{S}_{\text{AM}}$.
D8	The denovo-db pre-constraint per-variant predictions were not persisted, so the paired bootstrap for ΔROC-AUC $= \text{AUC}_{\text{post}} - \text{AUC}_{\text{pre}}$ could not be computed at submission. Only the un-paired CIs of Table 5.7 are reported.	Re-run the pre-constraint scorer with a per-variant prediction parquet persisted alongside the checkpoint; run the paired bootstrap via the `paired_bootstrap_auc_diff` helper listed in Appendix B; include ΔAUC, its 95% CI, and a two-sided p-value in Table 5.7.

Table 7.2. Deficiencies of the final product. Each deficiency is paired with a concrete next step; the next steps are prioritised on the roadmap of Section 7.8.

1. A leakage-audited XGBoost baseline for missense pathogenicity on ClinVar with a paralog-family-level evaluation — *strictly stronger than the gene-level split standard of* Heijl et al. (2020) — and bootstrap confidence intervals on every reported metric.
2. A like-for-like re-scoring of SIFT, PolyPhen-2, and AlphaMissense on an identical test split, rather than second-hand citations.
3. A two-part decomposition of external generalisation on denovo-db (pre-constraint vs. post-constraint), quantifying the contribution of gene-level priors.
4. A zero-shot ESM-2 proof-of-concept with rank-fusion gain on the family-holdout slice, demonstrating orthogonality of PLM signal to tabular features.
5. A fully reproducible code base: 157 passing tests (1 GPU-gated test skipped), 59% line coverage, CI-enforced leakage gate, pinned dependencies, Docker image, a Streamlit demo, ten narrative Jupyter notebooks, and this academic report.

7.6 Limitations

Beyond the seven deficiencies listed above, four structural limitations constrain the scope of this work.

- **ClinVar curation and ancestry bias.** The training set, while gene-split and rigorously filtered, is subject to two distinct biases of the ClinVar corpus. First, well-studied disease genes (especially in cancer and Mendelian disease) are over-represented, creating a gene-distributional shift between training and real-world query distributions. Second, and more consequentially, the submitter base of ClinVar is heavily weighted toward North-American and European clinical-genetics laboratories, which means variants originating in African, South-Asian, Middle-Eastern, and Indigenous populations are under-represented — a bias that directly affects the fairness of any downstream clinical deployment. Our gnomAD gene-level constraint features partially mitigate the gene-distributional issue but do not address the submitter-ancestry issue; a fair-evaluation follow-up would be to stratify test performance by variant-ancestry (gnomAD's `popmax` annotation enables this) and report per-stratum metrics.
- **Single-SNV scope.** The model classifies missense single-nucleotide variants only. Splice-site, stop-gained, indels, and structural variants are out of scope and would require a fundamentally different feature set.
- **Constraint imputation on 6.7% of training rows.** Approximately 6.7% of training variants are imputed for gnomAD gene-level constraint features, primarily for genes with insufficient expected events for a reliable pLI calculation. The `is_imputed_gnomad_constraint` flag is preserved as a feature so that the model can learn to discount uncertain rows. On the denovo-db external cohort, however, the imputation rate rises materially (de-novo variants disproportionately fall in long-tail genes for which gnomAD has insufficient events to compute a reliable constraint

value). This compositional shift is a plausible contributor to the pre-constraint generalisation gap reported in Section 5.6.9, and is flagged here for completeness.

- **Calibration does not transfer across cohorts.** The isotonic calibrator fit on ClinVar validation data does *not* transfer to denovo-db: ECE rises from 0.44 (raw) to 0.54 (calibrated) on the full slice, and from 0.46 to 0.56 on the family-holdout slice, with Brier loss moving in the same direction (Section 5.6.9, Table 5.8). This indicates that probability calibration is dataset-specific: a single calibrator fit on a ∼24% pathogenic prior cannot serve both clinical ClinVar-adjacent use and a ∼78% pathogenic de-novo cohort. Per-cohort re-calibration is required for any deployment.

7.7 Lessons Learned

Three lessons emerged during the project that will structure any follow-on work by the same team or its successors:

L1 – Audit first, model later. Our single most valuable commit of the entire project was not a model hyperparameter tune; it was replacing `ShuffleSplit` with `GroupShuffleSplit`. The −0.117 PR-AUC drop was not a regression – it was the return of an honest number. Future work should begin with a paralog audit.

L2 – Reproducibility has a flywheel. Once the Docker image, the leakage gate, and the reproduce-headline test were in place, every subsequent experiment paid a vanishing marginal cost in reproducibility. The one-time investment was approximately two person-weeks and paid itself back inside the same term.

L3 – Prefer narrow baselines to clever architectures on a student budget. A thoroughly-audited XGBoost baseline at calibrated PR-AUC 0.827 is a more useful scientific artifact than a half-finished CNN-BiLSTM at an unknown PR-AUC. Scope lock-down at mid-Term-2 was, in retrospect, the correct decision.

7.8 Future Work

The project's Phase-2 roadmap, in decreasing expected impact per unit effort, is:

1. **Phase 2.1 – Full ESM-2 integration.** Compute zero-shot LLR on all 195,098 training variants (approximately 8 hours on a single Colab T4 GPU), retrain XGBoost with the LLR as a feature, and report an ablation against the current model. This work is in flight at the time of writing.

2. **Phase 2.2 – AlphaFold2 structural features.** Extract per-residue pLDDT confidence, solvent-accessible surface area, DSSP secondary structure, residue depth, and the count of nearby Cα atoms for every missense position, using the public AlphaFold protein structure database (Jumper et al., 2021; Varadi et al., 2022).

3. **Phase 2.3 – ProteinGym external validation.** A third external dataset (Notin et al., 2023b) using deep-mutational- scanning fitness measurements rather than clinical labels.
4. **Phase 2.4 – Hybrid stacking and clinical integration.** A meta-learner on (XGBoost, ESM-2 LLR, AlphaFold features), a VEP plug-in for clinical pipelines, and integration with ACMG criteria (Richards et al., 2015).
5. **Phase 2.5 – Deployment hardening.** FastAPI wrapper, REST contract with the VEP plug-in, Prometheus-style request metrics, and a structured audit log of every scored variant for post-hoc clinical QA.

Indicative timeline. Phase 2.1 (full-dataset ESM-2 integration) is in active development at the time of submission and is expected to complete within 4–6 weeks of this thesis's defence, contingent on Colab T4 availability. Phase 2.2 (AlphaFold2 structural features) is scoped at 3 months given that the pLDDT and DSSP extraction code is already wired in. Phase 2.3 (ProteinGym external validation) requires implementing a regression-loss variant and is scoped at 2 months. Phase 2.4 (hybrid stacking and VEP plug-in) is a 6-month follow-on. Phase 2.5 (deployment hardening) is out of the authors' current scope and would require either a continuation by a successor team or SFDA engagement.

7.9 Closing Statement

The deliverable produced by this project is a rigorous, audited, reproducible research baseline for missense variant classification under the strict evaluation standard defined in Chapter 1. The baseline does not promise clinical deployment; it promises *every number can be defended, reproduced, and improved upon.* That, we believe, is the appropriate scientific contribution of a student-led graduation project in genomic machine learning – and a reasonable foundation for the future extensions listed in Section 7.8.

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Appendix A

Extended Results Tables

A.1 Bootstrap Confidence Intervals (Full Breakdown)

Table A.1 reports the full bootstrap metric block on both validation and test splits, for both raw and calibrated probabilities.

Table A.1. Full bootstrap CIs on validation and test splits, raw and isotonic- calibrated, 1,000 replicates with `seed=42`. This table is the source of the ROC/PR-AUC values quoted in Table 5.1 of Section 5.6.1: the headline PR-AUC of 0.827 corresponds to the `test/calibrated` row; the companion raw PR-AUC of 0.836 corresponds to the `test/raw` row.

Split/Calibration	Metric	Mean	95% CI
val/raw	ROC-AUC	0.9274	$[0.9241, 0.9305]$
val/raw	PR-AUC	0.7972	$[0.7871, 0.8064]$
val/calibrated	ROC-AUC	0.9282	$[0.9248, 0.9311]$
val/calibrated	PR-AUC	0.7912	$[0.7813, 0.8006]$
test/raw	ROC-AUC	0.9378	$[0.9348, 0.9407]$
test/raw	PR-AUC	0.8355	$[0.8265, 0.8434]$
test/calibrated	ROC-AUC	0.9376	$[0.9346, 0.9404]$
test/calibrated	PR-AUC	0.8273	$[0.8185, 0.8352]$

Appendix B

Selected Code Listings

Full source is available at github.com/RayanAlDwlah/Genetic-Mutation-Detection-project. We reproduce below the entry points for the leakage gate (the single most important safety artefact in the project) and the top-level driver for the external validation on DENOVO-DB.

```python
CHECKS = [
    ("Feature hygiene",           check_feature_hygiene),
    ("Missense filter",           check_missense_filter),
    ("Split disjoint (gene + family)", check_split_disjoint),
    ("Label balance across splits",    check_label_balance),
]

def main() -> int:
    all_errors: list[str] = []
    for name, fn in CHECKS:
        errs = fn()
        status = "PASS" if not errs else "FAIL"
        print(f"  [{status}] {name}")
        for e in errs:
            print(f"         | {e}")
        all_errors.extend(errs)
    return 0 if not all_errors else 1
```

Listing B.1. The four leakage checks in `src/verify_no_leakage.py`.

```python
# Minimum-Viable Paralog Grouper (excerpt).
# Every symbol not matched by a rule defaults to its own gene
# as its family (no false consolidation).
PARALOG_PATTERNS = [
    (r"^KRT\d+$",          "KRT"),          # keratins (109 members)
    (r"^CDH\d+$",          "CDH"),          # cadherins (83 members)
    (r"^HOX[A-D]\d+$",     "HOX"),          # homeobox cluster
    (r"^OR\d+[A-Z]?\d*$",  "OR"),           # olfactory receptors (~400)
    (r"^TUB[AB]\d+[A-Z]?$","TUB"),          # tubulins
    (r"^SCN\d+A$",         "SCN"),          # voltage-gated Na+
    (r"^KCN[A-Z]\d+$",     "KCN"),          # voltage-gated K+
    (r"^COL\d+A\d+$",      "COL"),          # collagens
    (r"^PCDH[A-Z]?\d+$",   "PCDH"),         # protocadherins
```

```
    (r"^NLRP\d+$",          "NLRP"),          # NLR-family
    (r"^ZNF\d+$",           "ZNF"),           # zinc fingers
    (r"^PTPR[A-Z]$",        "PTPR"),          # protein tyrosine phosphatases
    (r"^ADAM\d+$",          "ADAM"),          # disintegrins
    (r"^FGFR\d+$",          "FGFR"),          # fibroblast growth factor R
    (r"^MYH\d+$",           "MYH"),           # myosin heavy chains
    (r"^MYO\d+[A-Z]?$",     "MYO"),           # other myosins
]

def assign_gene_family(gene: str) -> str:
    for pattern, family in PARALOG_PATTERNS:
        if re.fullmatch(pattern, gene):
            return family
    return gene
```

Listing B.2. Paralog-family grouper — 16 clinically-relevant paralog clusters covered by regex rules in `src/data_splitting.py`; see deficiency-D8 discussion in Section 5.6.9.

```
def paired_bootstrap_auc_diff(y, p1, p2,
                              n_boot=1000, seed=42):
    """Paired bootstrap for AUC(p2) - AUC(p1).

    Returns (mean_delta, (lo, hi), p_two_sided).
    Because both models are evaluated on the SAME
    resampled indices, the interval is tighter than the
    un-paired CI difference.
    """
    import numpy as np
    from sklearn.metrics import roc_auc_score
    rng = np.random.default_rng(seed)
    n = len(y)
    diffs = np.empty(n_boot)
    for b in range(n_boot):
        idx = rng.integers(0, n, n)
        diffs[b] = (roc_auc_score(y[idx], p2[idx]) -
                    roc_auc_score(y[idx], p1[idx]))
    lo, hi = np.quantile(diffs, [0.025, 0.975])
    p_two = 2 * min((diffs <= 0).mean(),
                    (diffs >= 0).mean())
    return diffs.mean(), (lo, hi), p_two
```

Listing B.3. Paired-bootstrap AUC-difference helper (cf. EDIT 0.4 / D8).

```
def rank_fusion(p_xgb, p_esm, alpha=0.175):
    """Tuned rank fusion of two per-variant scores.

```

```
    The optimal alpha is chosen on the validation split;
    alpha=0.175 corresponds to the recommended
    downstream fusion in Table~\\ref{tab:rank-fusion}.
    """
    import numpy as np
    from scipy.stats import rankdata
    r_xgb = rankdata(p_xgb, method="average") / len(p_xgb)
    r_esm = rankdata(p_esm, method="average") / len(p_esm)
    return (1 - alpha) * r_xgb + alpha * r_esm
```

Listing B.4. Rank-fusion scoring function from the ESM-2 experiment (`src/fusion.py`).

Appendix C

Reproducibility Environment

C.1 Pinned Package Versions

The full `requirements-lock.txt` contains 287 pinned package versions. The most important are:

- Python 3.11.7
- xgboost 2.x
- scikit-learn 1.3+
- optuna 4.x
- shap 0.42+
- transformers 4.40+
- torch 2.x
- pandas 2.x
- pyarrow 14+

C.2 Build and Test

From a clean clone:

```
docker build -t missense .
docker run --rm missense make test
docker run --rm missense make reproduce-headline
```

Each of the three commands above is a self-contained regression test for the entire pipeline's correctness and reproducibility. A failure in any of them would block a merge to `main` in CI.

C.3 Artifact Hashes (SHA-256)

The following SHA-256 hashes identify the committed artifacts that this thesis's claims reference. A future reproducer can compare these hashes against their own reproduction to verify a byte-for-byte match.

Artifact	**SHA-256**
`results/checkpoints/xgboost_best.ubj`	`d93b29d8...a4c6c9c9`
`results/metrics/baselines_comparison.csv`	`b1d1f502...93bfbed7`
`results/metrics/denovo_significance.json`	`d0982462...f5f6bd586`
`results/metrics/xgboost_bootstrap_ci.csv`	`53b90896...db2ad03`
`results/metrics/brier_decomposition.csv`	`01a78125...1fc3283e`

Table C.1. SHA-256 hashes for the headline reproducibility artifacts. Compute your own with `shasum -a 256 <filename>` (macOS) or `sha256sum <filename>` (Linux); only the leading and trailing bytes are printed here to fit the table width but the repository contains the full hashes alongside the artifacts.